

MALVIYA NAGAR FIRE, SAIDUAJAB INCIDENTS

CM gives ex-gratia to victims' families

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday handed over ex-gratia assistance to the families of people who died in the Malviya Nagar fire and Saiduajab building collapse incidents, saying the government is taking concrete steps to prevent such tragedies in future.

The chief minister also asserted that those responsible for the two incidents will not be spared under any circumstances.

Six persons, mostly medical students, died in May after a multi-storey building collapsed in South Delhi's Saidulajab area. In the Malviya Nagar fire tragedy earlier this month, 23 persons, mostly foreigners, died after the fire engulfed a building where a restaurant and hotel ran.

After meeting the affected families, the chief minister said, "No assistance can make up for the loss of a loved one, but in this hour of grief, the Delhi government stands firmly with you like a family."

She met them at the Delhi Secretariat and handed over ex-gratia assistance of ₹10 lakh each, said a Delhi CMO statement.

"As a mother, a daughter and a public servant, I could deeply understand the pain and suffering being endured



by the affected families," Gupta said and assured that those responsible for these tragedies would not be spared.

She also said that the government is taking concrete steps to ensure that such incidents do not recur in future. The chief minister handed over ex-gratia assistance to the families of those who lost their lives in the Saidulajab building collapse, including Ramesh Chandra, father of the late Ekta Chaudhary; Ram Prakash, father of the deceased Ravi Prakash Verma; Rajesh Kumar, father of deceased Kapil; Sanjay Kumar, father of the deceased Nalin; Satyavan Verma, father of the deceased Alok; and Jai Raj Ojha, husband of the deceased Parvati Ojha, the CMO said.

The chief minister also assisted the families affected by the Malviya Nagar

tragedy. They included Saroj Devi, wife of the deceased Ashok Kumar Goyal; Sachin Agarwal, on behalf of the deceased Kamla Agarwal, Jawari Lal Agarwal; and Ramesh Prasad, on behalf of the deceased, Shrutiika Barnwal, the statement said.

Family members who lost their loved ones in both incidents shared their grief with the chief minister in an emotional interaction. The affected families also raised concerns related to administrative arrangements and emergency response systems, stressing the need for more effective and concrete measures to prevent such incidents in the future, added the statement.

The chief minister said that the government is not viewing these incidents merely as accidents but as lessons that must strengthen public safety in the future.

Metro commuters set to get FASTag-enabled smart parking facilities

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Metro commuters are set to get FASTag-enabled smart parking facilities with dedicated parking spaces for persons with disabilities as part of efforts to promote seamless digital payments and improve accessibility, officials said on Monday.

The project, estimated to cost around ₹1.26 crore, will cover the design, development, operation and maintenance of smart parking systems at the two stations Jamia Millia Islamia and Jasola Vihar Shaheen Bagh stations

initially, an official said. According to project documents, parking payments will be accepted only through digital modes, including FASTag, UPI and National Common Mobility Card (NMC), debit cards, credit cards and e-wallets. Automatic boom barriers will regulate vehicle entry and exit at the parking facilities.

Under the proposed fee structure, car and SUV users will be charged ₹30 for parking up to six hours and ₹50 for up to 12 hours, while two-wheeler users will pay ₹15 and ₹25, respectively. Monthly passes have



also been proposed for regular users.

Reserved parking space will continue to be available free of cost for DMRC employees at both stations. Around 102.5 square metres of space

has been earmarked at Jamia Millia Islamia station and 170 square metres at Jasola Vihar Shaheen Bagh station for staff parking.

A senior DMRC official said the system is intended to

reduce waiting time at parking lots, encourage cashless transactions and streamline vehicle movement and added that digital payment infrastructure has become an important component of modern urban mobility systems.

Special emphasis has been placed on accessibility under the proposed arrangement. Dedicated parking spaces with appropriate signage will be earmarked for persons with disabilities and located near parking entrances, station access ramps or lifts to ensure easier access to Metro services, he said.

Sangli Apartment certified as Anupam Colony

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) on Monday certified Sangli Apartments in Lutyens' area as an 'Anupam Colony', becoming the eighth residential area to receive the recognition under the civic body's zero-waste and sustainability initiative.

NDMC Chairperson Keshav Chandra unveiled the plaque at the residential complex located on Copernicus Marg and said the colony had achieved the distinction through active participation of residents in waste segregation and sustainable waste management practices.

"Residents have adopted a system of segregating waste into multiple categories, including dry waste, wet



waste, sanitary waste, horticulture waste and e-waste, helping reduce waste at source and improve recycling and recovery efforts," Chandra said in a statement.

According to an official statement, Sangli Apartments has implemented 100 per cent segregation of waste at source, on-site composting of wet and horticulture waste, a Material Recovery Facility (MRF) for dry waste management, and a Reduce-Reuse-Recycle (RRR) centre along with a "Neki Ki Diwar" initiative to encourage reuse of items.

Two feared drowned in Bawana Canal, search operation continues

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Two 20-year-old youths are feared drowned in the Bawana canal after strong currents swept them away while bathing near Hanuman Mandir in outer Delhi's Bawana area on Sunday afternoon.

A massive search operation involving the Delhi Police, Fire Services and the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) continued until Monday evening.

The missing youths have been identified as Prashant Pandey and Satyam Kumar, both residents of Prem Nagar-II in Kirari Suleiman Nagar. According to police, information about two persons missing in the canal was received around 1.15 pm on Sunday.

A team from Bawana police station immediately reached the spot and launched a rescue operation with assistance from NDRF personnel and other emergency responders.

Investigators said Satyam



and Prashant had gone to the canal along with their friend Manish. The three friends had reportedly planned an outing and later reached the Bawana canal near Hanuman Mandir on Satyam's scooter after having lunch together at a nearby hotel.

During questioning, Manish told police that Satyam had called him earlier in the day and persuaded him to join them.

According to reports, while bathing, they ventured into deeper waters and were caught in the canal's current. Hearing their cries for help, people nearby threw a rope into the water.

Manish managed to grab hold of it and was pulled to safety, but Satyam and Prashant were swept away before they could be rescued.

Satyam is survived by his parents, elder brother Shivam and sister Monica. He worked as a broom supplier in the area. Prashant, who lived next door, is survived by his parents, younger brother and sister.

Police said continuous search efforts were underway, but both youths remained untraced. Authorities have appealed to residents to avoid entering canals and other water bodies.

NORTHERN RAILWAY
Tender Notice

Sr. Divisional Mechanical Engineer, Northern Railway, Trainset Depot, Shakurbasti; for and on behalf of President of India, invites IREPS (www.ireps.gov.in) for the under noted work.

Tender No.	2581031TSDSSB
Name of work	Operation and Maintenance of 03 Nos. RO plants at Hydrogen Plant Jind, including condition-based replacement of components for the period of two years (Manpower + Material)
Approximate Cost	Rs. 42,57,204.00/- including GST
Earnest Money	Rs. 85,200.00/-
Completion period of the work	24 Months
Date and Time for opening of tender	15.07.2026 at 15:00 hrs.
Website particulars notice board location complete details of tender can be seen	Above tender is available on IREPS site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in w.e.f. 22.06.2026, 12:56 hrs.
No: 25.8.1031.TSD.SSB Date: 22.06.2026	2136/2026
Serving Customers With A Smile	

**राष्ट्रीय फैशन प्रौद्योगिकी संस्थान**
(वस्त्र मंत्रालय भारत सरकार)
NATIONAL INSTITUTE OF FASHION TECHNOLOGY
(Ministry of Textiles, Govt. of India)
NIFT Campus Karwar, Jodhpur (Raj) 342037

ADVT. No. 15169/Establishment/Adhoc Faculty Recruitment/2025
अल्प-कालिक संविदा आधार पर भर्ती
Recruitment on Short Term Contract Basis

NIFT Jodhpur invites applications for the Post of 'Assistant Professor' (Group-A) on Short Term Contract for a period of Six months. Last date for submission of application on 14-07-2026 at 05:00 pm. The details are as below:

S. No.	Name of the Post	No. of Post
1	Assistant Professor	10

For detailed information regarding eligibility criteria, qualifications, and application process etc. and any addendum or/and corrigendum will be uploaded only on NIFT Jodhpur please visit our website www.nift.ac.in/jodhpur

निदेशक, निफ्ट जोधपुर
Director, NIFT Jodhpur

Notice is hereby given that my client, Mr. Virender Singh, is the owner of a plot measuring 90 sq. yds. (75.25 sq. mtrs.), forming part of Kharsa No. 95, situated at Village Bhengal Begumpur, Pargana and Tehsil Dadri, District Gautam Budh Nagar, Uttar Pradesh. He acquired the said property by virtue of a Gift Deed dated 09.04.2026, as Doc No. 2691, executed by his father, Mr. Samay Singh, Mr. Samay Singh inherited the said property upon the demise of his father, Mr. Gyan Chand, who expired on 10.02.1998. Mr. Gyan Chand had, also inherited the property after death of his father, Mr. Fire Ram. Mr. Fire Ram was the recorded owner of the property as per the revenue records. That my client is presently availing a loan facility from Saraswat Co-operative Bank Ltd. against the above-mentioned property. All persons having any claim against or in respect of the said Property, or any part thereof, by way of sale, exchange, mortgage (equitable/registered or otherwise), gift, trust, inheritance, family arrangement, maintenance, bequest, partnership, possession, lease, sublease, tenancy, license, lien, charge, pledge, easement or otherwise whatsoever, are hereby requested to notify the same in writing to us with supporting documentary evidence at the address mentioned below within 7 days from the date hereof, failing which the claim or claims, if any, of such person or persons will be considered to have been waived and/or abandoned.
Kamal Kant Gupta (Advocate)
Unit No. FF-2, First Floor, Mahalaxmi Metro Tower Sec-4, Vaisali, Gzb., U.P., Mob. 9810063351

NOTICE REGARDING LOST CERTIFICATE(S)
COMPANY NAME: L.G. BALAKRISHNAN & BROS LIMITED
ADDRESS: 6/16/13, Krishnarayapuram Road, Ganapathy, Coimbatore - 641006, Tamil Nadu, India

I/We, Mergender Pal Singh Jauhar residing at EB- 13 DDA SFS Flats Maya Puri, New Delhi 110064, the registered holder(s) of the under mentioned shares held in the above said company, hereby give notice that the share certificate(s) in respect of the said shares have been lost and I have applied to the Company for issue of duplicate certificate(s).

Further, the said shares have been transferred to IEPF Authority, as the dividend amount remained unpaid.

Any person having any objection/claim in respect of the said shares should lodge such claims with the Company at its above referred address within 15 days from this date, else the Company will endorse to the IEPF Authority for releasing the said shares from their demat a/c to my/our demat account, without insisting for production of the original share certificates.

Folio No.	Certificate No.	Distinctive Nos.	No. of Shares
J0000253	585	438392-438491	100

DATE: 23.06.2026
PLACE: Delhi

Mergender Pal Singh Jauhar
NAME OF SHAREHOLDER

The Pioneer Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Nisha Sharma D/o Sh. Munendra Kumar Bharardwaj R/o H.No. 25 A, Ground Floor, Street NO. 3, South Ganesh Nagar, Shakarpur, Delhi-110092. I hereby declare that I have changed my name from Km Nisha Bhardwaj to Nisha Sharma and both are one and the same person

PD(1435)C I, Faheem Ahmad, Father of- No.16016647A Hav Shamshad, R/o- VPO- Ghatampur, Dist- Kanpur, U.P.- 209206, have changed my name from Faheem Ahmad to Fahim Ahmad, vide affidavit dated 22/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1440)C I, Rukhsana Begam, Mother of- No.16016647A Hav Shamshad, R/o- VPO- Ghatampur, Dist- Kanpur, U.P.- 209206, have changed my name from Rukhsana Begam to Rukhsana, vide affidavit dated 22/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1441)C

I, No.14676962L NK Managule Basavaraj Kallappa, R/o- Vill/PO- Badole Bk, Teh- Akkalkot, Dist- Solapur, Maharashtra- 413218, have changed my son's name from Yashraj Basavraj Mangule to Yashraj Basavaraj Mangule, vide affidavit dated 22/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1442)C I, Smt Sarita Kumari Yadav, W/o- No.6501158H Nk/ASH Surendra Kumar Yadav, R/o- Vill- Phulkahi, PO- Mahthur Khurd, P.S- Phulparas, Dist- Madhubani, Bihar- 847409 have changed my name from Smt Sarita Kumari Yadav to Shakshi Suman, vide affidavit dated 22/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1443)C I, Dolly Koch, W/o JC- 773305P Nb/Sub Karuna Koch, R/o- Vill- Udmari, PO- Balipara, P.S- Charidwar, Teh- Tezpur, Dist- Sonitpur, Assam- 784101, have changed my name from Dolly Koch to Dolly Borah Koch, vide affidavit dated 22/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1444)C

I, K Akash S/o JC-282228K Sub (GNR) Kuppam Venkata Ramana, R/o- 351, Govindapalle, Sirivella Mandal, Kurnool, A.P- 518502, have changed my name from K Akash to Kuppam Akash, vide affidavit dated 22/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1445)C I, K Uday Kiran S/o JC- 282228K Sub (GNR) Kuppam Venkata Ramana, R/o- 351, Govindapalle, Sirivella Mandal, Kurnool, A.P- 518502, have changed my name from K Uday Kiran to Kuppam Uday Kiran, vide affidavit dated 22/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1446)C I, TJ Radhika, W/o JC- 282228K Sub (GNR) Kuppam Venkata Ramana, R/o- 351, Govindapalle, Sirivella Mandal, Kurnool, A.P- 518502, have changed my name from T J Radhika to Kuppam Radhika, vide affidavit dated 22/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1447)C I, Rajesh Kumar, Father of- No.16029645N Nk Sangeet Kumar, R/o- Vill & PO- Nayasara, Teh & Dist- Junjunu, Rajasthan- 333001, have changed my name from Rajesh Kumar to Rajesh, vide affidavit dated 22/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1448)C

PUBLIC NOTICE

General Public at large is hereby informed that Home Dexters India Pvt. Ltd., a company incorporated under the Companies Act, 2013, having its registered office at Plot No. 2, E-1.1, Sector-82, Gurugram-122004, Haryana are proceeding to sell following TDR certificates to our client:-

i. TDR Certificate bearing Nos. 01-920 of 42/2026 out of a total of 1038 certificates, carrying a face value of 50 Sq. Mtr. each with an FAR of 2.0, all dated 22.05.2026 out of 01-1038 of 42/2026 dated 22.05.2026 granted against land bearing Rect. No. 10, Killa No. 11(1-6-6), 20/2/1 (2-16-1), 11 (6-1-3), 20/2/1 (0-1-2) situated in village Dhaumanspur, Sub-Tehsil Badshahpur, District Gurugram. The entire TDR Certificates (01-1038 of 42/2026 dated 22.05.2026) were transferred vide Transfer No. 31 of 2026 (Memo No. TDR-T5(TDRA-440A)/TDR440A/CTP/20874/2026 dated 12.06.2026) by the Department of Town & Country Planning, Government of Haryana from Sh. Pardeep Vig to Home Dexters India Pvt. Ltd.

In case any person, Company, Firm, Bank, Financial Institution, statutory authority, Society and/or any other entity have got any interest, claim, demand, right or title of any nature pertaining to the above mentioned TDR Certificates or land parcels against which the same have been issued or any part thereof including but not limited to by way of sale, exchange, Will, treaty, gift, lease/tenancy, licence, assignment, mortgage, hypothecation, charge, lien, encumbrance, trust, family settlement/arrangement, inheritance, bequest, easement, exchange, possession, maintenance, development rights, joint venture, partnership, order/decreed/judgment of any court, MOU or through any other document with respect to the ownership rights and possession of the aforesaid owner in respect of the same, in that event the same be intimated in writing to us by Speed Post at the address indicated hereinafter or by way of email along with supporting documents within a period of 10 days from the date of publication of this notice failing which our client shall presume that the Said TDR Certificates and land parcels against which the same have been issued are free from all encumbrances/charges/third party claims and shall proceed to transact on the same from the Owner indicated above. In case no claim is lodged within the period stipulated above, the same shall be presumed to be willful waiver of the claim which might be held by any person/third party in respect of the Said TDR Certificates and land parcels against which the same have been issued.

Jagmohan Krishan Dang & Ishaan Dang
Advocates
R/o K-140, South City-I, Gurugram- 122001(HR).
Email: mailbox@ishaandang.com
Mob. 9871011115

Barapullah Phase-III nears completion after final slab casting

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The final deck slab of the Barapullah Phase-III elevated corridor was successfully cast on Monday evening. The corridor physically connects both ends of the structure across the Yamuna River, bringing one of Delhi's most delayed infrastructure projects to the threshold of completion. The project was finally completed eleven years after work began in 2015 and nine years after its original 2017 completion deadline.

The casting involved approximately 175 cubic

metres of concrete, taking the project's cumulative concrete use to nearly 4.5 lakh cubic metres. With the final slab in place, the two sides of the Yamuna are now structurally connected through the corridor, a milestone many had come to doubt would ever arrive.

PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh visited the site to mark the occasion and shared dinner with workers, engineers, and staff members who have spent years on the project. He said the moment was about far more than an engineering milestone.

"Today is not just about concrete and steel. Today is

about completing a promise that Delhi had been waiting for over a decade. This final slab represents the determination of hundreds of workers and engineers who refused to let this project remain unfinished," Singh said.

The minister said that after the current government assumed office, Barapullah Phase-III was identified as a priority project and has been continuously monitored at the highest level. He said he personally visited the site multiple times, reviewed progress regularly, and worked with officials to clear bottlenecks.



"For years, Delhiites saw deadlines come and go. After our government came to power, we decided that this project could not be allowed to remain stuck any longer," he said.

Barapullah Phase-III was approved in 2014, and work began in 2015, with an origi-

nal completion target of 2017. What followed was a protracted series of setbacks: a seven-year land acquisition dispute, environmental clearances, technical challenges associated with building a major elevated structure across the Yamuna floodplain, and prolonged administrative hurdles.

The project's revised cost now stands at approximately ₹1,635 crore, a significant increase from the original estimate driven by the years of delay, escalating material costs, and scope revisions forced by the various obstacles encountered along the way.

Despite the extended history of missed deadlines, the project saw accelerated progress over the past year and a half through continuous monitoring, regular inspections, and coordinated action by multiple agencies, culminating in Monday's casting of the final slab.

Once operational, the Barapullah Phase-III corridor is expected to meaningfully improve connectivity between East and South Delhi. Commuters travelling from Mayur Vihar and adjoining areas toward Sarai Kale Khan, AIIMS, and South Delhi will benefit from largely signal-free movement, reduc-

ing travel time significantly and easing congestion at major bottlenecks, including NH-24, the DND Flyway, Ring Road, and Sarai Kale Khan interchange.

As the sun set over the Yamuna on Monday, workers who had spent years on the structure sat down with the minister for dinner at the project site.

For the workers, it was a rare moment of recognition for years of labour on a project that, for most of its life, was better known as a symbol of what Delhi's infrastructure ambitions struggle to deliver than as something nearing completion.

Govt brings 23 new services under Time-bound Delivery Act

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has brought 23 new services under the Delhi Right of Citizens to Time-Bound Delivery of Services Act, 2011. The services covering licences, NOCs, registrations, and approvals across departments, including Labour, Tourism, Jal Board, Energy, Excise, Forest, and RERA, with timelines ranging from a single working day to 60 days, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta announced on Monday. Currently, the Act covers time-bound delivery of 561 services delivered by various departments of the Delhi government.

Monday's announcement adds 23 more services to this existing list, expanding its coverage to newer categories of licences and approvals that did not previously carry mandatory delivery timelines.

The Chief Minister said the decision will directly benefit ordinary citizens as well as businesses in industry, trade, hospitality,



tourism, construction, and the service sector by ensuring approvals. The registrations are delivered within defined, legally enforceable timelines, reducing unnecessary delays and the need for repeated visits to government offices.

Among the most notable timelines, registration under the Shops and Establishments Act will now be completed within a single day. Approval for the storage of construction material by local bodies will also be issued within one day. These two are among the fastest under the new framework.

Factory plan approvals by the Labour Department will be granted within 15 days. The Delhi Jal Board will

provide sewerage connections within 15 days. Film shooting permissions from the Delhi Tourism and Transportation Development Corporation will be issued within 15 days. The Delhi Pollution Control Committee will issue authorisations related to the collection, storage, transportation, and recycling of battery waste under the Battery Waste Management Rules within 15 days.

The Agriculture Department will complete processes related to pesticide control operation licences, sales registrations, and seed licences within 21 days each. Permission for the installation of mobile towers will be provided within 30 days. Bar licences under the

Excise Department will be issued within 30 days. Registration of builders and real estate agents under RERA will be completed within 30 days each. Brand and label registrations under both IMFL and FL categories handled by the Excise Department will be completed within 42 days. Registration of weighing and measuring instruments under Legal Metrology will be completed within 45 days. Road cutting permissions and associated works under the Public Works Department will be granted within 45 days.

Approvals for operating amusement parks and registration of water sports and adventure sports operators under municipal services will be issued within 60 days. NOCs from local bodies required for state licences for food businesses will also come within 60 days. Hotel registration or operational permissions and slaughterhouse licences will be granted within 60 days. Applications related to electricity meters and connection agreements

under the Energy Department will be processed within 60 days. The Forest and Wildlife Department will decide applications for tree felling permission under the Delhi Preservation of Trees Act within 60 days.

The Chief Minister said the time-bound delivery mechanism is intended to do two things simultaneously: strengthen citizens' rights by making the government's obligations explicit and enforceable, and make the government machinery more accountable by attaching consequences to delay.

It is worth noting that since the announcement of the existing approximately 500 services under the Right of Citizens to Time-Bound Delivery scheme over the years, no formal public complaint has been recorded against the mechanism so far, a fact that the government has not highlighted prominently, but which broadly suggests the framework has operated without generating significant friction at the citizen interface.

HC refuses to interfere in proposed CAG audit of BSES discoms

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Monday refused to interfere with the Delhi government's proposal to entrust the audit of BSES Rajdhani Power Ltd and BSES Yamuna Power Ltd to the Comptroller and Auditor General of India (CAG).

A vacation bench of Justice Tejas Karia dismissed a petition by the power distribution companies, stating that their challenge was premature at this stage. Welcoming the Delhi High Court's order, Power Minister Ashish Sood stated that the judgment has completely unmasked the failures and hidden motives of Arvind Kejriwal and his administration.

"The judgement has exposed the deep rooted 'nexus' of the previous AAP regime with the private electricity distribution companies (discoms) to deliberately evade financial accountability and fleece the residents," he said.

"Our government has



always maintained that there was collusion—a nexus—between the electricity companies, the Aam Aadmi Party, and Arvind Kejriwal," Minister Sood said. "In 2015, using a particular judgment as an excuse, it was falsely claimed that conducting a CAG audit of the discoms was not allowed. Arvind Kejriwal and his government simply sat back and did nothing."

The Minister highlighted that the stiff resistance from the power companies against the audit was proof enough of an underlying conspiracy.

Sood criticised the previous regime for leaving behind a massive financial strain on the public without any justifi-

cation. "No deficit is visible anywhere, nor is there any apparent lack of funds with the companies, yet Arvind Kejriwal and the Aam Aadmi Party government walked away after placing a burden of ₹38,000 crores on the people of Delhi," he noted.

Pointing to the High Court's observations, the Power Minister added that the legal clarity has exposed the previous government's deception. "The High Court stating that the 2015 judgment contained no restrictions whatsoever against conducting a CAG audit shows in itself that Arvind Kejriwal and the AAP government were absolute failures."

Man, two daughters injured after falling from Geeta Colony Flyover in Shahdara

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A man and his two minor daughters were injured after they fell more than 20 feet from the Geeta Colony flyover in east Delhi's Shahdara on Monday afternoon while travelling on a motorcycle, police said. One of the girls sustained critical injuries, while her father and sister are said to be stable.

According to preliminary information, the accident took place on the loop of the Geeta Colony flyover near Geeta Colony Police Station at 1.45 pm.

The man, identified as Ashish (35), was travelling from Sonia Vihar towards Daryaganj on a motorcycle with his daughters, Rubi (12) and Mansi (11), when the incident occurred, a senior police officer said.

Police said Ashish was heading towards Rajghat via Gandhi Nagar and had



entered the flyover loop when he allegedly lost control of the motorcycle at a sharp turn.

The three reportedly plunged from the flyover under circumstances that are yet to be ascertained. While Ashish and Rubi are believed to have fallen after getting entangled in a tree below, Mansi landed directly on the road, sustaining severe injuries, police sources said.

Passersby rushed to the spot and helped shift the injured to a nearby hospital before police personnel arrived.

"I immediately ran towards the site. There were three people on a motorcycle. They appeared to have lost balance and fallen from the structure. We helped shift them to the hospital," one of the eye-witnesses, Gulfam, told PTI.

Another eyewitness said he was standing near the flyover when he heard a loud thud and rushed to the spot.

"I saw a young girl and her father lying on the road below. We informed the police and tried to help them until emergency services arrived," he said.

Police said the victims were

initially taken to Chacha Nehru Hospital and later referred for specialised treatment. Mansi was subsequently shifted to Guru Teg Bahadur (GTB) Hospital due to the seriousness of her injuries.

According to hospital sources, the girl suffered severe head injuries and a fracture in one of her legs. Her condition remained critical, and she was undergoing treatment under close medical supervision. Ashish and Rubi are out of danger, police said.

In a statement, police said they received information regarding the accident at around 1.45 pm.

"Information regarding a road accident on the Geeta Colony Flyover near the CNG Pump was received from Chacha Nehru Hospital. A police team immediately rushed to the spot and subsequently reached the hospital," the officer in the statement said.

Government promotes 200 DASS cadre officers to Group A posts

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Fulfilling a long-pending demand of its DASS cadre employees, the Delhi Government has promoted 200 of them to the Group-A officer posts, officials said on Monday.

The Services Department, in a communication to the secretaries and heads of various departments of the Delhi Government, released the list of 200 Grade-I DASS officers promoted and appointed to the Senior Scale (GNCTDSS) Group 'A' posts.

The Union Public Service Commission (UPSC) previously conveyed its recommendation for formation of a departmental promotion committee (DPC) for promotion of Grade-I DASS officers.

Also, in November 2023, the then LG of Delhi, VK Saxena, approved the first restructuring of the Government of National



Capital Territory of Delhi Subordinate Services (GNCTDSS) cadre, paving the way for the promotion of Group "C" and "B" employees to Group "A" officers.

A Delhi Administration Subordinate Services (DASS) officer said that the cadre officers who were stagnating on their present posts for many years have finally got what was long pending and due to them.

The creation of the Group-A posts for Grade-I DASS officers was aggressively contested by the Delhi, Andaman and Nicobar, Lakshadweep, Daman and Diu and Dadra and Nagar

Haveli (Civil Services) Officers Association for years.

The case was fought in the Central Administrative Tribunal (CAT), Delhi High Court and the Supreme Court, but finally the DASS cadre tasted victory, he added. The DASS cadre employees enter service as Group C employees in the Delhi government. The cadre complained about years of stagnation without any chances of promotion to higher posts.

The cadre was constituted in 1967, without restructuring for more than five decades, till the Delhi LG approved it in 2023.

Govt notifies SOP for tree offences

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has notified a Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) for dealing with tree-related offences, directing that inquiries into complaints be completed preferably within two months of their receipt.

The SOP, issued by the Forest and Wildlife Department under the Delhi Preservation of Trees Act, 1994, provides for round-the-clock forest control rooms and division control rooms, quick response teams (QRTs), dedicated legal cells and prosecution cells, and a complaint-tracking website to strengthen enforcement against tree-related violations.

Complaints can be lodged through the Green Helpline, a dedicated website, in the written format and on government mobile applications. Upon receiving information, officials will register a First Offence Report (FOR)



and transmit details in real time to the Forest Control Room, the Division Control Room, beat officers and the land-owning agency concerned for immediate action.

Under the SOP, QRTs will be tasked with reaching sites of reported violations, stopping ongoing offences, maintaining status quo and collecting evidence.

Team members have been directed to take geo-referenced photographs and videos, record details of suspects and document tools, equipment and vehicles allegedly used in the commission of offences.

Forest officials have also been empowered to issue restraining orders where there is a likelihood of illegal felling or damage to trees, inform land-owning agencies and police authorities, and seek seizure of tools, vehicles and tree material involved in offences. Violations of such orders can be referred to police for legal action.

Tree officers have been directed to gather evidence, including CCTV footage and eyewitness accounts, issue notices to alleged offenders and conduct hearings in accordance with the principles of natural justice.

Waterholes sustain wildlife in Asola Bhatti Sanctuary

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Thirty kilometres from Connaught Place, past the city's southern sprawl, a stretch of the Aravallis is quietly being given back to what it once was. Camera traps have caught leopards padding through the dark. Striped hyenas have been photographed at dusk. Spotted deer move between the trees. And across the Asola Bhatti Wildlife Sanctuary, 218 waterholes, built by the Delhi government and regularly replenished with potable water, make sure that none of these animals go thirsty when the summer drains everything else dry.

The eco-restoration programme underway at Asola Bhatti, run by the Department of Forests and Wildlife of the Government of NCT of Delhi, is among the more ambitious ecological projects in the capital's recent history. More than 10



lakh native trees are being planted across the Southern Ridge as part of Delhi's Aravalli eco-restoration effort. Bharat Nursery, the department's principal nursery located within the sanctuary itself, is currently growing nearly 6 lakh saplings of native species. These are being used for afforestation, habitat restoration, urban greening, and free distribution to citizens.

The plantation programme is specifically focused on native and ridge-specific species rather than

fast-growing ornamental or exotic trees. Species selection is based on ecological suitability, with an emphasis on creating self-sustaining forest habitats in areas previously degraded by mining activity.

Environment, Forest, and Wildlife Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa said the vision goes well beyond planting trees. "The Asola Bhatti Wildlife Sanctuary is one of Delhi's most valuable ecological assets and a critical part of the Aravalli ecosystem. Our vision is not merely to plant trees but to scientific-

ly restore degraded landscapes into self-sustaining forest ecosystems that support wildlife, improve air quality, and strengthen Delhi's environment," he said.

On the waterhole network, Sirsa said access to water during summer is fundamental to wildlife survival. "The development of waterholes across the sanctuary is a significant intervention that is helping improve habitat quality and supporting wildlife conservation in a meaningful way," he said.

The 218 waterholes have been placed strategically along wildlife movement corridors. Beyond the leopard and hyena, camera traps and field observations have recorded porcupines, reptiles, and a wide variety of bird species across the sanctuary. Birdwatching trails and conservation measures around natural water bodies are also being actively maintained.

While redesigning the roads, other aspects will also be kept in mind, including essential services such as stormwater drainage, street lighting, signal poles and utility ducts for telecom and electrical systems, officials said.

IN FOCUS



People gather at a snow site at Baralacha Pass in Lahaul and Spiti district, Himachal Pradesh on Monday

PTI

Budget of development and legacy, covers every segment: Bengl CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

Describing the first BJP government's maiden budget in West Bengal as that of development and legacy, Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari on Monday said it covers every segment from law and order to employment generation. He said that an over ₹4.38 lakh crore budget proposal has been placed in the West Bengal Assembly during the day, despite a funds crunch and debt burden.

"This is a budget of 'vikas and virasat' (development and legacy)," Adhikari told a press conference, flanked by Finance Minister Swapan Dasgupta, following presentation of the budget proposals for 2026-27.



West Bengal CM Suwendu Adhikari addresses a press conference after the presentation of the first Budget of the BJP government in the West Bengal Legislative Assembly in Kolkata on Monday

PTI

He said that the BJP government has only been able to present a budget for the remaining eight months of the fiscal, with the previous Mamata Banerjee dispensation earlier presenting a vote on

account for the first four months of 2026-27 following the April assembly polls. "I welcome the budget placed by Finance Minister Swapan Dasgupta. The way an inclusive budget has been placed within a short time

after our government took over just one and a half months ago is commendable," the CM said.

He said steps have been taken to ensure the security of the state's citizens, including the recruitment of 20,000 police personnel and the introduction of the 112 helpline and related services to maintain law and order.

"Special importance has been given to infrastructure development, industry and the agricultural sector," he said. Stating that one lakh new government jobs will be given this fiscal, the chief minister asserted that no political person will be part of the appointment committees for these to ensure transparency in the recruitment process.

Delhi influencer alleges rape, forced religious conversion bid, FIR registered

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police registered an FIR and launched an investigation after a 36-year-old social media influencer from North Delhi's Burari area accused a man of raping her and pressuring her to convert to Islam.

According to the complaint, the woman, who lives in Burari with her husband and 15-year-old daughter, approached police headquarters on May 11, alleging that the accused had sexually assaulted her and later subjected her to sustained pressure to change her religion.

The complainant told police that she creates social media content and uploads videos from her home. She alleged that in 2022, she came into contact with a man identified as Sunny through Instagram, and the acquaintance later led to regular interaction and, she alleged, sexual assault.

In her complaint, the woman further alleged that after the incident, the accused, along with his brother and brother-in-law, pressured her and her family to convert to Islam. She claimed that in 2023, three men identified as Shakib, Usman and Afroz repeatedly urged both her and her daughter to embrace Islam.



The complainant also alleged that the accused persons demanded a substantial amount of money in connection with the proposed religious conversion. North Delhi Deputy Commissioner of Police Raja Banthia confirmed that an FIR has been lodged and said further investigation is underway. Investigators are examining the claims and collecting evidence to ascertain the sequence of events and the role of the accused persons.

The Pioneer has learnt that the angle of religious conversion remains contentious, and Delhi Police officials have yet to independently confirm it. No arrests had been announced by the time this report was filed. Police said further action would be taken based on the findings of the ongoing investigation.

Ladakh LG lays foundation stone for 2 high-altitude flower fields in Leh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Leh

Ladakh Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena on Monday laid the foundation stone for two high-altitude flower fields in Leh as a major initiative aimed at diversifying the Union Territory's biodiversity, enhancing farmers' incomes and creating new livelihood opportunities through floriculture.

The two flower fields at Choglamsar and Stakna in

Leh will be the first such high-altitude projects in the country, a spokesperson of Lok Bhavan said.

He said the Choglamsar Park is spread over an area of 92,687 square metres, and the Floriculture Project at the School of Agriculture Science and Technology, University of Ladakh, Stakna, is spread over 1.02 lakh square metres of land. The Flower Garden at Choglamsar is being developed as one of the largest organised high-altitude floriculture parks in the country and is the first project of its kind in Ladakh. The project assumes special significance as the idea originated during the LG's visit to the site on April 7, when he had directed that the area be developed as a dedicated floriculture park, the spokesperson said.

He said the Choglamsar flower park will serve as a demonstration and model floriculture centre where high-value flowers such as

Lilium, Gladiolus, Tulips and other ornamental species, with strong market demand in national and international markets, will be cultivated. The garden will also function as a recreational and educational space for residents and tourists alike, the spokesperson said.

Under the project, for the first time, farmers will be trained in floriculture and later on, these fields will be handed over to them for commercial utilisation



Vinai Kumar Saxena

through the cooperatives. The floriculture project at Stakna has been conceived as a livelihood-generation and economic-diversification initiative. The project aims to establish a model floriculture centre for promoting scientific flower cultivation in Ladakh and will focus on producing premium-quality cut flowers for marketing in metropolitan cities and other markets across the country, the spokesperson said.

through the cooperatives.

The floriculture project at Stakna has been conceived as a livelihood-generation and economic-diversification initiative.

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change the tone in the evening and try to appease them. There seems to be some problem with them," Shinde said.

Amid the crisis, Uddhav Thackeray met his MLAs to draft a strategy to corner the Mahayuti government during the ongoing monsoon session of the Maharashtra legislature. The meeting, held at the party's 'Shivalay' office on the first day of the monsoon session, took place even as six MPs defected to the rival Shinde-led faction just 500 meters away at the Yashwantrao Chavan Pratishthan.

12 Indians killed in Qatar factory explosion

According to operator QatarEnergy, an "operational incident" occurred during the start-up of operations at the Barzan local gas supply centre within Ras Laffan Industrial City on Sunday evening, triggering an explosion and subsequent fire. The Energy Ministry confirmed the casualties in a statement, reporting 13 fatalities and 66 injuries. Authorities said the facility's export operations remain unaffected and that there is no environmental risk resulting from the incident.

QatarEnergy did not disclose the exact location of the explosion within the complex or provide details regarding the extent of the damage. However, Saad Al Kaabi, Qatar's Energy Minister and Chief Executive Officer of QatarEnergy, said an investigation had been launched to determine the cause of the incident.

The blast was powerful enough to rattle windows and was reportedly felt across central Doha, causing alarm among residents more than 70 kilometres away from Ras Laffan.

Ras Laffan is home to the world's largest LNG processing complex and plays a critical role in global energy markets, supplying approximately one-fifth of the world's liquefied natural gas. The facility was previously targeted during Iranian missile strikes in March, which caused significant damage to parts of the complex.

Reacting to the tragedy, the Embassy of India in Doha expressed deep concern over the incident and extended solidarity with Qatar.

"At this challenging and difficult time, the Embassy of India and the entire Indian community in Qatar stand in solidarity with the Government and people of Qatar," the mission said in a statement. The embassy wished a speedy recovery to those injured and expressed hope for the safety of those reported missing by authorities. The embassy urged Indian nationals seeking information or assistance to contact its emergency helpline numbers at +974-55647502 or +974-55384683, or email cons.doha@mea.gov.in.

Further details are expected as authorities continue their investigation into one of the deadliest industrial accidents in Qatar's recent history.

BJP woos Bengal with welfare push in first...

The Budget sought to reassure beneficiaries that welfare programmes would continue despite the change in Government, even as the BJP moved to put its own stamp on several flagship schemes. ₹36,000 crore was earmarked for the Annapurna Yojana, the BJP Government's replacement project for the TMC-era Lakshmi Bhandar scheme. Under the programme, women between 25 and 60 years of age will receive direct financial assistance in their bank accounts.

The Women and Child Development and Social Welfare Department saw the highest allocation of ₹52,308 crore. The Panchayats and Rural Development Department received ₹51,836.55 crore, while School Education got ₹44,948.21 crore.

Lucknow building blaze engulfs 15...

People were being taken out during the rescue operation, with some bodies being carried in body bags and others wrapped in blankets. Visuals from the scene also showed some people rappelling down the wires to escape the blaze. Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath cut short his visit to Aligarh and reached the site to review the situation. He later visited the injured at the hospital. Deputy Chief Minister Brajesh Pathak, who had reached the spot as the rescue operation was underway, said a high-level inquiry had been ordered into the incident to ascertain the cause of the fire and determine how it occurred. "Strict action will be taken so that such incidents do not happen in future," he said.

He said that the children had come during summer holidays to learn animation at the centre. "The fire broke out suddenly. It was an animation centre. While there is no immediate clarity about the sequence of events, it seems that the children ran towards the back side when the fire broke out, but they couldn't survive," he said.

With tears welling in his eyes, the deputy chief minister said he had seen 14 bodies at the spot. "They were our children. It is a very tragic incident," he said. PM Modi announced an ex-gratia of ₹2 lakh from PMNRF to the next of kin of each deceased. The injured would be given ₹50,000.

The UP CM also declared an ex-gratia assistance of ₹5 lakh each for the families of those who died in the fire and ₹50,000 each for the injured.

Firefighters and National Disaster Response Force personnel were conducting a room-to-room search inside the premises till late in the evening. Senior officials, including Principal Secretary (Home) Sanjay Prasad, Director General of Police Rajeev Krishna and Lucknow Police Commissioner Amrendra Sengar, also reached the spot to monitor the rescue operation.

Outside the building, scenes of anguish and helplessness unfolded as parents and relatives rushed to the spot after receiving distress calls from those trapped. Distraught men and women, apparently guardians and relatives of the victims, were seen standing near the site and urging authorities to allow them to enter the building when the firefighting and rescue operations were underway.

"*Mujhe jaane do apne bete ke paas* (Let me go to my son)," one distraught woman cried repeatedly, pleading with officials as rescue operations continued. Eyewitnesses said many tried to break the building's glass panes to allow thick smoke to escape and create possible routes for those trapped inside. One of the most harrowing moments was captured in visuals showing a student jumping from an upper floor to escape the flames. People below quickly spread a mattress-like object to cushion the fall, following which locals immediately moved the student away from the area and arranged medical assistance.

Some locals were seen rescuing cats from the pet clinic on the ground floor. People living near the affected structure supplied water bottles to firefighters engaged in the rescue operation.

As the rescue operation ended, the tragedy moved from the fire site to the hospitals and mortuary, where families reached to identify their loved ones after their post-mortem.

The bodies of the victims were shifted from the trauma centre at KGMU to the post-mortem house for identification and autopsy procedures. Most of those who lost their lives were young adults, KGMU PRO K K Singh said.

Those deceased were identified as Sagar, Nilesh, Anamika, Sanyam, Anuchha, Sukhmani, Aditya Srivastava, Jyoti, Bhavishya, Abdul Rehman, Suraj Bhaat, Sehjan, Jaynil Chakraborty, Mohammad Ammar and Sumalya, according to a list issued by the hospital.

SIT flags lapses in cash handling in Ram Mandir

Counting staff often worked in their regular clothes rather than the uniforms provided to them. Controls were weak as funds moved from the donation boxes to the counting hall and then to sealed bank deposits.

These gaps may have allowed money to be diverted. For example, Anukul Mishra, who is connected to the trust, helped his brother-in-law, Lavkush Mishra, get a cash-counting job. This indicates the risk of favouritism and weak independent checks.

Surveillance was meant to safeguard cash handling, but the SIT found employees blocked the cameras during cash handling. Investigators reviewed extensive footage and identified these instances. There are strong signs that recordings in the cash-counting area were tampered with, including possible deletions or changes. This made it difficult to understand what happened fully. Older CCTV footage was also limited, with only about 45 days readily available in some reports, making it harder to examine longer-term trends.

The SIT is also looking into the increase in donations during the busy Maha Kumbh period in January and February 2025. It is reviewing how the trust bought land and materials. Other areas are being checked for similar problems, such as weak controls or irregularities. Cash handling was given to outside staff with weak checks. CCTV cameras were installed, but they could be tampered with and were not always monitored. Hiring often depended on personal connections instead of strict checks. The total financial impact remains unclear, as public claims cite different amounts. The SIT has recommended major changes: use only regular bank staff for counting, make hiring more transparent, improve CCTV rules and storage practices, hold regular independent audits, and increase supervision, possibly with additional professional or government oversight. These steps aim to prevent similar lapses and strengthen accountability at the trust.

The SIT is still working on the case and giving updates to the Chief Minister's Office. Its early findings show how a major religious site can fail without strict and independent enforcement.

Six tigers are here: Eknath Shinde

The meeting was attended by only three Lok Sabha MPs of the Opposition party.

These rebel parliamentarians had won against the BJP and Shiv Sena candidates in the 2024 general elections. The Shiv Sena (UBT) had bagged nine Lok Sabha seats in Maharashtra in 2024. The entry of the dissident MPs in the Shiv Sena is expected to give a boost to the bargaining power of Shinde in the ruling coalition Mahayuti, which also consists of the BJP and the NCP.

"I did it earlier (split Shiv Sena) to save the principles of late Balasaheb Thackeray and to save the Shiv Sena. Now, this move (rebellion in the Lok Sabha wing of the Sena UBT) is the second stage of Shiv Sena expansion," Shinde asserted. All of them will contest on the Shiv Sena symbol in the 2029 Lok Sabha polls from their respective constituencies and will get elected for sure, he said while responding to a question.

Without taking names of Shiv Sena (UBT) leaders, Shinde advised them to introspect instead of resorting to abuses, an oblique reference to Thackeray aide and Rajya Sabha MP Sanjay Raut, who launched an expletive-laden tirade against the rebels last week. "It is time for introspection for those whose party these MPs have left. They start abusing in the morning, and

Centre to set up vehicle repair hubs across highways

RAJESH KUMAR ■ New Delhi

Car drivers travelling with families need not worry any longer about getting stranded after their vehicles break down on highways. The Centre is soon setting up repair hubs at designated zones. The move comes amid growing traffic volumes on national highways and expressways, where a lack of nearby repair facilities often leaves motorists stranded for extended periods following tyre punctures or mechanical failures. The move is aimed at improving roadside assistance for motorists and freight operators travelling across the country's highway network. The National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) has directed operators of wayside

amenities (WSAs) along national highways and expressways to prioritise the establishment of vehicle repair shops and puncture repair facilities. The move is aimed at improving roadside assistance for motorists and freight operators travelling across the country's highway network. The NHAI said it has been observed that a larger number of vehicles and puncture repair services are required on several National Highways and Expressways, which will enable highway users to avail themselves of timely mechanical assistance during breakdowns and emergencies, avoiding inconvenience, delays, and potential safety concerns. For highway users, a tyre



puncture or minor mechanical issue often means searching for assistance in unfamiliar areas, particularly on newly developed expressways. Greater availability of repair facilities at designated highway amenities could help reduce waiting times and improve safety for both

private vehicle owners and commercial fleet operators. The move is aimed at improving the overall National Highway travel experience, reducing vehicle downtime, enhancing road safety and ensuring prompt assistance to commuters as well as freight operators trav-

elling on the National Highway corridors. NHML is currently developing a network of modern wayside amenities across the country under the public-private partnership (PPP) model. These facilities are being built on a long-term lease basis and are designed to serve both passenger vehicle (PV) users and commercial transport operators. Under existing concession agreements, operators of wayside amenities are already permitted to establish vehicle repair shops and puncture repair facilities in addition to mandatory services. NHAI has now asked its field offices to encourage lessees to develop these facilities at the earliest. Vehicle Repair Shops and Puncture Repair Facilities are among

the approved permissible facilities under the contractual framework. The authority said the repair and assistance services will complement its broader objective of creating user-centric highway infrastructure and providing seamless mobility services to road users. These WSAs are envisioned as integrated service hubs that provide essential amenities to commuters and commercial vehicle operators on National Highways and Expressways. Development of such facilities will complement the broader objective of creating world-class National Highway infrastructure and delivering seamless mobility services to National Highway users.

States Focus



CONGRESS MP NEERAJ DANGI TAKES OATH AS RS MEMBER

Rajya Sabha Chairman CP Radhakrishnan on Monday administered the oath to Congress member Neeraj Dangi, who has been re-elected to the Upper House from Rajasthan. Dangi took the oath in Hindi. Dangi was elected for the first time as a member of the Rajya Sabha from Rajasthan in June 2020. "Vice President and Chairman, Rajya Sabha, CP Radhakrishnan administered the oath to Shri Neeraj Dangi, Member of the Rajya Sabha, re-elected from Rajasthan, at Parliament House today," the Vice President said on social media while sharing pictures of the oath-taking. Rajya Sabha deputy chairperson Harivansh, leader of the house and Union Health minister Jagat Prakash Nadda, Minister of Parliamentary Affairs and Minority Affairs Kiren Rijiju, Congress member Jairam Ramesh and Rajya Sabha Secretary General PC Mody and other senior officers of the secretariat were also present on the occasion. (PTI)



MINISTER JITENDRA SINGH REVIEWS IAS CADRE STRENGTH

Union Minister Jitendra Singh on Monday reviewed the cadre strength of the Indian Administrative Service (IAS) and discussed the evolving manpower requirements of states and the Centre. Launching the e-civil list 2026 of the IAS at the Kartavya Bhawan in New Delhi, he said that governance responsibilities continue to expand across sectors and regions, making efficient human resource planning increasingly important. Singh, the Minister of State for Personnel, expressed confidence that continuous assessment of requirements and regular cadre reviews would help address emerging needs and further strengthen administrative capacity. Highlighting the importance of data-driven governance, he reviewed the cadre strength position of the Indian Administrative Service and discussed the evolving manpower requirements of States and the Centre, according to a personnel ministry statement. (PNS)



Prime Minister Narendra Modi greets the gathering during the Republic Summit 2026 in New Delhi

PTI

PM Modi slams Congress over past Naxal violence

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi launched a scathing attack on the Congress on Monday for decades of unabated Maoist violence in the country and said the hands of those who are waving the Constitution now were trembling then. Addressing the "Republic Summit 2026", Modi also said Bharat is not only a fast-growing economy, but also a credible and reliable global power, and the country is scripting the future of the next 1,000 years. He said the previous Congress governments had labelled Naxal-affected areas as backward regions but the NDA government undertook the challenge of transforming those areas, helping the people there rise above despair and igniting their aspirations for progress.

To reflect this new approach, Modi said his Government renamed those areas as aspirational districts and blocks and today, these aspirational districts and blocks are driving the growth of those regions. He said a significant proportion of the population in these regions lived in poverty, but over the last few years, 25 crore people have overcome poverty, with aspirational districts playing a crucial role in this achievement, and those areas that were once affected by Naxalism are seeing new rays of development now. The prime minister said even in the 21st century, terrorists had prevented any facility from being established in the tribal areas. He added that even a government vehicle could not pass through, as it would be riddled with bullets. Governments came and

went, generations came and went, and it seemed that this misfortune of violence would persist just like that, Modi said. "Between 2004 and 2014, more than 17,000 violent incidents occurred due to Maoist terrorism and nearly 7,000 lives were lost. After 2014, we moved forward with the resolve of Nation First to change the situation. Today, Maoist terrorism in the country is counting its final breaths. This became possible because it required total dedication. Today, those who are waving the Constitution, their hands were trembling to even show the Constitution, then," he said. Congress leader Rahul Gandhi has been seen carrying a copy of the Constitution for different occasions, including while taking oath as an MP after the 2024 Lok Sabha polls.

BJP blames Congress rally after NEET students miss exam

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Slamming the Congress over reports that several students could not take the NEET-UG exam in Bengaluru due to its rally disrupting city traffic, the BJP on Monday said this makes it clear that for the party, politics comes above students' interests. "On one hand, Rahul Gandhi was doing theatrics and indulging in diversionary tactics just 72 hours before the examination in Kota. On the other hand, his own Government was not even ready to change the time of the rally to ensure that none of the students taking the NEET exam faces any problem," BJP national spokesperson Sudhanshu Trivedi told reporters. According to media reports, several NEET-UG aspirants in Bengaluru could not reach their examination centres to take the test on Sunday due to traffic disruptions allegedly caused by a Congress rally in the city. Reacting to media reports,



BJP national spokesperson Sudhanshu Trivedi

Trivedi said, "It is deeply unfortunate and concerning that, due to a rally held on Sunday in Bengaluru by the Karnataka Congress State president BK Hariprasad, many candidates were unable to appear for the NEET exam." Calling it "disturbing and disheartening", the BJP leader said this makes it clear that, for the Congress, politics is above the students' interests. Trivedi demanded a response from Rahul Gandhi on the issue, saying the Congress leader cannot run away from his responsibility. "After returning from Kolkata on Sunday, Prime Minister Narendra Modi stayed at the Delhi airport for 45 minutes to ensure that NEET aspirants do not face any inconvenience in reaching their examination centres," the BJP leader said. This is the difference between the thinking of the Congress Government and that of the BJP, Trivedi added.

30 arrested for malpractices in NEET-UG re-exam in Bihar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Patna

The police arrested at least 30 people allegedly for attempting irregularities in the NEET-UG re-examination in Bihar, an officer said on Monday. While 18 people working in the exam centres were arrested for violating the biometric verification norms, the majority of the others were impersonators who tried to write the exam in place of the genuine candidates. The re-examination was conducted across the state on Sunday amid tight security after the original undergraduate medical entrance test, held in early May, was



cancelled amid widespread allegations of a question paper leak. ADG (Law and Order) Sudhanshu Kumar

said 18 staff members associated with the biometric verification system had been arrested for allegedly collud-

ing with dummy candidates and middlemen by compromising the verification process. According to a statement issued by Lakhisarai police, nine impersonators, a genuine candidate, and two associates were also apprehended. Among the impersonators were one fourth-year MBBS student each from New Jalpaiguri Medical College (West Bengal), AIIMS Raebareli (UP) and AN Magadh Medical College (Bihar), along with a first-year student at Government Medical College in Satna (Madhya Pradesh), an MBBS intern at University College of Medical Sciences in Shahdara

(Delhi), a fourth-year B.Pharm student at NMCH Patna, and another student at NMCH Patna. Two of the impersonators were female: a BSc nursing student at BHU, and a BAMS student at Government Ayurvedic College in Odisha. A genuine candidate, Sanjeet Kumar of Nalanda district, was also arrested for irregularities. Among the arrested biometric verification staff, three were supervisors and a fourth-year MBBS student at PMCH Patna. The ADG said that two FIRs were lodged in the Kiul and Kawayiya police stations of the district.

Kerala reports 10 new Shigella cases; Nipah contained

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Thiruvananthapuram

Kerala reported 10 new cases of Shigella infection on Monday, taking the State's total for the year to 226. Health Minister K Muralaeeharan said authorities had successfully contained the spread of the Nipah virus and continued to maintain strict precautions against Ebola. The latest Shigella cases were detected in four districts, with Kozhikode reporting seven infec-



tions and Wayanad, Ernakulam and Malappuram recording one case each. According to the minister, 150 Shigella cases and six deaths have been reported across the state in June. Outbreaks have been declared in Kozhikode, Wayanad, Thrissur and Alappuzha, while infections have also been reported from Malappuram, Thiruvananthapuram, Kannur, Kollam, Idukki, Ernakulam and Palakkad. On Nipah, Muralaeeharan said the state's disease-control mea-

sures in Kozhikode had proved effective, with no evidence that the infection had spread beyond the confirmed patient. Health officials traced the patient's movements, mapped contacts and monitored people who may have been exposed, such as those linked to hospitals, the workplace and other locations visited by the patient. Samples collected from 15 symptomatic contacts have all tested negative, Muralaeeharan said in a statement. A total of 104 people remain on the contact list, of whom four

have been classified as very high risk, 14 as high risk and 86 as low risk. The infected patient continues to receive ventilator support at Kozhikode Medical College. The minister credited the coordinated efforts of district authorities, healthcare workers, doctors, local bodies, ASHA workers and others involved in the response with helping contain the outbreak. Muralaeeharan said Kerala had strengthened surveillance against Ebola following reports of the disease in the Congo, Uganda and South Sudan.

Sanjay Raut slams Shinde over defection of 6 Sena (UBT) MPs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Mumbai

In the latest twist to the never-ending Shiv Sena political soap opera, Sena (UBT) leader Sanjay Raut launched a scathing counterattack on Monday following the defection of six Lok Sabha MPs, claiming Deputy CM Eknath Shinde had undergone a 'Cesarean procedure' to give birth to 'six traitors.' The remarks from the Thackeray confidant came just hours after Shinde announced the successful conclusion of "Operation Tiger", the codename for engineering the defection of over half of the Sena (UBT)'s parliamentary strength.



"Let them show it. Shinde has delivered... 'Mindhe' has delivered and given birth to six traitors," Raut said. "Mindhe" is a derogatory term used by the Uddhav camp for Shinde, which loosely means a "puppet of the BJP."

CDSCO finds 46 drug samples not of standard quality for May

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The Central Drugs Laboratories found 46 drug samples manufactured by various firms to be "not of standard quality (NSQ)" in its monthly drug alert for May, health ministry officials said on Monday. Further, the State Drugs Testing Laboratories have identified 113 drug samples as NSQ, they said. According to routine regu-



latory surveillance activity, the list of NSQ and spurious drugs is being displayed on the Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO) portal on a monthly basis. "For the month of May 2026, Central Drugs Laboratories have identified 46 drug samples to be Not of Standard Quality (NSQ) and State Drugs Testing Laboratories have identified 113 drug samples as NSQ," a health ministry statement said.

NSA Doval meets senior Iranian security official

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

National Security Adviser Ajit Doval on Monday held wide-ranging talks with senior Iranian security official Ghadir Nezamipour, focusing on the evolving security environment in West Asia. Nezamipour, the Deputy Secretary for Defence Affairs at Iran's powerful Supreme National Security Council (SNSC), is in New Delhi to attend a conclave of BRICS. "Both sides reviewed the ongoing situation in West Asia. They also discussed cooperation under the BRICS platform and India-Iran bilat-

eral ties," External Affairs Ministry spokesman Randhir Jaiswal said on social media. It is the first visit to India by a senior official from Iran after it struck a peace agreement with the US. The NSAs of the BRICS nations will hold extensive discussions on the security scenario in the region on Tuesday. The conclave officially begins on Monday. India to host key BRICS security conclave amid rising geopolitical tensions. Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi, Russian NSA Sergei Shoigu, and other top BRICS security officials are set to be part of the deliberations.



■ States Focus ■



PM MODI CONDOLES DEMISE OF BHAVANABEN PATEL

Bhavanaben Patel, the wife of Union Territory Administrator and former Gujarat Minister of State for Home Praful Patel, passed away after a prolonged illness, prompting condolences from political leaders across the country. Prime Minister Narendra Modi expressed grief over her demise through a social media message, recalling his long association with the Patel family and conveying condolences to the bereaved family. He also prayed for eternal peace for the departed soul. According to family sources, Bhavanaben Patel had been undergoing treatment for a serious illness for some time.

(PTI)



BJP READY TO LEAD FIGHT FOR CHANGE IN PUNJAB: NITIN NABIN

BJP National President Nitin Nabin on Monday said the party is ready to lead the fight for change in Punjab and urged the youth to play a major role in the state's transformation. Addressing a Yuva Milni programme in Ludhiana during his first visit to Punjab after assuming office, Nabin said the BJP has high expectations from the state's youth and is prepared to meet the aspirations of the people. Interacting with young participants, he answered questions on issues such as infrastructure development, Punjab's debt burden, law and order, women's safety, industrial migration, agriculture, international flight connectivity, sports and healthcare. Nabin said infrastructure and development are closely linked to law and order and require a clear vision from the Government. He claimed that states such as Uttar Pradesh and Bihar have progressed due to strong governance and leadership. Nabin said Punjab has immense potential but has fallen behind in development.

(PTI)

TMC rebel camp appoints Arup as faction chairperson

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Kolkata

In a dramatic escalation of the battle for control of the TMC, the party's rebel faction, led by Leader of the Opposition Ritabrata Banerjee, on Monday convened a special session in Kolkata, and named senior MLA Arup Roy as the chairperson of what it described as the "real" Trinamool Congress.

The move marked the most direct organisational challenge yet to party supremo and founder chairperson Mamata Banerjee, whose authority over the organisation has come under increasing strain, following successive rebellions within the party's legislative and parliamentary wings after the TMC's defeat in the Assembly elections.

Held at a five-star hotel in New Town, the special session brought together rebel MLAs, councillors and former elected representatives from several districts.

The backdrop itself underscored the political messaging of the gathering. While the TMC party symbol remained prominently displayed, portraits of Mahatma Gandhi, Rabindranath Tagore and BR Ambedkar adorned the stage.

Notably absent were photographs of Mamata Banerjee and her nephew Abhishek Banerjee, who have long been the central faces of the party.

The rebel camp claimed the meeting was convened to address what it



MLA Arup Roy

termed a "constitutional crisis" within the organisation.

Addressing the session, Ritabrata Banerjee argued that the party's constitution mandated the formation of a national working committee every three years and that the last such panel had been constituted in February 2022.

"The organisational structure was not renewed after the expiry of its tenure. Therefore, it became necessary to initiate the process of reconstituting the party's national leadership," a leader present at the meeting quoted Banerjee as saying.

The gathering swiftly moved to constitute a new national working committee, beginning with an initial panel of leaders that included Arup Roy, Firhad Hakim, Arup Biswas, Biplab Mitra, Akhruzzaman Ansari, Sabina Yasmin, Sandipan Saha, Rathin Ghosh, Javed

Khan and Ritabrata Banerjee.

The committee subsequently expanded to 30 members. Soon afterwards, Arup Roy, the veteran MLA from Howrah Central, was elected chairperson by voice vote. Firhad Hakim, Aroop Biswas, Rathin Ghosh and Sabina Yasmin were named vice-chairpersons, while Ritabrata Banerjee, Javed Khan and Sandipan Saha were appointed general secretaries. Akhruzzaman Ansari was later announced as treasurer. The faction also resolved to appoint an auditor to examine the party's finances.

Several prominent leaders associated with the rebel bloc attended the session, including Hakim, Biswas and legislators from Birbhum and Murshidabad districts. Sources in the camp claimed that around 60 MLAs and a large number of councillors, including many from the Kolkata Municipal Corporation, either attended or endorsed the proceedings. The organisational exercise comes amid a deepening crisis within the TMC, which has witnessed an unprecedented split in its elected ranks since losing power in West Bengal after 15 years.

Only days ago, 58 of the party's 80 MLAs backed Ritabrata claim to the post of Leader of the Opposition, rejecting the choice favoured by the Mamata Banerjee-led leadership. The rebel camp has since claimed its strength in the assembly has risen to around 65 legislators.

Pankaj Tripathi's brother attacked in Bihar; accused held

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Gopalganj

Vijaynath Tiwari, elder brother of actor Pankaj Tripathi, was seriously injured on Sunday in an alleged assault over a land dispute in Gopalganj district, police said on Monday. According to police, the accused has been arrested, and the weapon allegedly used in the attack has been recovered.

According to Gopalganj Superintendent of Police Vinay Tiwari, the incident occurred on June 21 at Belsand Tiwari Tola village under the jurisdiction of Madhopur police station. Preliminary investigation suggests the attack stemmed from a longstanding



dispute over a piece of ancestral land. "Vijaynath Tiwari sustained injuries and was rushed to a local hospital. His condition is stable now," SP Tiwari said. "We have arrested the accused

within 24 hours".

Police sources said an argument broke out between Vijaynath Tiwari, 62, and a resident over demarcation and possession of farmland. The alter-

cation escalated, and the accused allegedly attacked him with a sharp-edged weapon. Family members intervened and took the injured man to Sadar Hospital, Gopalganj, where he received stitches and is under observation. Doctors treating him said he is out of danger. The weapon allegedly used in the assault and the blood-stained clothes have been recovered from his possession.

An FIR has been registered at Madhopur police station under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita for attempt to commit culpable homicide and voluntarily causing hurt by dangerous weapons. The accused, a resident of the same village, was produced

before a local court on Monday and remanded to judicial custody. Family members said they are more focused on Vijaynath Tiwari's recovery.

SP Tiwari added that land disputes remain a frequent trigger for violence in the region. "We have directed local police stations to maintain a list of chronic disputes and intervene early. A revenue team will also measure the disputed plot to prevent further flare-ups," he said.

The district administration has deployed additional personnel in the village to maintain law and order. Police said that further investigation is underway and that statements from eyewitnesses are being recorded.



the former environment minister said. "You are aware that the public Private Partnership Appraisal Committee of the Ministry of Finance had met on March 17, 2026 and March 19, 2026, to consider the proposal of the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways for the development of an international container transshipment port at Galathea Bay, Great Nicobar Island."

"Para 15 vii of the record of discussions of this meeting issued on April 2, 2026, States that the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways itself had identified two major risks that are: the development of a large-scale greenfield port project; and the challenge of diverting and establishing transshipment traffic well-established ports," Ramesh said.

Ahmedabad gears up for 149th Jagannath Rath Yatra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Ahmedabad

Preparations for the 149th edition of the annual Jagannath Rath Yatra have gathered momentum at the historic Jagannath Temple in Jamalpur ahead of the grand procession scheduled for July 16. Temple authorities, artisans and the administration have intensified efforts to ensure the smooth conduct of one of Gujarat's most significant religious events.

Extensive renovation and decoration work is underway on the three ceremonial chariots that will carry Lord Jagannath, Lord Balabhadra and Goddess Subhadra through the city. This year, the chariots have been fitted with newly crafted wooden wheels in keeping with longstanding traditions. Craftsmen are also repainting and decorating the chariots, while devotees have performed rituals before the installation of the new wheels.

Police and temple authorities have also begun coordinating security arrangements, traffic management and facilities for the large number of pilgrims expected to attend the annual procession.



CBI arrests two SBI scam fugitives absconding for 20 years

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH

■ New Delhi

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has arrested two fugitives, Brijbhushan Prasad and Kartar Singh, who were wanted for nearly 21 years in connection with the alleged siphoning of over ₹1.25 crore from an SBI branch in Dhanbad, Jharkhand. Both were facing Interpol Red Notices and had been declared proclaimed offenders by the court.

The arrests were carried out on Sunday in a simultaneous operation at two separate locations. Prasad was apprehended in Kopargaon, Ahmednagar district, Maharashtra, while Singh was taken into custody in Raipur, Chhattisgarh. Officials said the duo had been living



under assumed identities to evade arrest.

According to the Central Bureau of Investigation, the case was registered on August 31, 2005, on the charges of misappropriation of funds from the SBI branch in Dhanbad between November 2002 and June 2005. After the Central Bureau of Investigation took over the investigation, the accused fled to Nepal. An Interpol Red Notice was subsequently issued against them, and a reward of ₹25,000 was announced for information leading to their arrest.

"Subsequently, the accused were declared proclaimed offenders by the court. Based on sustained efforts, technical inputs, meticulous follow-up and coordinated action by CBI, both the proclaimed offenders,

who had been absconding for nearly two decades and were living under assumed identities to evade arrest, were apprehended on Sunday in a simultaneous operation conducted at two different locations," the CBI spokesperson said.

The arrests bring closure to a long-pending financial fraud case that had remained unresolved for over two decades. The two accused are now in Central Bureau of Investigation custody and are likely to be produced before the designated court in the coming days for further legal proceedings.

Senior CBI officials described the operation as a result of persistent investigation and interstate coordination. The agency had maintained continuous surveillance and followed leads

that ultimately helped track down the fugitives who had changed locations and identities multiple times over the years.

The case pertains to alleged irregularities in banking transactions at the Dhanbad branch during the specified period. Details of the modus operandi and the exact role of the accused will emerge during further investigation and trial, officials added. With these arrests, the Central Bureau of Investigation has once again demonstrated its commitment to pursuing economic offenders regardless of how long it has been since the crime was committed.

The agency is expected to file a chargesheet or seek further remand in accordance with legal requirements in the coming weeks, an official said.

J&K DGP reviews security ahead of Amarnath Yatra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Srinagar

Jammu and Kashmir Director General of Police Nalin Prabhakar on Monday reviewed the counter-insurgency measures and arrangements for the upcoming Amarnath Yatra.

"The DGP chaired a comprehensive Security Review Meeting (SRM) to assess counter-insurgency measures and security arrangements for the forthcoming Shri Amarnathji Yatra 2026 (SANJY-2026)," a police spokesman said.

He said the meeting was attended by senior officers. All Senior Superintendents of Police (SSPs) of the concerned districts made detailed presentations covering the prevailing security scenario, counter-insurgency operational measures, and the multi-layered security grid being put in place for the Yatra, the spokesman said.

20,000 kids receive free CBSE schooling in Maharashtra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

At a time when quality education is becoming increasingly expensive for ordinary families, a Maharashtra-based educational trust is demonstrating that world-class schooling can be made accessible to all. The Jijau Educational and Social Organisation, founded by social activist and educationist Nilesh Sambare, is successfully running 10 CBSE English-medium schools across the Mumbai Metropolitan Region and Palghar district, providing completely free education to nearly 20,000 students.

The initiative began in 2014 with the establishment of its first school in Zhadpoli. Over the years, the network has expanded to ten locations, including Brahmanpada, Chalatlwad, Ambadi, Khodala, Zhap, Gotheghar, Mokhada, Kasara, and Dolkhamb. Students at these schools are not charged any tuition fees and also receive free textbooks, educational materials, and school bus transportation.

A key highlight of the Jijau model is its focus on competitive exam preparation. From Class IX onwards, students receive specialised coach-



ing for NEET and JEE examinations from experienced faculty, including IIT-trained teachers.

The organisation further strengthens educational access by distributing around 3.5 million books and notebooks annually. "Education should never depend on a family's income. Every child deserves an equal opportunity to learn and excel," said Nilesh Sambare.

With plans to establish 50 more schools across the Konkan region, the Jijau Educational and Social Organisation is emerging as a powerful example of education-driven social transformation and inclusive development.

Kashmiri Pandits yearn for home at Kheer Bhawani Temple

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Ganderbal

At the crack of dawn, when Shreya Tikoo stepped inside the Mata Kheer Bhawani Temple complex, escorting her grandfather for the first time, the resonating sound of the conch greeted her on Monday morning. The air was filled with the fragrance of flower petals and incense sticks. A large number of devotees were already present in the temple premises, offering prayers on the auspicious occasion of Jyeshtha Ashtami.

As the day progressed, Shreya made many friends and participated in the rituals, soaking herself in the spiritual atmosphere of the temple complex nestled in the shade of mammoth Chinara trees in the central Kashmir district of Ganderbal. After performing prayers, Shreya expressed her keen desire to stay back in the Kashmir valley for some more time.

"Mera bahut man hai yahan rahne ka lekin philhaal ke liye wo abhi possible nahin hai". (I wish I could stay back a little longer, but it is not possible.) I have met several relatives here. Compared to Jammu, I feel nice



here, "I really get the vibes that's our place". A large number of youngsters who visited the temple complex for the first time also expressed a similar desire to one day return to their 'homes and hearths'.

"We have been yearning for 'ghar wapsi' since 1990. 36 years later, we are still struggling for a dignified and secure return to our homeland", several other members of the exiled Kashmiri pandit community reiterated

their passionate demand, seeking their rehabilitation at the earliest.

Kashmiri Pandit families travel from different corners to offer prayers on the occasion of Jyeshtha Ashtami. Devotees offer milk and kheer (rice pudding) at the sacred spring within the complex while chanting 'sholokas'.

The annual festival witnessed one of the highest footfalls in recent years. The festival marks

the appearance day of Goddess Ragnya Bhagwati. It is celebrated at several shrines dedicated to the deity across Kashmir, including Kheer Bhawani at Tulmulla, Tripur Sundari at Devsar, Ragnya Bhagwati at Manzgam, Loktipora and Tikker.

The local Muslim families welcome them with open arms and set up small shops offering pooja material and other logistics to ensure hassle-free celebrations.

Maharashtra Govt tables ₹97,706 crore supplementary demands

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Maharashtra Government on Monday tabled supplementary demands of ₹97,706.40 crore, including ₹20,552 crore for the farm loan waiver scheme, with a net additional burden of ₹74,817.66 crore on the exchequer.

Notably, the Opposition has been demanding a complete farm loan waiver with minimal technical conditions. NCP (SP) MLA Rohit Pawar protested earlier this month to press for the removal of "stringent" conditions from the farm loan waiver scheme and demand a blanket loan waiver for farmers. Chief

Minister Devendra Fadnavis tabled the demands in the Assembly on the first day of the legislature's monsoon session on Monday.

Of the total supplementary demands, ₹13,825.71 crore has been sought for unavoidable expenditure, ₹66,559.40 crore for programme-related spending, and ₹17,321.29 crore against expenditure to be supported through funds available under centrally sponsored schemes. Despite the gross demands of ₹97,706.40 crore, the actual financial burden will be ₹74,817.66 crore due to adjustments and recoveries, an official note released by the Government said. Among the largest allocations pro-

posed is ₹20,552 crore for the farm loan waiver scheme — Punyashlok Ahilyadevi Holkar Shetkari Karjimukti Yojana, 2026.

A provision of ₹10,007.10 crore has been made towards interest-free loans under the Centre's Special Assistance to States for Capital Investment scheme. Another ₹8,000 crore has been earmarked for repayment of loans and interest liabilities of the Maharashtra State Electricity Distribution Company Ltd (MSEDCL). The Government has proposed ₹7,367.32 crore for the Viksit Bharat-Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) programme, comprising both central and state shares, and



₹4,000 crore for payment of electricity bills of Government offices through a unified billing system.

A sum of ₹3,076 crore has been sought for the AMRUT 2.0 mission (aimed at making cities water-secure and self-

sustaining), while ₹3,000 crore has been set aside for planning and execution of the Simhastha Kumbh Mela.

The Government has also sought ₹2,722.42 crore towards electricity tariff subsidies for agricultural pumps,

powerlooms, textile and industrial consumers and ₹2,360.06 crore for scholarship schemes covering tuition and examination fees.

A provision of ₹2,000 crore has been made for beneficiaries under the Shravanbal Seva State Pension Scheme and ₹1,874.38 crore for disabled and general category beneficiaries under the Sanjay Gandhi Niradhar Yojana.

An allocation of ₹1,734.92 crore has been proposed for honorarium and salaries of anganwadi workers, while ₹1,100 crore has been earmarked for projects of the Vidarbha Irrigation Development Corporation.

Other notable provisions include ₹1,000 crore each for

Swachh Maharashtra Abhiyan (Urban) 2.0 and equity contribution to the Maharashtra State Road Development Corporation for the Revas-Reddi coastal highway project. The supplementary demands also include ₹942.50 crore for employment guarantee schemes, Rs 777 crore as equity contribution to district central cooperative banks, ₹744.45 crore for the Mahatma Jyotirao Phule Jan Arogya Yojana and ₹600 crore for the development and commercial complex plan around the Shri Vitthal-Rukmini temple precinct in Pandharpur.

Department-wise, the highest supplementary allocation of ₹22,015.42 crore has

been proposed for the Cooperation, Marketing and Textiles Department, followed by the Urban Development Department with ₹15,152.43 crore and the Industries, Energy, Labour and Mining Department with ₹14,760.48 crore. The Finance Department has been allocated ₹9,934 crore, and the Planning Department ₹9,539.03 crore.

The Public Works Department is set to receive ₹5,361.90 crore, while allocations of ₹3,481.01 crore and ₹3,061.26 crore have been proposed for the Social Justice and Special Assistance Department and Public Health Department, respectively, according to the Government.

Nagaland Governor calls for future-ready education

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Dimapur

Nagaland Governor Nand Kishore Yadav on Monday asserted that India's education system must prepare young people with knowledge, skills, values and creativity to meet future challenges, while asserting that education remains the most powerful instrument of transformation in the country's journey towards achieving the Viksit Bharat 2047.

Addressing the Byatikram Education Conclave 9.0 in Dimapur, attended by educationists, academicians, principals, teachers and students, the governor said the education sector must focus on producing lifelong learners, innovators and responsible citizens capable of adapting to rapid technological changes.

Highlighting the significance of the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020, Yadav said the policy offers a comprehensive roadmap for educational advancement through multidisciplinary learning, critical thinking, innovation and skill development.



Nagaland Governor Nand Kishore

Bidadi row: Kumaraswamy challenges Karnataka CM Shivakumar to debate

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

JD(S) leader HD Kumaraswamy on Monday challenged Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar to an open debate on the proposed GBIT project near Bidadi in Bengaluru South district, and the Government's land acquisition for it.

He asked the CM to come to Byramangala, where farmers have been protesting, whenever he was free.

Claiming that 80-90 per cent of local farmers remain opposed to the township project and that more than 4,000 farmers have filed objections since the Government issued its preliminary notification, the Union Minister criticised the administration for allegedly failing to respond to those objections and asked: "Is this what public service means?"

"A challenge was thrown for a debate (from Shivakumar). Come, let's go to Byramangala and see whether the farmers have really consented to give up their land for the project," Kumaraswamy said.

Speaking to reporters, he said, "I'm free, you (Shivakumar) are running a Government and will be busy until midnight 12 or 1. So I had said that whenever you make time and fix a schedule, I would come for a discussion. I'm saying the same thing even now: I'm free, and I can come any time. I never said I would not come. He



JD(S) leader HD Kumaraswamy

(CM) is busy. I'm not as busy as he is. So amid his busy schedule, if he comes, I'm ready at any time."

"Let's go to the people at Byramangala, where women and the elderly have been sitting in protest for over 450 days. Let's discuss in front of them," he added.

However, Shivakumar, not willing to respond in detail, said, let JD(S) MLAs raise the issue during the upcoming Assembly session, and he would reply to them.

"I will not say anything. He (Kumaraswamy) did not come when I called (for a debate). There is an Assembly, where he can make his experienced politicians (MLAs) speak. Will respond to them... I wish them all the best," he told reporters.

Despite opposition from sections of farmers and villagers, a final notification was recently issued for the acquisition of 499 acres across three

villages in Ramanagara and Harohalli taluks for the Greater Bengaluru Integrated Township, one of Shivakumar's ambitious projects, projected as India's "first AI-powered integrated township".

The project is expected to cover a total of 7,481 acres across nine villages in the region, sources said, adding that the notification issued recently is likely to be the first in a series of land acquisition notifications expected in the coming days.

Alleging that the project-related work is not happening at the Government offices but at a rented house at Nagarbhavi in Bengaluru, Kumaraswamy said the transactions are happening with some mafia elements around.

"The project-related work is not happening at the DC office... Be prepared for how many of you will have to go to jail. I know things very well," he said.

MAHARASHTRA MLC POLLS

BJP-led Mahayuti bags 16 of 17 seats

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Amid cross-voting from both ruling and Opposition ranks, the BJP-led Mahayuti on Monday swept 16 of the 17 Maharashtra Legislative Council seats from local authorities' constituencies, even as Nashik delivered a surprise defeat to the governing bloc.

The BJP won 11 seats and its allies, Shiv Sena, three and the NCP two. Independent and BJP rebel Gokul Gite, a relative of a local party leader, clinched the Nashik seat.

The biennial elections were originally notified for 17 seats, including one bypoll, but voting was necessitated in only 11 constituencies as candidates of the Mahayuti alliance, comprising the BJP, Shiv Sena and NCP, secured unopposed victories in six seats.

Voting in the 11 constituencies, where elected members of local self-governing bodies formed the electoral college, was held on June 18 and counting took place on June 22.



BJP candidate Rajiv Potdar with supporters celebrates after winning MLC election

PTI

The Opposition MahaVikas Aghadi, comprising the Congress, Shiv Sena (UBT) and NCP (SP), failed to win a single seat.

Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis termed the poll outcome a "resounding victory" and decisive mandate in favour of the Mahayuti.

Fadnavis, who belongs to the BJP, asserted the victory came under the

leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and guidance of senior party leaders.

"The BJP-Mahayuti has won the Legislative Council elections in Maharashtra. I congratulate all the winning candidates," he said.

The results were marked by cross-voting across constituencies, including from Congress, Shiv Sena (UBT) and NCP (SP) ranks in favour of BJP and Shiv Sena candidates.

In Nagpur, BJP nominee Rajiv Potdar registered a record win as Congress candidate Atul Londhe failed to retain even his party's votes, with around 40 Congress votes reportedly defecting. The Nagpur local authorities constituency saw a bypoll, which was necessitated after senior BJP leader Chandrashekar Bawankule vacated the seat following his election to the Assembly.

Potdar will have a two-year tenure as the seat was held by Bawankule for four years.

Odisha Speaker Surama Padhy rejects Opposition demand to disqualify 11 MLAs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhubaneswar

Odisha Assembly Speaker Surama Padhy has dismissed the Opposition BJD and Congress petitions to disqualify the membership of 11 of their MLAs on the charge of anti-party activities and cross-voting during the March 16 Rajya Sabha election.

While BJD chief whip Pramila Mallik sought the disqualification of eight of its MLAs, Congress Legislature Party leader Rama Chandra Kadam had sought the disqualification of three of its legislators. Referring to BJD petitions, the Odisha Assembly secretariat, in a June 19 notification, said, "The petition is cryptic, vague, unsubstantiated and does not fulfil the statutory requirements to be gone into on merits, even



Odisha Legislative Assembly Speaker Surama Padhy conducts proceeding of the State Assembly in Bhubaneswar

PTI

assuming for the sake of argument, but not admitting, that the contents are otherwise worthy of being enquired into."

"Therefore, the petition suffers from gross infirmity or defects have been presented in sure ignorance of the statutory require-

ments and do not deserve any consideration," it said.

After examination, the Speaker noted that the evidence against the MLAs did not establish voluntary resignation or defection under paragraph 2(1)(a) of the Tenth Schedule of the Constitution.

"These (petitions) failed to comply with mandatory requirements under the Members of Odisha Legislative Assembly (Disqualification on Ground of Defection) Rules, 1987," the notification said.

The order further noted that the petitions were not verified in the manner prescribed under the Code of Civil Procedure, 1908.

Supporting annexures, documents and digital evidence were not properly authenticated, and no affidavit was filed to substantiate the allegations made in the petition, Speaker Padhy told reporters on Monday, adding that mandatory procedural requirements under the rules were also not fulfilled. "The decision in this regard was taken as per law," she said.

The BJD had demanded the disqualification of the membership

of eight MLAs — Chakramani Kanhar of Baliguda, Devi Ranjan Tripathy of Banki, Arvind Mohapatra of Patkura, Sanatan Mahakud of Champua, Subasini Jena of Basta, Naba Kishore Mallick of Jaydev, and Souvic Biswal of Cuttack-Chowdwar.

Each notification cited the Speaker's finding that the members had not voluntarily relinquished their party affiliation as alleged by the BJD.

The Congress had also filed a petition seeking the disqualification of its members, such as Sofia Firdous of Barabati-Cuttack, Ramesh Jena of Sanakhemindu, and Dasarath Gamag of Moihana.

The BJD, in its petition, alleged that the legislators had violated the anti-defection provisions under the Constitution's Tenth Schedule by acting against the

party's official stand. The BJD also claimed that the legislators violated the party whip and defied official directives during the polls, terming their actions as anti-party activities warranting disqualification under the anti-defection law.

Invoking powers under Rule 7(2) of the Defection Rules, 1987, the Speaker has dismissed the petition at the threshold stage, for which the Assembly Secretariat did not examine the merits of the cross-voting allegations.

The alleged cross-voting incident occurred during elections for four Rajya Sabha seats from Odisha on March 16.

The BJD, in an understanding with the Congress and CPI(M), had fielded noted urologist Dr Datteswar Hota as a joint candidate for one seat.

20% quota to ex-Agniveers in police, forest dept in Gujarat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gandhinagar

The Gujarat Government has announced a package of recruitment benefits for former Agniveers, including 20 per cent reservation in direct recruitment to Class III posts across several State departments.

Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel has approved the policy to facilitate the transition of ex-Agniveers into Government service after completing their military tenure. Along with the reservation, eligible candidates will receive an exemp-

tion from the prescribed physical efficiency test for the notified recruitments.

The Government has also approved relaxation in the upper age limit by up to three years for eligible candidates. Members of the first batch of the Agniveer scheme will be entitled to an age relaxation of up to five years. According to the State Government, the initiative aims to provide trained and disciplined former Agniveers with employment opportunities while strengthening the State's security and administrative services with experienced personnel.

Andhra allocates ₹800 crore for development of ancient temples

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Amaravati

Andhra Pradesh Endowments Minister A Ramnarayan Reddy on Monday said the State Government has allocated over ₹800 crore for the development of nearly 700 neglected ancient temples in the State.

Presenting the achievements of the Endowments Department in the past two years under the TDP-led Government, Reddy said the funds for developing these temples were sanctioned under the 'Sarvasreyonidhi' scheme.

"We have created history by allotting ₹813 crore under Sarvyasreyonidhi to



A Ramnarayan Reddy

develop 692 neglected ancient temples," he said, addressing a press conference in the secretariat.

The Endowments Minister said the department has set a target to build 5,000 'Srivani Bhajan Mandirs' (places for worship) at a cost of ₹750 crore with cooperation

from TTD, the official custodian of Sri Venkateswara Swamy temple in Tirupati.

Of the proposed target, Reddy said approvals were granted for 1,270 'Srivani Bhajan Mandirs' with an allocation of ₹267 crore.

According to the minister, the annual allocation for 'dhoopa deepa naivedya' scheme (rituals such as lighting lamps, smoke and others) in 6,137 temples across the state has been doubled to ₹73 crore from ₹35 crore.

Further, he said the Endowments Department has started blockchain-based digitalisation of nearly 4.5 lakh acres of land belonging to 22,672 temples to protect them.



BIT-Mesra, IIT-Kharagpur sign MoU for research

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ranchi

Birla Institute of Technology-Mesra and IIT-Kharagpur have signed an MoU for structured collaboration across research, academics, and institutional capacity-building.

The agreement establishes a five-year framework, extendable by mutual consent, covering joint PhD supervision, shared laboratory access, intellectual property development and commercialisation, and a range of collaborative academic and research activities, according to an official statement.

"The collaboration with IIT-Kharagpur represents an important milestone in BIT Mesra's pursuit of academic excellence, impactful research,



and innovation-led growth," said BIT-Mesra vice-chancellor Professor Indranil Manna. "Through this partnership, we aim to create new opportunities for our students and faculty while contributing to national priorities through collaborative research and technology development," he said.

Both institutions will also explore a joint Integrated MTech-PhD programme and dual-degree pathways under the agreement.



Editor's
TAKE

Bracing for a below-average monsoon

With farms, food prices and growth all riding on the rains, India needs contingency planning now, not after the kharif season fails due to deficient rains

India's monsoon has arrived, but it has not turned up for work. The Southwest Monsoon reached Kerala on June 4 – three days behind its normal schedule – and after a brief burst of progress, it has since stalled. By mid-June, the country was sitting on a 38 per cent rainfall deficit, with central India, the heart of the rain-fed farm belt, down 62 per cent. The India Meteorological Department had already lowered its seasonal forecast to 90 per cent of the long-period average, with a 60 per cent chance of a deficient season overall. The reasons: a strengthening El Niño, a neutral Indian Ocean Dipole, a weak Somali Jet, sluggish convection over the Bay of Bengal, and an absent assist from Pacific typhoon remnants.

Agriculture still employs nearly half of India's workforce and contributes around 15 per cent of GDP, even though more than half the net sown area depends entirely on rainfall rather than irrigation. A weak or delayed monsoon does not just dent a harvest; it works through wages, mandi turnover, and the spending of hundreds of millions of rural households. Kharif sowing of pulses and cotton is already running behind last year. If the lull persists into July, paddy, soybean, oilseeds, and coarse cereals will bear the brunt.

The transmission to the wider economy is fairly direct. Food and beverages make up roughly 37 per cent of India's CPI basket, and El Niño years have historically pushed food inflation above 1.7 percentage points higher than normal years. Every percentage point of rainfall shortfall against the long-period average has, on past form, shaved around 0.4 percentage points off agricultural value-added growth.

That feeds into the RBI's calculations: a brief vegetable price spike can be looked through, but a season-long shortfall risks hardening inflation expectations and complicating any room for rate cuts. Rural demand for tractors, two-wheelers, and FMCG goods – which had a strong run in the first half of the year on the back of the rabi harvest – would lose its principal prop for the second half. A weaker rupee and a wider current account deficit are already being priced in by markets.

The encouraging counterweight is that India is not starting from scratch. Major reservoirs are filled well above the ten-year average, giving irrigation a buffer through the sowing window. Irrigation coverage itself has crept up from under half to 55 per cent of cropped area over the past decade. The right response now is to lean on these buffers deliberately rather than wait them out: release reservoir water in a calibrated, monitored manner; fast-track short-duration and drought-tolerant seed varieties for late sowing; expand crop insurance payouts and make claim processing faster, not just available; keep diesel and fertiliser supply chains, already strained by global disruptions, unblocked, and ensure the more than 300 districts under contingency watch actually have funded, district-specific cropping plans rather than templated advisories.

Monsoon forecasting has improved, but India's vulnerability to a bad one has not gone away. The next six weeks of rainfall, not the next six months of policy statements, will decide how this season plays out.

India's delicate balancing act with the US

As Trump's transactional approach to foreign policy reshapes Washington's priorities, New Delhi finds itself walking a diplomatic tightrope: preserving a vital partnership with the United States while safeguarding its own strategic autonomy and regional interests



PARUL
CHANDRA

Anticipation ran high ahead of the meeting between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and President Donald Trump on the sidelines of the recent G-7 Summit in Evian-les-Bains, France. The encounter marked their first bilateral engagement since February 2025 – a 16-month hiatus that underscored the growing friction in India-US ties.

While New Delhi subsequently sought to dismiss the prolonged gap as “nothing unusual”, the reality is quite different. Following the meeting, foreign secretary Vikram Misri acknowledged the strain, noting that “relationships naturally go through ups and downs” and that both nations must actively “manage those fluctuations”. This candid admission confirms that managing bilateral friction has replaced the unabashed optimism and strategic convergence during Trump's first term in 2017-2021.

A keyword in Misri's statement was “manage” – a deliberate choice that reflected New Delhi's pragmatic approach toward Trump's unpredictable, transactional foreign policy approach. Indeed, the Trump administration's disruptive policy shifts and rhetoric have strained bilateral relations, forcing India to recalibrate its approach to protect its own strategic interests. The Modi-Trump meeting was clearly not a “reset” in ties, nor will it automatically lead to more robust, stable relations.

In the months leading up to the meeting, the Trump administration in keeping with its mantra of ‘America First’ slapped high tariffs on Indian goods, including the imposition of punitive penalties for importing Russian oil. This has directly undermined India's energy security, carrying serious strategic implications.

Additionally, Trump's repeated – and, as per the Modi government, entirely unsubstantiated ones – claims about enforcing a truce between India and Pakistan following four days of cross-border hostilities under ‘Operation Sindoor’ have aggravated matters. This, combined with his administration's restrictive immigration policies and the recent killing of three Indian seafarers in US strikes in the Hormuz Strait, have also contributed to the downward spiral in ties.

During their recent meeting, both leaders reaffirmed their commitment to strengthening the India-US Comprehensive Strategic Partnership. Yet, New Delhi knows all too well that a transactional leader like Trump can pull



WHAT IS DEEPLY WORRYING FOR NEW DELHI, HOWEVER, IS THE TRUMP ADMINISTRATION'S WANING INTEREST IN THE INDO-PACIFIC FRAMEWORK DESIGNED TO COUNTER CHINA. INDIA HAS BEEN UNABLE TO HOST THE QUAD SUMMIT DUE TO TRUMP'S DISINCLINATION

the carpet from under its feet any moment. This friction has eroded trust – a reality Modi implicitly referenced in his broader address to G-7 leaders, where he underscored the importance of trust-based international partnerships in an increasingly interconnected and interdependent world.

It's precisely this trust that is currently missing from the New Delhi-Washington dynamic. Consequently, there is a delicious sense of irony in Trump's post-meeting declaration that the two countries have “always had a great relationship”. It's a measure of New Delhi wanting to keep the bilateral relationship stable that PM Modi also asserted that ties have gained “speed and energy” since their meeting last year.

As the two sides seek to bridge the trust deficit, deftly managing the relationship is a strategic necessity for India amid the geopolitical flux. The raging West Asia conflict, a region where India has huge stakes, also demands that New Delhi adopt a highly-calibrated approach towards Washington to safeguard its interests.

Though there is a fragile peace prevailing for now between the US and Iran after they inked a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU), the situation in the region remains volatile.

Already seriously impacted by the conflict, with its energy supplies from the region having taken a huge hit following the closure of the Hormuz Strait, India must remain engaged with all regional players.

India, however, also needs to employ some strategic pushback and plain-speaking when required. Modi, in his meeting with Trump, only indirectly raised the killing of the

three Indian mariners by mentioning the general need for the safety of seafarers transiting the Hormuz Strait. The message should have been delivered much more directly. The US has expressed no regret over the killings, and President Trump himself was remarkably blasé about the deaths, dismissing them with: “It's a rough profession.”

Meanwhile, the bilateral trade deal too has been hanging fire for far too long, though an outcome of the Modi-Trump meeting is the resolve to work out a “balanced, mutually beneficial and commercially meaningful agreement”.

What is deeply worrying for New Delhi, however, is the Trump administration's waning interest in the Indo-Pacific framework designed to counter China. India has been unable to host the Quad Summit due to Trump's disinclination. Equally problematic for New Delhi has been Trump's frequent invocation of a “G-2” (US-China) framework, which positions these two nations at the absolute centre of the global order. Washington's latest move to revert to the old nomenclature of the US Pacific Command (USPACOM) from the US Indo-Pacific Command (USINDOPACOM) also signals the diminishing importance of India and Indian Ocean in its strategic calculus.

Amid this fraught and uncertain scenario, New Delhi will have to delicately navigate its ties with Washington for as long as the mercurial Trump remains in office.

For India, an aggressive China remains its foremost strategic challenge. Balancing the threat with the help of the US, and to some extent other Indo-Pacific powers like Japan, Australia and South Korea, is pivotal.

The writer is a senior journalist

The invisible boundaries we build

was even more troubling. Some residents argued that domestic workers should not use the same lifts as apartment owners. The argument was presented as practicality and convenience. Yet beneath it lay an assumption that certain people, despite working there every day, somehow belonged to a different category. Another discussion arose when a resident discovered that the husbands of certain domestic workers employed in the society had criminal records. The concern for safety was understandable. What puzzled me, however, was the assumption that the actions of those men somehow cast suspicion upon the women themselves. We routinely argue that individuals should be judged on their own merits, yet that principle often appears to weaken when applied across social and economic boundaries.

What struck me was not the existence of such views, but the fact that they were expressed by educated, successful, and professionally accomplished individuals. Economic progress, it seems, does not automatically eliminate social prejudice. Perhaps this is because many forms of discrimination no longer present themselves openly. They survive in subtler ways-in assumptions about status, in expectations about who belongs where, and in beliefs about whose choices deserve respect and whose do not.

The irony is difficult to miss. Many of us rightly expect dignity, fairness, and equal opportunity in our own professional lives. We resist discrimination when it affects us. Yet we sometimes struggle to extend the same principles to those whose lives intersect with ours through work and

service. What makes this particularly significant is that such attitudes are no longer confined to inherited social structures. They increasingly appear within gated residential complexes that pride themselves on education, professionalism, and progressive values. The physical distance between people may have narrowed as they live within the same gated complexes, use common facilities, and participate in community events. Yet social distance often remains intact. Old assumptions continue to survive beneath the veneer of modernity and progress. We may share addresses without sharing perspectives. We may inhabit the same community while unconsciously maintaining invisible boundaries between those who belong and those who merely serve. The challenge before urban India is not merely to build better infrastructure, but to build more inclusive communities. Modern urban spaces bring together people from vastly different social and economic backgrounds. The real test is not the quality of their infrastructure, but their capacity to treat every individual with dignity. Progress is not measured only by rising incomes, or professional success. It is also measured by our willingness to recognise the humanity of those whom society has traditionally placed on the other side of invisible social boundaries. Modern buildings can bring people closer together, but only mutual respect can make them a truly inclusive and compassionate community.

The writer is a founder of Kala - Krazy About Literature And Arts, is an author, speaker, coach, arbitrator, and strategy consultant

PIC TALK



A sadhu blows a horn amid folk singing during the Ambubachi Mela, at Bhutnathi in Guwahati

PHOTO: PTI



SANJAY
CHANDRA

2ND OPINION

Urban India has changed dramatically over the past few decades. Our cities are more prosperous, our homes more comfortable, and our lifestyles more modern than those of previous generations. Yet beneath this visible progress, some older attitudes continue to survive in ways that are often difficult to acknowledge. A few recent discussions within my own residential society brought this reality into sharp focus. One discussion centred around a domestic worker who had left a part-time arrangement to accept a full-time position elsewhere. The response from some residents was revealing. There was an expectation that the community should somehow regulate such movement, as though the worker's freedom to choose a better opportunity was negotiable.

The same discussion produced another suggestion that

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THE BJP'S STRATEGY OF POLITICAL CONSOLIDATION

The turmoil within the Shiv Sena, the exodus from the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) in Tamil Nadu and the recent strains within the All India Trinamool Congress (AITC) in West Bengal appear to reflect a broader pattern in contemporary Indian politics. Over the years, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) has demonstrated a remarkable ability not merely to defeat rivals electorally but to reshape the political landscape in ways that enhance its long-term dominance. The trend was evident in Maharashtra, where splits within the Shiv Sena and later the Nationalist Congress Party significantly altered the state's political arithmetic. In Assam, the Asom Gana Parishad gradually ceded political space to the BJP. Elsewhere, parties such as the

Shiromani Akali Dal in Punjab, Janata Dal (United) in Bihar and Janata Dal (Secular) in Karnataka have witnessed a decline in their bargaining power through varying political trajectories. A discernible pattern emerges: forge alliances with influential regional parties, expand organisational strength, attract key leaders from within allied ranks and gradually reduce the ally's political leverage. Even where partnerships survive, the balance of power increasingly favours the BJP.

The party has effectively redefined alliance politics. Coalitions are no longer enduring partnerships but temporary arrangements from which a dominant political force can advance towards greater predominance.

R NARAYANAN | MUMBAI

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Standard prescriptions saves lives

The decision to restrict the sale of cough syrups as over-the-counter (OTC) medicines is a welcome, though overdue, step. Across India, particularly in rural and underserved regions, pharmacies often serve as the first point of contact for healthcare. In the absence of adequate access to qualified doctors, pharmacists frequently advise patients on treatment and, at times, influence the choice of medicines.

While this fills a critical gap, it has also fostered a culture of self-medication that can result in inappropriate drug use and delayed diagnosis. Even patients who consult doctors often alter prescribed dosages or discontinue medicines prematurely once symptoms subside.

There is, therefore, a strong case for stricter enforcement of prescription requirements for a wider range of medicines. However, regulation alone will not suffice. The issue is rooted in inadequate healthcare access, uneven medical literacy and weak monitoring of medicine dispensing practices.

A lasting solution demands a balanced approach—strengthening regulatory oversight, expanding access to qualified healthcare professionals, improving public awareness and promoting responsible prescribing and dispensing.

A.P. THIRUVADI, CHENNAI

Building trust without militarising exams

The deployment of nearly 200 Indian Air Force sorties to transport NEET-UG retest question papers underscores the authorities' determination to restore public confidence following allegations of paper leaks and examination irregularities. While safeguarding the integrity of high-stakes examinations is essential, the exercise also raises important questions about the appropriate use of military resources. Viewed in this context, the use of military aircraft appears less a logistical necessity and more a symbolic confidence-building measure intended to reassure anxious students and parents. The armed forces are entrusted with the crucial responsibility of safeguarding national security and should ideally remain focused on their core operational mandate. Prestigious examinations such as the UPSC Civil Services Examination have maintained secrecy and credibility for decades through secure printing, sealed transportation and rigorous chain-of-custody procedures without military involvement. The long-term answer lies not in extraordinary interventions but in strengthening institutional safeguards, improving accountability and embracing secure technologies. Public trust in examinations will be restored not through military participation, but through transparent and reliable civil systems.

R.S. NARULA | PATIALA

Bullet trains need economic viability too

The government's decision to approve seven new high-speed rail corridors, even before the much-awaited Mumbai-Ahmedabad Bullet Train becomes operational, reflects India's growing ambition to build world-class infrastructure. The proposed routes promise dramatic reductions in travel time – from just 48 minutes between Mumbai and Pune to six hours between Delhi and Siliguri. Such projects have the potential to transform inter-city connectivity and boost economic activity.

Faster travel can improve productivity, facilitate business, promote tourism and strengthen regional integration. However, enthusiasm must be tempered with realism. High-speed rail networks require enormous capital investments, and their long-term sustainability depends on adequate passenger demand and financial viability. India already has several metro rail systems that continue to rely heavily on government support and have struggled to achieve projected ridership levels. The experience of urban transport projects offers valuable lessons for future infrastructure planning. Before embarking on multiple bullet train corridors, policymakers must carefully assess costs, demand projections and revenue potential. Infrastructure should not only inspire national pride but also deliver lasting economic value and public benefit.

YASHASWI BAIRAGI | UJJAIN

Yoga, soft power and the rise of India’s global influence

From an ancient practice nurtured by Indian sages to a worldwide movement embraced across continents, yoga has emerged as one of India’s most effective instruments of soft power. As the world grapples with stress, and diseases, this year’s theme, ‘Yoga for Healthy Ageing,’ underscores yoga’s universal relevance.



SANTHOSH MATHEW

On June 21,the City of Joy became the City of Yoga. Kolkata, a city celebrated for its culture, literature and spirituality, hosted India’s main celebration of the International Day of Yoga 2026. As thousands gathered on the banks of the Hooghly to celebrate this ancient Indian tradition, the event was

much more than a display of physical exercise. It was a celebration of India’s growing influence in the world through ideas rather than weapons, culture rather than coercion, and spirituality rather than superiority.The theme of this year’s International Day of Yoga, “Yoga for Healthy Ageing,” is especially relevant at a time when the world is facing rising lifestyle diseases, mental stress and an ageing population. Yoga offers a simple answer to many modern problems. It requires no expensive equipment, no costly medicines and no complicated technology. It only requires discipline, patience and a willingness to live in harmony with oneself and with nature.

Few could have imagined that an ancient Indian practice, developed thousands of years ago by sages and saints, would one day become one of India’s strongest diplomatic tools. That transformation began in September 2014 when Prime Minister Narendra Modi addressed the United Nations General Assembly and proposed that June 21 should be observed as the International Day of Yoga. His proposal received the support of 177 countries, one of the highest levels of support ever received for a UN resolution. Since then, yoga has travelled from the ashrams of India to parks, schools, universities and public squares across the globe.Today, millions perform yoga every June 21 in cities ranging from New York to Nairobi, London to Tokyo and Sydney to São Paulo. Even New York’s famous Times Square, once known only for giant advertisements and commercial activity, now welcomes thousands of yoga enthusiasts every year. It is a remarkable example of how Indian civilisation has quietly entered global public life.

This is where the idea of soft power becomes important.The late American political scientist Joseph S. Nye, who introduced the concept of “soft power,” argued that the most successful countries are not always those with the biggest armies or the strongest economies. Real influence comes from the ability to attract rather than force others. As Nye famously said, “It is not just whose army wins, but whose story wins.”India’s story today is increasingly told through yoga, Ayurveda, classical music, spirituality, cuisine, democracy and its global diaspora. Yoga has become one of the brightest symbols of that story. Every person who learns yoga anywhere in the world unknowingly becomes connected to India’s civilisational heritage.

Prime Minister Modi understood this potential early. His vision of India as a Vishwaguru is not based on military dominance or economic pressure. It is rooted in the belief that India can guide the world by sharing its timeless wisdom. Yoga has become the most visible expression of that vision. Unlike many forms of diplomacy that remain confined to conference halls and government meetings, yoga reaches ordinary people. It enters homes, schools, workplaces and communities. It creates goodwill that cannot be purchased with money.This may well become one of the defining diplomatic achievements of the Modi era. Governments often spend billions on public relations campaigns to improve their national image. India has achieved something unique by promoting a cultural tradition that people willingly embrace because it improves their health and quality of life.

Yoga is also closely linked with what may be called Modi’s Dharma Diplomacy. This is not about promoting one religion over another. It is about presenting India’s ancient spiritual traditions as universal values that belong to all humanity. Yoga is practised today by people belonging to every religion and every nationality. It has crossed political boundaries because its message is universal. It speaks of harmony between body and mind, between humanity and nature, and between individual well-being and collective welfare.India’s spiritual teachers have always viewed



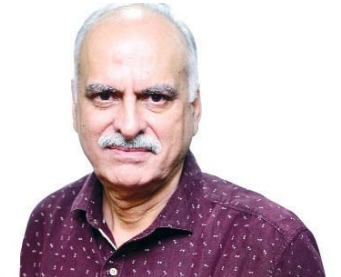
yoga in this universal spirit. Sri Ramakrishna Paramahansa taught that all religions ultimately lead to the same truth. Swami Vivekananda introduced yoga to the modern world as a scientific method of self-development rather than a religious ritual.Sri Aurobindo expanded it into Integral Yoga,combining spiritual growth with social transformation. Their ideas continue to shape India’s cultural image abroad.

Another remarkable example of India’s soft power under Prime Minister Modi is Mann Ki Baat. Since its launch in 2014, the monthly radio programme has become one of the world’s most successful experiments in public communication. Instead of political speeches or election campaigns, the programme highlights ordinary citizens, innovators, teachers, farmers, students, environmental activists and social workers. Their stories inspire millions and create a sense of national participation.Like yoga, Mann Ki Baat works through persuasion rather than pressure. It reminds people that communication is not merely about delivering messages but about building trust. In many ways, it has become another instrument of India’s soft power by projecting a positive image of the country and celebrating grassroots achievements. Together, Yoga and Mann Ki Baat demonstrate how communication and culture can become powerful diplomatic assets.

INDIA’S SUCCESS IN PROMOTING YOGA ALSO CARRIES AN IMPORTANT LESSON FOR INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS. INFLUENCE IN THE TWENTY-FIRST CENTURY WILL NOT BE MEASURED ONLY BY MISSILES, MILITARY ALLIANCES OR ECONOMIC SANCTIONS. IT WILL ALSO DEPEND ON CULTURE, EDUCATION, INNOVATION, IDEAS AND VALUES

The writer is Professor at Centre For South Asian Studies, School of International Studies & Social Sciences Pondicherry Central University

Factionalism, drift and decline: Congress’s J and K challenge



ANIL ANAND

Picking up from what one had written months back in this column on the endangered but truly-portrayed Nehruvian model, based on plurality, secularism and multiculturalism, in demoted and disintegrated erstwhile state of Jammu and Kashmir, the developing circumstances warrant further delving into the matter. There is a circumstantial transition, from then to now, with shifting of roles from the Narendra Modi government authoring the shake-up in the constitutional scheme of things, in fulfillment of their political and ideological agenda, to focus on the misdeanours of Congress.

The Grand-Old-Party (GOP) which should have stood ground to safeguard the Nehruvian model in the sensitive and strategic Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir has not only dithered, faltered and fallen flat, the All India Congress Committee and its spearheads are much to be blamed alongside the PCC leadership of time to time. Significance of J and K was much high in the Nehruvian scheme of things which despite having some grey areas and controversial aspects saw democracy strengthening in the ultra-diverse state with three distinct regions- Jammu, Kashmir and Ladakh.

Right from the 1975 Indira Gandhi-Sheikh Abdullah accord which led to the rehabilitation of the Sher-e-Kashmir (as the Sheikh is popularly called in Kashmir) with Congress pulling down its own government, chief minister Syed Mir Qasim resigned to make way for a Sheikh-led government of National Conference, has no parallel in the history of Indian democracy. No doubt, the national interest under the gaze of the Nehruvian model, must have been the guiding force behind rehabilitation of the Sheikh, without any doubt the tallest leader of Jammu and Kashmir. It spelt disaster for Congress which the party strategists not only failed to contain but followed it up with disastrous approach coupled with fueling factionalism, egged on from New Delhi.

Even the tallest of the leaders such as Mufti Mohammed Sayeed, who subsequently parted ways with the party as result of factionalism, and Mr Ghulam Nabi Azad, despite their towering stature, turned a blind eye towards protecting the Nehurivan model or arresting the factionalism. Instead, the leaders played their games to achieve personal milestones. The Congress suffered all this while and is continuing to do so. After the 1975 model, the two developments taking place three decades later, were a direct reflection of the mindset of the decision makers in the Congress’s higher echelons and exposed the inner weaknesses of the party in terms of leadership.

First the appointment of Prof Saif-ud-Din Soz, who had his political roots in National Conference, as PCC chief, and more recently Mr Tariq Hamid Karra, who came from Peoples Democratic Party (PDP). The results are for everyone to see with Congress having lost its grassroots character, in Jammu to BJP and in Kashmir to National Conference and PDP. The lack of credible leadership, either due to over-arching influence of the veteran leaders of the yore who checked this growth, or attempts by a coterie to dominate and not give space to new leadership, has become the Congress’s bane. Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha, Mr Rahul Gandhi’s Bharat Jodo Yatra evoked a tremendous response among the people cutting across regions. It kindled a hope for the Congress’s revival not only in Jammu, where it still has pockets of influence and following, but also Kashmir. The subsequent mishandling of the party affairs and total lack of interest by the AICC in containing factionalism, has pushed the Congress in J & K to the crossroads. Both Mr Soz and Mr Karra, coming from different political backgrounds and without any mass-base of their own, thrived on the backing of the Gandhi family.

However, both of them failed to command the organisation for different reasons and capping the factionalism. This led to, as is the case under current PCC chief Mr Karra despite full backing of the top leadership, total demoralisation in the organisation.What has made the matter worst is approach of the central leadership, including the AICC in-charges appointed from time to time, to perpetuate the ineffective system and not disturb the incumbent UT PCC chief so as not to antagonise his source of power in Delhi. Least the present AICC in charge Syed Naseer Hussain could have done was to convince the PCC chief to carry everyone along. The vested interest in the Jammu and Kashmir Congress, have thrived.

A fresh round of “open-war” has ensued between factions claiming to be in the vanguard of saving the Congress ideology based on the Nehruvian spirit, and those far removed from it. The sudden appointment of Mr Karra, on the eve of 2024 assembly elections replacing Mr Vikar Rasool Wani, who has since launched the latest tirade seeking central intervention, wrong selection of candidates (allegedly at the behest of some influential local Congress leaders with the patronage of the then AICC in-charge Mr Bharat Singh Solanki) and mishandling, has pushed the UT Congress to the throes of serious crisis.

The one big fallout is that despite being a partner in the ruling alliance with National Conference, though giving outside support, Congress is not in the reckoning of the Omar Abdullah government. Latest example of this was the convening of a meeting of the ruling alliance MLAs to which the Congress legislators were not invited. At stake in Jammu and Kashmir is the core of the Nehruvian ideology and model. And the Congress is morally bound to protect whatever of it is left by seriously taking its organisational matters. There is no space for further experimentation as it has, coupled with personal whims and fancies of the leaders, already considerably harmed the party which has an important role to play not only nationally but in Jammu and Kashmir as it is the only party with a pan-J and K spread. Since a perceived Rahul Gandhi-acolyte is in the centre of the storm, and, perhaps, no one dare advise him on J & K Congress affairs, he must come out and act decisively. The vested interests seem to be using his name as a shield to allow the system to perpetuate. It is not too late for Mr Gandhi to order an internal probe into the ticket distribution during 2024 Lok Sabha and later J and K assembly elections which might give him interesting insights. More importantly the AICC in-charges should be appointed, in all states and UTs, with a strong message of accountability.

Congress has a vital role to play in Jammu and Kashmir to balance the current mode of politics based on BJP’s (with its ever expanding but frustratingly saturated domain) communally divisive framework, and unabashed fanatical regionalism of the regional parties such as National Conference and PDP. No scope for delay or else new and more-divisive and regional forces are threatening to raise their ugly head.



The writer is a political and national affairs analyst



ASHWANI MAHAJAN

several decades. Once a major contributor to India’s GDP-accounting for 10.5 percent in 1960-West Bengal’s share had fallen to just 5.6 percent by 2024-25. Per capita income tells a similar story: from 127.5 percent of the national average in 1960 to only 79.5 percent today. Much of this slide is attributed to weak industrial policy. Older industries faded away, new investment never arrived in sufficient scale, and recurring labor unrest pushed both factories and corporate headquarters out of Kolkata toward other states.

Critics argue that years of populist spending and appeasement-driven politics turned the state budget away from development and toward consumption. As growth lagged, so did revenue, and the gap was increasingly filled by borrowing. Public debt, which was about 22 percent of state GDP in 1990, has since climbed to around 38 percent, placing West Bengal among India’s most

indebted states. The outgoing Mamata Banerjee government’s interim budget for 2026-27 had projected a fiscal deficit of 3.5 percent-a figure the BJP repeatedly attacked during its campaign. That criticism now puts pressure on the new administration to rein in spending and stabilise the debt trajectory.

At the same time, the new finance minister can’t simply cut welfare spending outright. Direct Benefit Transfer programs are expected to continue and even expand, though with tighter targeting to curb leakages and waste.

Mirroring the approach taken by the central government and other BJP-led states, West Bengal increased outlays on roads, industrial parks, logistics hubs, ports, waterways, and urban development.

One striking figure from the outgoing government’s interim budget has drawn particular attention: ₹5,713.61 crore allocated to the Department of Minority Affairs and Madrasas Education.

Among Indian states, only Telangana comes close to matching this in absolute terms, though its per-capita spending on minority residents is actually higher despite a smaller total figure-and Telangana, too, is governed by a non-BJP party. More notably, this single state department’s allocation dwarfs the spending earmarked for MSMEs (roughly ₹1,250 crore) and for industry and commerce combined (around



₹1,484 crore). It also exceeds the entire Union Ministry of Minority Affairs budget for 2026-27, which stood at just ₹3,400 crore nationally. For critics, this disparity raises pointed questions about whether the previous government’s spending priorities favored political constituencies over productive, job-creating sectors of the economy.

Industrial revival is to be a centerpiece of the new budget. After decades of deindustrialisation, the BJP leadership has signalled intent to build a more business-friendly climate-freeing up land for industry, reviving dormant manufacturing clusters, and courting investment in steel, chemicals, engineering, electronics, and food processing.

There’s also talk of actively wooing back

investors who left the state in earlier years. Beyond attracting capital, the government is expected to prioritise job creation through large-scale recruitment drives, skilling programs, and apprenticeships, while also extending support to small and cottage industries and new startups.

Agriculture and rural development remain central to the state’s economy and have receive renewed focus-expanded irrigation, stronger food processing capacity, better agricultural value chains, improved cold storage and logistics, and easier market access for farmers. Given that agriculture will continue to employ a large share of the population for years to come, this sector isn’t likely to be sidelined even as industrial policy takes center stage.

On the welfare front, the new government appears set to honor a campaign promise to double the monthly cash transfer to women from ₹1,500 to ₹3,000. However, there are widespread perceptions that the existing scheme suffers from significant leakage and fraudulent enrollment under the previous administration.

A re-verification of beneficiaries is expected, which would likely shrink the total number of recipients-but with the same budget pool stretched across fewer, genuine beneficiaries, the actual payout per person could rise meaningfully. Healthcare policy is also poised for a major shift with the planned rollout of the central govern-

ment’s Ayushman Bharat scheme in the state. Ayushman Bharat, now in its eighth year nationally, offers free treatment up to ₹5 lakh per family, with the central government covering 60 percent of costs and the state covering the rest. Until now, West Bengal had run its own parallel scheme, Swasthya Sathi, covering all 2.45 crore families in the state entirely from the state budget. Under the new arrangement, roughly 1.43 crore poor families would shift to Ayushman Bharat, with the center picking up most of the bill, while the remaining roughly one crore families continue to be covered through state funds. Between December 2016 and October 2025, the state had spent about ₹13,156 crore extending hospitalisation benefits to a crore beneficiaries. With central funding now offsetting much of this cost, the state stands to free up resources for other priorities.

Taken together, the budget balances fiscal discipline with continued welfare commitments: trimming wasteful spending, pushing harder on infrastructure and industry, doubling direct cash support to women, and shifting healthcare costs partly onto the central government-all while trying to chart a more sustainable fiscal path than the one the state has followed for decades.

The writer is National Co-convenor, Swadeshi Jagaran Manch and Former Professor, PGDAV College, University of Delhi



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Order Order

Access to clean water a fundamental right, says HC; flags scarcity in Maharashtra



Access to clean and potable water is a fundamental right, the Bombay High Court on Monday said while expressing concern over water scarcity in the State, and sought to know from the Government when the issue would be resolved.

A bench of Justices AS Gadgari and Kamal Khata was hearing a bunch of petitions over the issue of deaths of infants, pregnant and lactating mothers due to malnutrition in the tribal Melghat area of Amravati district in the Vidarbha region.

The court was informed that amid soaring summer temperatures, the area was severely affected due to a shortage of clean and potable water. In the last hearing in April, the court was informed that 13 persons had died in the area due to consumption of contaminated water.

The Government informed the bench on Monday that potable water tankers were being provided periodically, but the petitioners said the supply was erratic.

The high court then said the Government was not doing any "favours" by providing water tankers.

"Access to clean and potable water is a fundamental right enshrined in the Constitution, and the Government has a duty to provide the same to all its citizens. (PTI)

Don't want to open pandora's box with regard to proceedings of collegium: SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

"We don't want to open a pandora's box with regard to the proceedings of the collegium," the Supreme Court said on Monday while refusing to entertain a petition filed by a judicial officer from Himachal Pradesh.

The petitioner had approached the apex court alleging that names of officers junior to him were recommended for appointment as judges of the Himachal Pradesh High Court.

A bench of Justices BV Nagarathna and Joymalya Bagchi observed these are matters where ultimately it is the subjective satisfaction of the collegium of the high court.

"Can on the judicial side, the Supreme Court say to the collegium you do this or you do that and you consider the name? It can't be done," the bench said.

"On the judicial side, we



don't want to open a pandora's box with regard to the proceedings of the high court collegium or the Supreme Court collegium," it said. Senior advocate Balbir Singh, appearing for the petitioner, said the petitioner is the senior-most judicial officer in the State and has around 10 more years of service left.

The bench observed that merely because someone is high in seniority does not mean that he is entitled to be recommended for elevation. After the top court showed

RTI: Supreme Court sends a strong message



RANJIT KUMAR SINHA

The Supreme Court recently refused to grant anticipatory bail to an RTI (Right to Information) activist and his associate from Punjab. The accused were facing charges for allegedly obstructing a public servant and interfering with a Government road construction project.

The Apex Court dismissed the activist's pre-arrest bail plea. It upheld the order of the Punjab and Haryana High Court, which had also denied them pre-arrest protection.

During the hearing, the Supreme Court made strong oral observations regarding the growing misuse of self-styled activism to disrupt public infrastructure development.

Some of the Key Oral Observations by the Supreme Court reported in the media were that "RTI activism has become a new business. The Central Government has issued funds, and it will take care of the construction of the road. You are nobody."

Labelling the unnecessary interference as highly improper, the Bench added, "So-called RTI activist! Yellow journalism."

"Who are you to monitor the construction of all these roads? Are you some superior authority or what?" This was another remark by the judges, who questioned the standing of the petitioners to block developmental projects.

The bench indicated that public infrastructure projects are subject to monitoring and evaluation by designated, competent Government



authorities and engineers, rather than private individuals.

The case stems from an FIR registered in Batala (Gurdaspur district, Punjab). The prosecution alleged that the activist and his associate not only obstructed the ₹57-crore central Government-funded road project but also physically assaulted the project supervisor, caused injuries, and used caste-based slurs against the labourers at the site.

The dismissal of the Special Leave Petition on June 15, 2026, by the Supreme Court has given a clear message and warning to the public, administrative bodies, and self-styled advocates that "RTI Activism Cannot Be a Profession or Business." It rejected "Sensationalism" as Advocacy.

The Apex Court is warning that transparency tools must not be weaponised for personal gain, coercion, or financial arm-twisting under the guise of public interest.

By explicitly using the term "yellow journalism," the bench is signalling its disapproval of activists who use loud, threatening, or sensational tactics simply to create administrative hurdles rather than seeking genuine legal remedies.

The Top Court is making it clear that specialised technical work, like road construction, is the domain of qualified professionals. Private individuals do not have the expertise or the legal standing to judge engineering quality on the spot.

The remark, "The Central Government has issued funds; it will take care of the construction," emphasises that the State has its own auditing and monitoring mechanisms. Citizen oversight cannot replace or hijack State execution.

Further, the Supreme Court is giving a message that RTI Activists Are Not Parallel Authorities. The apex court is firmly establishing that holding an RTI card or calling oneself an activist does not grant anyone special policing powers or legal immunity.

It is signalling that individual grievances or suspicion of corruption cannot be used as a tool to physically halt massive public welfare and infrastructure projects that benefit the larger community.

Also, the Label of "Activist" is No Shield Against Criminal Liability. The Court's refusal of anticipatory bail in a case involving physical assault

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

Police encounter in Bihar: Plea in SC seeks CBI probe, constitution of expert committee

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A plea has been filed in the Supreme Court seeking the constitution of an independent expert committee under the chairmanship of a former apex court judge to inquire into the alleged "extra-judicial killing" of Bharat Bhushan Tiwari in a police encounter in Bihar.

The plea has also sought a probe by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), claiming the case warrants a prompt independent and impartial investigation.

The killing of Tiwari, a resident of Bilauti village in Bihar's Bhojpur district, on June 17, has triggered a row with his family claiming that he had surrendered and discarded his weapon before being fatally shot by the police. The Bihar Government had on Saturday announced a judicial inquiry into the incident.

On Monday, advocate Vishal Tiwari, who has filed the plea, mentioned the matter for urgent listing before a bench of Justices B V Nagarathna and Joymalya Bagchi.

"Mention before the registrar," the bench told Tiwari. In his plea, Tiwari has said that in a democratic society, the police cannot be allowed to become a punishing authority as this power is only vested in the judiciary.



Referring to the Bihar incident, the petition said it has triggered a debate over police procedures and the use of force during encounters.

"The incidents of extra-judicial killings have increased in the past few years, which is a big challenge to the rule of law," the plea said, claiming that recently, police encounters have increased sharply across Bihar. It claimed that the killing of Tiwari appeared to be "suspicious".

It referred to a 2014 apex court verdict which had issued a slew of guidelines to be followed in matters of investigating police encounters which have led to death or grievous injury.

The plea said, "Fake encounters or deaths/murder of accused in police custody/jail weakens the rule of law, and if these killings will be justified by saying that the killed accused was a gangster or having antecedents of criminal cases, then it would be leading the society towards the law of 'eye for an eye'".

COMPUTER TEACHER ACQUITTED IN POCSO CASE



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Palghar

A special court in Palghar has acquitted a 48-year-old computer teacher accused of outraging the modesty of a minor girl in 2018, citing material contradictions in the victim's testimony.

Additional Sessions Judge AR Rahane noted in his order on June 19 that despite CCTV cameras near the spot, the prosecution produced no footage.

Highlighting discrepancies in the complainant's Statements, the judge observed: "It is apparent that the victim has made material improvements in her version regarding time, commencement, and aftermath of the alleged incident."

Palghar Police had registered an FIR against the teacher under section 354 (assault or criminal force used against a woman with the intention or knowledge that it will outrage her modesty) of the Indian Penal Code (IPC) and the POCSO Act for allegedly kissing the minor in his computer class on February 12, 2018.

"The victim has omitted the above-cited material facts in her report and supplementary Statement, but, she has deposed them before the court for the first time. As her evidence appears doubtful, her testimony cannot be relied upon," the judge stated.

The judge also noted that the spot panch has acted as a panch witness in about 50 cases, which means that he is a habitual panch.

"He has deposed that there is a glass partition at the spot, which is a computer class. He has admitted that CCTV cameras are installed near the spot. No such CCTV footage is produced on record by the prosecution. The prosecution's evidence on record does not meet the standard of proof expected in criminal prosecution to establish the charge against the accused," the court said.

Kerala Industries Secy tenders apology to HC in contempt case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kochi

Industries Department Principal Secretary Mohammed Haneesh on Monday appeared before the Kerala High Court and tendered an unconditional apology after it warned of coercive action in a contempt case related to the KSCDC corruption probe.

Haneesh appeared before the bench of Justice A Badharudheen, which was considering a contempt peti-



tion filed by Kollam native Kadakampally Manoj alleging non-compliance with court directions regarding the grant of sanction to the CBI to prosecute Kerala State Cashew Development Corporation (KSCDC) officials in a corruption case.

Haneesh had challenged

an earlier order of the single judge directing his personal appearance before the court. However, a division bench dismissed his plea.

On June 19, the court directed Haneesh to appear in person and warned that failure to do so would compel it to take coercive steps, including issuing an arrest warrant.

In compliance with the order, Haneesh appeared before the court at 10.15 am along with the Government pleader.

Allahabad HC declines out-of-turn hearing on plea seeking probe into Ram Temple offerings row

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

The Allahabad High Court on Monday refused to accord an out-of-turn hearing on a plea seeking an inquiry into the alleged irregularities in the management of offerings at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya, observing there was no urgency in the matter.

The plea is listed at serial number 392 among 529 fresh cases before the Lucknow bench of the



court on Monday. A vacation bench comprising Justice Pankaj Bhatia and Justice Amitabh Kumar Rai

the matter out of turn. The bench also orally observed that since the State Government had already taken cognisance of the issue, there was no urgency at this stage.

Petitioner Mohit Ashok has sought an independent probe into the alleged misappropriation of funds received as offerings at the Ram Temple. He has also sought a direction for an audit of the matter by the Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) of India.

New policy formulated for evaluation of private CBSE students in Gulf countries: Centre to SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Centre on Monday informed the Supreme Court that the CBSE has come up with a new policy for the evaluation of private students, who were affected by the cancellation of Class XII board examination in Gulf countries due to the recent Iran-US war.

A bench of Justices SVN Bhatti and Vipul M Pancholi was told by Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Centre and the CBSE, that a fresh all-India policy has been framed to address

the concerns of similarly situated students affected by the cancellation of examinations in the Gulf countries due to the regional conflict.

Mehta said that under the new policy, which was notified on June 21, a distinct formula for evaluating the private students appearing for the board exam was developed.

Giving details, Mehta said for the subjects for which examination could not be held, the performance will be assessed based on the marks obtained by the private candidate in Class X and the last attempted Class XII board



examination. He said under the new policy, subjects for which the examination was cancelled, the marks would be computed as 40 per cent of theory marks scored in the Class X board examination

and 60 per cent of theory marks scored in the last attempted Class XII board examination.

Mehta explained that there were two categories of students who were largely

affected due to the cancellation of the examinations across seven Gulf countries, and they were regular school students and private candidates.

He said that the unique challenge posed by private candidates was that they had no school to supply internal assessment records such as quarterly, half-yearly and pre-board examination marks, which were the very basis on which the original March 27 evaluation scheme was designed to evaluate results.

The top court was hearing a plea filed by one Pransu

jigarkumar Patel, a private candidate from Al Jubail, Saudi Arabia, who had challenged CBSE's failure to declare his Class XII improvement examination results as per the original evaluation scheme.

The petitioner had contended that while CBSE's March 27 assessment scheme covered regular students, no clarification had been issued regarding private candidates appearing for improvement examinations, resulting in his result being withheld as "Result Later" (RL).

He had argued that the omission was arbitrary and

discriminatory, adversely affecting his higher education prospects.

Patel had claimed that in his case, Physics and Chemistry examinations were held, but Mathematics, English and Computer Science papers were cancelled.

He had claimed that in the two papers of Physics and Chemistry in which he appeared, the evaluation was done on actual marks, while in the three cancelled subjects, the evaluation was done under the new formula, which was notified on June 21.

PIOTECH

Aadhaar App crosses 3.1 crore downloads in 5 months of launch



The new mobile application of Aadhaar has crossed 31 million (3.1 crore) downloads within five months of its launch, an official statement said on Monday. Almost 4 million users have updated their mobile numbers through the new Aadhaar App, and around 8.5 lakh people have used it to update their address. "The Aadhaar App is witnessing a robust acceptance among people across India, with over 31 million downloads since it was launched less than 5 months back. The growing adoption reflects increasing resident confidence in the App for bringing services at their fingertips, " Aadhaar custodian, The Unique Identification Authority of India, said in a statement. The new Aadhaar App enables various services, including updating mobile number and address directly on smartphones. It also features sharing contact details digitally using an in-built QR, which does away with the need to carry visiting cards. "The app has several pro-people features, including biometric lock/unlock in a single click, face verification for proof of presence, authentication history, and a QR-based editable contact card for easy sharing of contact information instead of physical visiting cards. It also allows the download of e-Aadhaar and facilitates easy appointment booking online for visiting Aadhaar Seva Kendras (ASKs), among others," the statement said. The new App also enables hotel check-ins through Offline Verification Seeking Entity's (OVSE) QR code scanning without the need for submitting a physical Aadhaar copy. "It (new app) facilitates hospitals admissions, visitor management, event entries, identity verification of gig workers and service partners among many such use cases," the statement said.

(PTI)

Cyberattacks surge amid India's holiday booking rush



Cybercriminals are heavily targeting India's travel and hospitality sector to exploit the holiday booking rush, with organisations facing significantly more cyberattacks than the global average, according to a report. Indian organisations faced an average of 3,296 cyberattacks per week over the past six months, compared to the global average of 2,085, the report by Check Point Research said. The hospitality, travel, and recreation sector recorded 2,291 average weekly attacks per organisation in May 2026, marking a 24 per cent year-on-year increase. In contrast, the global year-over-year rise across all industries was merely 2 per cent. "This is not a general uptick in cybercrime that happens to touch travel. It is a deliberate, seasonal intensification targeting an industry that processes enormous volumes of personal and financial data precisely when people are distracted, rushing, and eager to secure a good deal. "The risks are amplified in India, where 86 per cent of malicious files observed in the last month were delivered via the web. This underscores how fake travel websites, fraudulent booking portals, and malicious online advertisements have become some of the most effective tools for cybercriminals targeting travellers," the Check Point report said. In May 2026 alone, 47,318 new travel – related domains were registered, a 33 per cent increase from April and 19 per cent higher than May 2025. The report noted that one in every 112 of these domains is already classified as malicious or suspicious, with many remaining dormant until they are activated to exploit peak travel web traffic. Threat actors are actively impersonating trusted online travel booking platforms. Check Point identified active phishing campaigns using fake domains mimicking Booking.com, Airbnb, and Skyscanner, alongside bulk-registration campaigns impersonating brands like American Express and Lloyds Travel Choice.

(PTI)

How Modi's India climbed the technology stack

From UPI to AI: How Prime Minister Modi's 12 years changed India's tech story



NISHANT SAHDEV

In 2005, American journalist Thomas Friedman published *The World is Flat*, a book that captured the optimism of an age when globalisation appeared unstoppable. Technology was dissolving borders, supply chains, and talent could move through digitally. India emerged as one of the great beneficiaries of that world. That could be seen for example Bangalore's technology parks. For much of the next two decades, that was India's technological identity. We supplied services but owned few platforms. We assembled products but imported the critical components. We participated in the digital economy, but largely on terms set elsewhere. Today, however, the world that Friedman described no longer exists. Technology is becoming more strategic, more vertically integrated, and more geopolitical. Semiconductors, artificial intelligence, cloud infrastructure, digital payments, satellite networks, and data centers are increasingly treated not merely as commercial products but as instruments of national power. Nations are not only competing for market share; they are competing for control over the technological stacks that underpin economic and military influence. The central technology story of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's twelve years in office is India's attempt to move from participating in global technology systems to building them. The COVID-19 pandemic exposed the fragility of global supply chains. The intensifying rivalry between the United States and China changed technology into a geopolitical battleground. Governments and corporations alike began searching for alternatives to concentrated manufacturing networks and single-country dependencies. Suddenly, resilience mattered as much as efficiency. India found itself presented with a rare strategic opening. Rather than positioning itself solely as a large consumer market, New Delhi increasingly sought to establish India as a trusted technology partner and manufacturing destination. The objective was technological relevance in a world where infrastructure and geopolitics had become inseparable. Perhaps nowhere is this clearer than in India's Digital Public Infrastructure. While many Western economies allowed digital identity and payment systems to evolve primarily through competing private firms, India chose a different path. The result was an ecosystem built around Aadhaar, digital verification systems, and most importantly, the Unified Payments Interface (UPI). UPI has fundamentally altered how India transacts. Digital payments that once required



multiple intermediaries now occur almost instantly. From a roadside tea vendor to a small manufacturer in Coimbatore, millions of Indians now participate in a common digital financial ecosystem. More importantly, UPI demonstrated that digital infrastructure could function as a public utility, like roads or railways. By reducing conflict and lowering barriers to participation, it accelerated formalisation and digital adoption at extraordinary scale. Encouraged by this success, policymakers are now attempting to apply similar principles elsewhere through initiatives such as the Open Network for Digital Commerce (ONDC), which seeks to create open and interoperable digital marketplaces rather than closed platforms. Yet success also brings new questions. The sustainability of the UPI model remains under debate, particularly under a zero-MDR framework that limits monetisation opportunities for payment providers. More broadly, as Governments assume greater responsibility for building digital rails, policymakers must ensure that public infrastructure remains a platform for innovation rather than a substitute for it. The challenge for India is not merely building digital infrastructure but preserving the entrepreneurial dynamism that makes such infrastructure valuable in the first place. If Digital Public Infrastructure represents one layer of *Atmanirbharta*, manufacturing represents another. For decades, India's greatest technological weakness was its inability to translate engineering talent into industrial capacity. The country excelled at services but struggled in mass-scale manufacturing. The Production Linked Incentive (PLI) scheme represented an effort to change that equation. By incentivising companies to manufacture within India, the Government sought to change the country from a market for electronics into a producer of them. The results have been visible. Smartphone manufacturing has expanded significantly, with major firms increasing production and exports from Indian facilities.

Electronics have emerged as one of India's fastest – growing export categories, marking a change from the situation that existed barely a decade ago. Yet manufacturing smartphones, important as it is, represents only part of the challenge. The true center of gravity in modern technology lies inside the semiconductor. Semiconductors have become the strategic resource of the twenty-first century. They power smartphones, cloud servers, fighter aircraft, autonomous systems, telecommunications networks, and artificial intelligence models. Control over semiconductor production increasingly determines which nations capacity in technological frontier. Recognising this reality, the Modi Government launched the India Semiconductor Mission, seeking to establish a domestic ecosystem capable of supporting advanced electronics manufacturing. The strategic logic is undeniable. The practical challenges are high. Semiconductor fabrication is arguably the most sophisticated industrial process humanity has ever developed. It requires extraordinary precision, uninterrupted power, ultra-pure water, specialised supply chains, and highly skilled engineering talent built over decades. India has made meaningful progress, particularly in packaging, assembly, and semiconductor ecosystem development. Investments are now underway. Yet there remains a difference between participating in semiconductor supply chains and competing with global leaders such as Taiwan, South Korea, or the US in fabrication. This distinction matters because technological sovereignty is not achieved through announcements. It is achieved through capabilities. The same reality applies to AI. If data defined the previous decade, compute is defining this one. AI has introduced a new hierarchy of power based not simply on software expertise but on access to computational infrastructure. Training AI systems requires enormous quantities of specialised hard-



ware, energy, and capital. Recognising this challenge, the Government launched the India AI Mission, seeking to expand access to computing resources for startups, researchers, and developers. This is an important step. But it would be premature to conclude that India has solved the problem of AI sovereignty. The country remains heavily dependent on imported GPUs and foreign semiconductor supply chains. Most frontier AI development continues to be concentrated among a small number of firms with access to enormous computational resources. India has made progress in democratising access to AI tools, but it has yet to produce a globally influential frontier model ecosystem comparable to the industry's leading players. We are democratising access to the tools. We do not yet own the forge. That distinction may ultimately define the next decade of technology policy. The same pattern can be observed beyond Earth's atmosphere. For much of independent India's history, space was synonymous with ISRO. Yet the future space economy is unlikely to be driven by Governments alone. Recognising this, policymakers opened the sector to greater private participation through institutional reforms and the establishment of IN-SPaCE. The result has been the emergence of a new generation of Indian space startups seeking to build launch systems, satellite technologies, and commercial space services. Taken together, these developments reveal the logic behind India's technology strategy over the last twelve years. This is more than a story of digitisation or Government programs. It is the story of a nation attempting to move upward through the technology stack. From digital payments to semiconductor manufacturing, from AI infrastructure to commercial space, India is trying to build capabilities that were once assumed to belong exclusively to a handful of advanced economies. The project remains unfinished. India's semiconductor ambitions face formidable obstacles. Its AI ecosystem remains dependent on foreign hardware, and its digital infrastructure must confront questions of sustainability, competition, and governance. Yet history is often defined less by achievements than by direction. For much of the globalisation era, India supplied the talent that helped build the technological systems of others. The ambition of the Modi years has been more consequential: to ensure that India owns part of the infrastructure on which the next technological age will run. Whether that ambition succeeds remains uncertain. What is no longer uncertain is that India's technological aspirations have changed. The world may no longer be flat. The question now is whether India can help build the terrain.

(The writer is a physicist at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill and a columnist on AI, infrastructure and global systems)

The fable lesson: Why India must play its AI market card



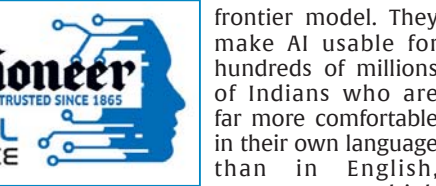
ROHIT YADAV

For the last three years, India followed a simple strategy on artificial intelligence. It did not try to build the world's most powerful AI models. Instead, it focused on building smart applications using models made by others. India has a huge pool of tech talent, strong digital infrastructure, and a habit of adopting new technology quickly and cheaply. That is why it eventually become a place where raw AI capabilities turned into practical, valuable applications for farmers, small businesses, hospitals and everyday users. The AI models themselves, mostly built in American and Chinese labs, were treated like electricity or the internet. Something you simply plug into, without worrying too much about who built it. This month, it was a comfortable assumption put to the test. Anthropic, a large U.S AI firm, was instructed by the U.S Government to block foreign users, such as Indians, from accessing its latest, most powerful model Fable. The message was loud and clear. Powerful AI is no longer just a product you buy. It is now treated as a strategic asset, something a Government can switch on or off in the name of national security. The same week, a report revealed the depths to which AI has already seeped into the Indian work life. It found that 41 per cent of Indian workers use AI almost every day, higher than 26 per cent in China and 19 per cent in the United States. That is why the episode had the attention of many Indian founders and businesses. None of this means India should panic, or shut its doors to the world. It's merely a shift from the days of energy and semiconductors becoming a source of national strategy to AI. India needs to respond calmly, using the strengths it already has, rather than reacting out of fear.

The real lesson is about leverage, not going it alone One can see the episode and easily deduce that India needs its own frontier AI model which is to be trained entirely on Indian soil so as no other country can be able to cut it off from the Indian frontier model. That instinct is understandable. But it should not be India's main takeaway. Building a model that can compete with the world's best requires far more computing power than India

currently has access to. It also requires a domestic chip industry that simply doesn't exist yet, and will take many years to develop. Trying to match the frontier on that timeline would pull money and attention away from where India's real strength lies. That strength is the size of India's market. India is the largest market for AI users and developers globally other than the United States and China. It is also the second largest contributor to AI projects on open platforms such as GitHub. No global AI company can afford to ignore a market this size. India's internet users population of a billion plus, its huge developer community and its rapid growing digital economy are essential to their own investments for every big AI lab. This need runs both ways. It is this mutual need, more than any dream of total self reliance, that gives a country like India real bargaining power. Indian entrepreneurs have already made this point clearly. Saket Dandotia, founder of the Indian AI startup Onetab.ai, saw the recent restriction affect his own business directly. He stated that diversification buys time, but it does not buy independence. That single line sums up the real challenge well. Using AI models from different companies and countries is a smart, necessary step, and India is right to encourage it. To its credit, India's Government already seems to understand this difference. India has at the recent Global Meetings made the argument for access to powerful AI models to be broad and equitable across countries. This is not a request for charity. It is about protecting the hospitals, banks, and public services that increasingly run on digital systems, and keeping them safe from cyber threats. Seek global consensus for a reliable, guaranteed connectivity as a common cause, incrementally create sufficient power within India so that no single limitation cripples it.

What building strength at home should really mean India's current approach here is already sensible, and worth building on rather than replacing. The India AI Mission already offers computing power to startups and researchers at around ₹65 an hour, a small fraction of the global rate of \$2.5 to \$3. This is the right instinct for a country still building its AI ecosystem. It focuses on giving more people access, rather than chasing prestige projects. Indian homegrown language models are designed specifically for Indian languages and their usage, which differs from the role of a



frontier model. They make AI usable for hundreds of millions of Indians who are far more comfortable in their own language than in English, no matter which company's technology runs underneath. These models are not required to outperform the best AI in challenging reasoning tests. They only have to function effectively in agriculture, classrooms and welfare programmes; in many instances they do effectively already. The right way to think about this is not sovereignty versus dependence, but balanced, diversified strength. India should continue to create cost – effective and locally available AI tools that align with their unique strengths and expertise, particularly in areas like agriculture, regional language instruction, public administration, and financial inclusion. At the same time, it should keep widening its partnerships with multiple AI companies and countries, so that one country's decision can never strand Indian businesses, hospitals, or Government systems. This is made apparent with a quick look at logistics. India never came to a halt for investing in highways as it also built railways and waterways. It created all three, for resilience. AI policy should follow the same logic, mixing open-source tools, partnerships with several global AI labs, and strong homegrown models, rather than betting everything on just one path.

India's growing voice on the world stage India is not entering this conversation from a position of weakness. Recently it became the

first South country to host a big global AI summit, making it an obvious host for the kind of conversations that are needed. It is bringing together nations that share its interest in fair, broad access to powerful AI, instead of a world where just two or three countries control the switch for everyone else. This role alone enables India to have an impact on how AI is used, making it accessible to a range of languages and keeping it safe, not just following instructions that have been set elsewhere. This is also why India's new AI governance framework matters beyond its borders. Its approach, built on clear principles and a focus on innovation, sends a strong signal to global partners. It informs them that India is a serious, stable market for them to establish long term partnerships – rather than a country that closes its doors in the wake of one challenging incident.

What India should do next Three practical steps can strengthen India's position, without chasing an unrealistic race to match the global frontier. First, India should open up its formal partnerships of AI in a manner that no Indian business, research institution or government system becomes entirely reliant on one firm or one country's export policies. This is simply good risk management, the same kind India already applies to energy supply contracts. Second, India must continue to invest in agricultural, health, regional-language education and financial-inclusion compute subsidies and develop local AI models, where it has an inherent advantage, and also in other areas. This matters more than trying to compete everywhere at once with limited resources. Third, India should keep using its growing voice on the world stage, built through this year's global AI summit and its presence at forums like the G7, to push for clear, lasting rules around fair access to powerful AI. None of this means India should treat the recent restriction as a crisis. It is better understood as an early preview of how AI politics will work over the next decade. Access to powerful AI will sometimes be restricted, and market size will increasingly decide who gets a fair seat at the table when those decisions are made. The countries that invest wisely and are smartly leveraging the market overseas, rather than depending solely on others or attempting to do it on their own, will be standing on top of the pile. With its scale, its talent, and its growing voice in exactly these conversations, India is better placed than most countries to be one of them.

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FROM THE WORLD

PAKISTAN

Police uncover 3 tons cocaine

Police found 2.7 metric tons (3 tons) of cocaine on a property on Sydney's outskirts in Australia's largest ever seizure of the drug, officials said on Monday. The drug was found on June 19 in plastic tubs buried in underground bunkers hidden beneath three shipping containers on a semirural property in the suburb of Londonderry on Sydney's western edge, the Queensland Joint Organised Crime Taskforce said in a statement.

EAST TIMOR

Francisco Guterres dies at 71

Francisco Guterres, a former president of East Timor and a leading figure in the country's independence movement, has died. He was 71. Guterres, widely known by his nom de guerre "Lu Olo," died on Sunday at Prince Court Medical Centre in Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia, where he had been in intensive care, his family said on the late president's official Facebook account. The cause of death was not disclosed. Guterres served as president from 2017 to 2022, capping decades of involvement in the political and armed struggle that led to independence for Southeast Asia's youngest nation in 2002.

Starmer announces resignation as UK Prime Minister

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

British Prime Minister and Labour Party leader Keir Starmer on Monday announced his resignation, triggering a leadership contest that will determine his successor in the coming weeks, with a new prime minister expected to be in place before Parliament returns in September.

The 63-year-old said he would remain in office until a new Labour leader is elected and pledged his "full and unequivocal support" to his successor to ensure an orderly transfer of power.

"I have heard the answer of my parliamentary party to that question, and I accept that answer with good grace," an emotional Starmer said during a statement outside 10 Downing Street.

"The question my party is asking now is whether I am best placed to lead us into the next general election. Every decision I have taken has been about putting the country I love first. That is why I will resign as leader of the Labour Party," he said.

Starmer revealed that he had



Britain's Prime Minister Keir Starmer and wife Victoria stand in front of 10 Downing Street door after speaking to the media in London

informed King Charles III of his decision earlier on Monday. The outgoing prime minister said he would ask the Labour Party's National Executive Committee (NEC) to establish a timetable for selecting his successor. Nominations are set to open on July 9, with the process expected to conclude before Parliament's summer recess on July 17.

However, growing support

within Labour for Andy Burnham, who returned to the House of Commons on Monday after winning a crucial by-election last week, has fuelled speculation that he could secure the leadership unopposed and take office as prime minister as early as mid-July.

"I will put myself forward as part of this process," Burnham said in a social media post shortly after Starmer's announcement.

"In the case of a contest, this timetable will ensure a new leader is in place before Parliament returns in September," Starmer said. "I will remain in post as Prime Minister until the contest is complete, and I will do everything I can to ensure an orderly handover of power."

He added that his successor would inherit "a Britain that is far stronger and fairer than the one I inherited two years ago" and expressed confidence that Labour would remain well positioned to seek a second term in Government.

Starmer led Labour to a landslide victory in the July 2024 general election, ending more than a decade of Conservative rule. While his government initially enjoyed strong public support, his popularity declined sharply in recent months amid a series of controversial policy decisions and internal party tensions.

During his farewell remarks, Starmer reflected on his government's achievements, highlighting economic growth, rising wages, increased investment and major infrastructure projects. "Look at

what we have achieved in just two years — an economy that is stronger, growing faster than our peers, wages rising faster than inflation in every single month since we came to power, investment secured, infrastructure being built," he said. "Change promised by a Labour Government, change fought for by a Labour Government, change delivered by a Labour Government."

The departing leader also pointed to his role in rebuilding Labour after its electoral setbacks, noting that he inherited a party that was "politically, financially and morally bankrupt" and transformed it into a Government with a commanding parliamentary majority of 174 seats.

At one point, Starmer struggled to contain his emotions as he paid tribute to his family.

"When I leave the biggest job in the country, I shall spend more time on the most important job — being the best husband I can to my fantastic wife, Vic, who has been a rock by my side through good times and bad, and being the best dad I can to my beautiful children,

who are my pride and joy," he said.

Potential contenders in the leadership race are expected to include former Health Secretary Wes Streeting, alongside Burnham. Candidates must secure the backing of at least 20 per cent of Labour MPs and meet additional support thresholds from constituency Labour parties or affiliated organisations and trade unions.

Starmer's departure will leave the United Kingdom searching for its seventh prime minister in a decade, continuing a period of significant political turnover that has characterised British politics in recent years.

His premiership faced mounting challenges over the past year, including criticism surrounding the appointment of Peter Mandelson as the UK's ambassador to the United States and growing backlash over welfare reforms, tax policy reversals and changes to social benefits. With support within his Cabinet reportedly weakening, pressure mounted for a change in leadership direction, ultimately leading to Starmer's decision to step down.

Jaishankar meets Mongolian FM to review strategic partnership progress

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Ulaanbaatar

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar met his Mongolian counterpart Battsetseg Batmunkh and reviewed progress in bilateral cooperation in development projects, capacity building, security and multilateral fora.

Jaishankar, who arrived in Ulaanbaatar on the first leg of a two-nation visit that will also take him to South Korea, said he was delighted to meet Batmunkh. "Our discussions reflected the warmth, strength and promise of our Strategic Partnership.



Union External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar meets his Mongolian counterpart Battsetseg Batmunkh, in Ulaanbaatar, Mongolia

Reviewed the progress in our cooperation in development projects, capacity building, culture, education, security and multilateral fora," he said in a post on X.

Talks with Iranian officials set good foundation for a deal to end the war, says JD Vance

AAMER MADHANI, JAMEY KEATEN, SEUNG MIN KIM/ JOSH BOAK ■ Obbuergen

Vice President JD Vance on Monday said his lengthy talks with senior Iranian officials in Switzerland created a "good foundation for a successful final deal" as they seek a permanent end to the war that the US and Israel began in late February.

"The final deal is the house," Vance told reporters after initial talks with Iran's parliamentary speaker, Mohammad Bagher Qalibaf. "We set the foundation. We haven't built the house, but



VP JD Vance speaking to members of the media after the US and Iran held high-level talks at the Buergerstock Resort in Obbuergeren

we've laid a successful foundation to get to a good place for the American people." Vance and US officials claimed progress on multiple fronts, including the establish-

ment of "mechanisms" to ensure the Strait of Hormuz, a vital waterway for global energy shipments, stays open and that a ceasefire holds in the fighting between Israel

and Iran-backed Hezbollah militants in southern Lebanon.

Hezbollah and Israel went to war shortly after the outbreak of the wider conflict, with Hezbollah firing rockets and drones at civilian communities in northern Israel and Israel seizing large swaths of southern Lebanon. Iran has insisted that addressing the fighting in Lebanon is a critical component of any deal to end the wider conflict. Iran noted "major progress" to end the fighting in Lebanon and called that the first real test of the negotiations. (AP)

New Okhla Industrial Development Authority

Administrative Building, Sector-6, Noida, G.B. Nagar (U.P.)

Website : www.noidaauthorityonline.in

E-TENDER NOTICE

E-Tenders are invited from eligible firms/contractors for the following jobs against which bids can be uploaded and same shall be opened/downloaded as per schedule mentioned. The details and conditions of all tenders are available on Noida Authority's official website: www.noidaauthorityonline.in & <https://etender.up.nic.in>. Please ensure to see these websites for any changes/amendments & corrigendum etc.

A) (Rs. 30.00 Lacs to 100.00 Lacs)

S. No.	Job No.	Sale Start Date	Sale End Date	Tender Opening Date and Time
1	Job No. - 08/ E-TENDER/ SPO/2026-27 Name of Work- Uniform of Contract Staff of Noida Authority, Estimated Rs.76,45,550.00	23.06.2026	13.07.2026 upto 5:00 P.M.	14.07.2026 11.00 AM

Office: Sector-39 **Store Purchase Officer, Noida.**

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E-Tender Notice

Sr. DEE/EMU/GZB for and on behalf of President of India, Invites open e-tender for the under noted work:

GeM Bid Number	GEIM/2026/B/7575616 Dated: 22.06.2026
Name of the work	AMC of Fire Extinguisher-hydraulic pressure testing, repair, refilling and testing of Fire Extinguisher type CO2 gas cartridge ABC type and ABC Dry Chemical powder stored pressure type N2 at EMU Car Shed, Ghaziabad.
Tender Cost	NIL
Approximate cost	Rs. 37,93,095.00 inclusive of GST
Earnest Money	Rs. 75,870.00 (payment mode available on GeM website)
Completion period	3 Year(s)
Validity of offer	90 days
Date & Time from tender advertised on GeM website	22.06.2026
Date & Time from tender submission start and end	22.06.2026 to 15.07.2026 15:00 Hrs.
Tender closing Date & Time	15.07.2026 15:00 Hrs.
Date & Time of tender Opening (immediately when tender submission ends)	15.07.2026 15:30 Hrs.
Publication cost allocation	06041132

Note: 1. All participant Tenderer/Tenderers will submit their requisite documents along with their tender offer. "No post tender correspondence for submission of additional document shall be entertained after opening of the Technical & Commercial offer. Even suo-moto post tender letters of the tenders shall be treated as null & void".

Note 2: Duplicate documents should not be enclosed/up loaded.

Tender Notice is available on website of www.gem.gov.in

GEIM/2026/B/7575616 Date: 22.06.2026 2134/2026

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केनरा बैंक Canara Bank

Canara Bank, Nangal Raya Branch Delhi

Canara Bank Pigmy/INN Agent Mr. Krishan Kumar Bhutani has resigned from bank on 24/04/2026 If any customer has any claim Kindly bring to Bank notice within 30 days from the public notice and no claims will be entertained after the expiry of stipulated period.

Sd/- Manager:Nangal Raya Branch Delhi

Public Notice

This is to inform the general public that Mrs. Mahima Khanuja & Mrs. Meenu Khanuja the owner of the Ground Floor without roof right "said floor", built on Plot no. C-50 (Block-C), area measuring 304.72 Sq. Mtrs situated at sector-12, T.H.A Residential Colony Chandra Nagar, Ghaziabad Tehsil & Distt. Ghaziabad through Sale Deed dated 20.09.2007 as doc. No. 42666 executed by Mrs. Usha Salini in favour Rakesh Kumar Khanuja in respect of plot no. C-50 (Block-C), area measuring 304.72 Sq. Mtrs. Unfortunately Mr. Rakesh Kumar Khanuja died on dated 30.04.2024 and left behind his legal heirs are (i) Mrs. Meenu Khanuja (wife), Mr. Sagar Khanuja (Son), Mrs. Mahima Khanuja (Daughter) Mrs. Mahima Khanuja & Mrs. Meenu Khanuja is Mrs. intends to transfer the ownership of above said floor by way of Sale Deed to Brij Mohan Goyal subsequently Brij Mohan Goyal is in the process of mortgaging the said Plot with ICICI Bank Ltd./ ICICI Home Finance Co. Ltd. Any objections or concerns regarding this transaction should be raised within a period of 10 days from the date of this public notice. Any objections submitted after the completion of this 10-days period will not be considered binding with respect to the said property or the interests of our client.

If anyone wishes to raise an objection, please do so within the stipulated 10-day period by contacting Law Veritas: North (Advocates & Legal Consultants) at Office No.11, 1st Floor, Building No. A-4/A, Sector-16, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301; Landline(nos): +91012-0499971, e-mail: accounts@lvnorth.in

Army to be deployed in six districts ahead of Awami League founding anniversary

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

The Government has decided to deploy Army personnel in six districts from June 22 to June 30 to prevent potential sabotage and maintain law and order ahead of the Awami League's June 23 founding anniversary, whose activities currently face restrictions.

The Ministry of Home Affairs has sent directives regarding the deployment to the deputy commissioners of six districts—Dhaka, Gazipur, Narayanganj, Faridpur, Gopalganj and Chattogram.

According to officials, the decision was taken amid concerns that the Awami League and its affiliated organisations may attempt to organise processions, demonstrations and other activities that could disrupt public order.

In a letter issued by the ministry, authorities warned of possible sabotage and disorder through unlawful programmes organised by various banned political groups across the country. Such activities, it noted, could lead to a deterioration of the overall law-and-order situation and result in significant loss of life and property.

To address these concerns, the ministry instructed relevant authorities to prepare for deploying the



required number of Army personnel under the "In Aid to Civil Power" provision. The deployment will cover the metropolitan areas of Dhaka, Chattogram and Gazipur, as well as the districts of Narayanganj, Gopalganj and Faridpur.

The army will remain stationed in the designated areas until June 30 to assist civil authorities in maintaining public order, ensuring public safety and protecting lives and property. Officials said the Ministry of Home Affairs is expected to issue a formal notification regarding the deployment on Monday.

This latest move follows the government's initiation of a phased withdrawal

of Army personnel from across the country on April 6. Troops had been deployed nationwide following the political developments of August 5, 2024, to support law enforcement agencies in maintaining stability. Sheikh Hasina left Bangladesh following the July uprising against the Awami League government, a period marked by widespread protests, political unrest, and growing opposition to her administration.

As the crisis intensified and her Government lost power, she departed the country and took refuge in India, where she has been living since her removal from office.

GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA TENDER NOTICE

SR NO	NAME OF DEPARTMENT	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE DEPARTMENT	NODAL OFFICER/CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	PWD B&R, HISAR	SPECIAL REPAIR OF FLOOD AFFECTED ROAD FROM PATTAN TO MUKLAN RAWALWAS ROAD RD 0.000 TO 0.900 IN HISAR DISTT. (ROAD ID 4960) + 1 WORKS	CLOSING DATE 25.06.2026	90.98 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9878384499 pwd-eeepd1-hissar@hry.nic.in
2	PWD B&R, HISAR	SPECIAL REPAIR OF FLOOD EFFECTED ROAD FROM HISAR KHANAK ROAD (MDR-108) RD 13.450 TO 14.250 IN HISAR DISTT. (ROAD ID 4756)	CLOSING DATE 30.06.2026	109.88 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9878384499 pwd-eeepd1-hissar@hry.nic.in
	PWD B&R, HISAR	CONSTRUCTION OF PROPOSED NEW 6 BAYS BUS STAND AT EXISTING CAMPUS OF BUS STAND AT BARWALA IN HISAR DISTT.(PDG. LIFT ONLY)	17.06.2026 24.06.2026	17 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	0166-2225651 pwd-eeed-hissar@hry.nic.in
4	PWD B&R, NARWANA	CONSTRUCTION OF BOUNDARY WALL WITH RCC POLE AND BARBED WIRE INSTALLING AROUND THE CAMPUS OF FIRE AND DISASTER MANAGMENT INSTITUTE AT VILLAGE KHERI MASANIA IN DISTT. JIND	19.06.2026 25.06.2026	9.07 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	8398098075 pwd-eeepd-narwana@hry.nic.in
5	IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA, HISAR	REPAIR OF 11 BOATS UNDER THE JURISDICTION OF DC OFFICE FATEHABAD	19.06.2026 26.06.2026	7.37 LAS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01662239534 xenwsdmchrsr@gmail.com
6	IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA, CHARKHI DADRI	INTERNAL CLEARANCE OF DHANASARI MINOR FROM KM 0.000 TO 2.840 + 3 WORKS	19.06.2026 25.06.2026	3.37 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	8059375563 xenmgckd11@gmail.com
7	IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA, ROHTAK	DEWEEDING AND BANK CLEARANCE OF ASSAN MINOR FROM RD 0 TO 44358(TAIL). + 24 OTHER WORKS	CLOSING DATE 26.06.2026	27.28 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9812111077 xenwsdnrtk@gmail.com
8	PANCHAYATI RAJ, FATEHABAD	BAIJALPUR = CONSTRUCTION OF STREET FROM MAIN CHOWK TO H/O OM PARKASH S/O AMI LAL AT VILLAGE BAIJALPUR BLOCK BHUNA DISTRICT FATEHABAD (10141 11/03/2026 VANGY) + 1 WORKS	19.06.2026 25.06.2026	6.31 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01667230855 prexeeng.ftb@hry.nic.in
9	PANCHAYATI RAJ, KARNAL	COMP. OF SAIN SAMAJ CHOUPAL AT VILLAGE BASTALI BLOCK NISSING DISTRICT KARNAL SCHEME VANGY + 5 WORKS	17.06.2026 25.06.2026	29.20 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9896634422 prexeeng.kr1@hry.nic.in
10	PANCHAYATI RAJ, KARNAL	CONST OF BALMIKI CHOUPAL VILLAGE MAINMATI BLOCK KUNJPURA + 6 WORKS	18.06.2026 27.06.2026	92.81 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9896634422 prexeeng.kr1@hry.nic.in
11	PANCHAYATI RAJ, PANCHKULA	PROVIDING 261 NO 'S OF STREET LIGHTS IN 10 VILLAGES OF DISTRICT PANCHKULA AT VILLAGE BHAGWANPUR, BUNGA, TAPRIAN, SHYAMTOO, KHAIRWALI PARWALA , HANGOLA, KAKRALI, KHERI , NATWAL, REHNA	19.06.2026 25.06.2026	11.71 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9416915374 prexeeng.pk1@hry.nic.in
12	PANCHAYATI RAJ, PANCHKULA	KHOKHRA : PROVIDING AND LAYING OF R.C.C. PIPE FROM KHERA MANDIR TO NATIONAL HIGHWAY G.P KHOKHRA BLOCK PINJORE PKL SCHEME-VANGY	18.06.2026 24.06.2026	3.08 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9416915374 prexeeng.pk1@hry.nic.in
13	PUBLIC HEALTH ENGINEERING,MANDI DABWALI	MANDI DABWALI:- DNIT FOR PROVIDING AND SUPPLY OF 3 NOS. HYDRAULIC-OPERATED MANHOLE DE-SILTING GRAB BUCKET TYPE MACHINES AND ALL OTHER WORKS CONTINGENT THERETO. CH. HEAD:- MANDI DABWALI:- PROVIDING SEWERAGE SYSTEM IN NEWLY APPROVED COLONY AND CONSTRUCTION OF IPS AT UTTAM NAGAR AT DABWALI TOWN DISTT. SIRSA.	19.06.2026 09.07.2026	48 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	873000001 ee.mandidabwali@gmail.com
14	PUBLIC HEALTH ENGINEERING,MANDI DABWALI	KALANWALI TOWN:- CONSTRUCTION OF STAFF QUARTER AT SUB DIVISIONAL CAMPUS, KALANWALI TOWN DISTT. SIRSA. CH.HEAD:- ESTIMATE FOR PROVIDING AND INSTALLATION OF ONLINE ANALYZER, FLOW METER, IRTU ETC. AT 9.50 MLD STP AT KALANWALI TOWN DISTT. SIRSA.	19.06.2026 26.06.2026	4.95 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	873000001 ee.mandidabwali@gmail.com
15	MOTILAL NEHRU SCHOOL OF SPORTS, RAJ, SONEPAT	SCHOOL UNIFORM WINTER	19.06.2026 10.07.2026	24 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	8708859410 mnsrai@rediffmail.com
16	FOREST DEPARTMENT, SIRSA	PLANTATION MAINTENANCE WORKS IN SIRSA RANGE + 3 OTHER WORKS	CLOSING DATE 25.06.2026	162.93 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9416067122 forest_srsa@yahoo.com

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT www.etenders.hry.nic.in

RO 46442-I-27-7

INDIAN RAILWAYS

GOVERNMENT OF INDIA

MINISTRY OF RAILWAYS

(RAILWAY BOARD)

E-TENDER NO. 2026RSI8742TC

Principal Executive Director, Railway Stores (S), Ministry of Railways, Railway Board, Government of India invites e-tender for procurement of 6,18,592 Nos. Low Torque Grease Seal for AAR Standard Upgraded Class 'E' (6"x11") bearings used in freight stock to RDSO's Specification No. WD-63-MISC-2020 of October 2020 with latest amendments, if any through E-Reverse Auction.

2.0 The interested tenderers are advised to visit the website <http://ireps.gov.in> for details of the tender and submission of their e-bids.

3.0 No manual offers will be accepted against e-tender.

4.0 Tender will be closed at 15.00 hours on 29.07.2026.

5.0 Any corrigendum to this tender will be published on the website <http://ireps.gov.in> only and not in print media.

Director, Railway Stores (W),
Ministry of Railways, Railway Board, New Delhi,
For and on behalf of the President of India

2138/26 **SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE**

Speeding car rams shia gathering in Karachi

At least 14 people, mostly women and children, were injured when a speeding car rammed into a Shia religious congregation in Pakistan's Karachi city, police said on Monday.

The incident occurred on Sunday when people had gathered at an Imambargah (Shia religious place) for a Muharram congregation in Karachi's Defence Housing Authority area, police said.

Eleven women and three children, who had come for the congregation, were injured when the vehicle rammed into them.

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NEW DELHI | TUESDAY | JUNE 23, 2026

BUSINESS13

Renault India starts exports of Duster; first shipment to South Africa

Renault India on Monday said it has started exports of its new Duster SUV, with the first shipment leaving for South Africa. The first shipment of 750 vehicles departed from Chennai to South Africa, marking the beginning of Renault India's export programme for the new Duster, with additional international markets planned in the coming months, the company said in a statement. Commenting on the start of exports of the new Duster, Renault Group India CEO Stephane Deblaise said it is a strong validation of the quality, capabilities, and competitiveness of the company's operations in Chennai.

"It reflects the progress we have made in building India into an integral part of Renault's global industrial footprint," he added.

As Renault continues to expand its international footprint, Deblaise said, "India will play an increasingly strategic role in our future plans. We remain committed to contributing to the country's manufacturing ambitions and are working towards our objective of generating Euro 2 billion in annual exports from India by 2030". India possesses all the fundamentals required to emerge as a leading automotive export hub – world-class manufacturing capabilities, engineering talent, scale, and a rapidly evolving logistics ecosystem, he noted.

(PTI)

K2 Infra bags ₹390.91 crore Telangana road project

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

K2 Infra Limited on Monday said it has secured a road infrastructure project worth ₹390.91 crore from Telangana Government for the construction, upgradation, strengthening and maintenance of selected PRED roads in the Bhongir Circle under the Telangana Rural Roads Development Programme.

The company in a statement said the project is aimed at improving rural road connectivity in the Bhongir circle and facilitating smoother movement for local residents, businesses, farmers and essential services. The scope of work includes the development and maintenance of selected road stretches under the Panchayat Raj Engineering Department framework.

Reliance Industries shares climb nearly 3% as Jio files for IPO

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Shares of Reliance Industries climbed nearly 3 per cent on Monday after its digital unit Jio Platforms filed draft papers for what could become India's largest-ever initial public offering.

The rally was also bolstered after billionaire Mukesh Ambani unveiled a roadmap for the company's next phase of growth spanning artificial intelligence, satellite broadband,

clean energy and consumer businesses at the company's 49th annual general meeting.

The bellwether stock rallied 2.75

per cent to ₹1,345.45 on the BSE.

At the NSE, the stock edged higher by 2.70 per cent to ₹1,344.90.

Rally in the blue-chip stock was also instrumental in driving the markets higher. The 30-share BSE Sensex traded 454.36 points higher at 77,253.07 in late morning trade. The 50-share NSE Nifty climbed 136.05 points to 24,149.50.

Jio Platforms, the telecom-technology company that transformed India's digital landscape over the past decade, filed a draft

red herring prospectus with market regulator SEBI on Friday for a fresh issue of up to 27 crore shares.

Sources familiar with the matter had said that the offering could raise about ₹37,700 crore (USD 4 billion), valuing the company at roughly USD 137 billion.

The offering aims to unlock value from Jio Platforms, whose telecom arm has grown into the world's second-largest mobile operator by subscribers in a single country after China Mobile.

SEBI mulls consolidating tech, cybersecurity norms

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Markets regulator SEBI on Monday proposed a comprehensive overhaul and consolidation of information technology-related regulations applicable to market infrastructure institutions aimed at simplifying compliance requirements, removing redundancies and ensuring regulatory consistency across.

In its consultation paper, the regulator proposed merging provisions of the Master Circulars for stock exchanges and clearing corporations with the Master Circular for commodity derivatives, while also creating a consolidated circular covering common IT-related areas such as cyber security, cyber resilience, annual system audits, busi-

ness continuity planning and disaster recovery (BCPDR), capacity planning and technology advisories. SEBI said several provisions currently duplicated across different circulars and frameworks could be streamlined to improve regulatory clarity and reduce compliance burden without diluting oversight.

Among the key proposals, SEBI has suggested removing repeated references to the Cyber Security and Cyber Resilience Framework (CSCRF) from various sections of existing circulars, noting that the framework already applies directly to MIIs and intermediaries.

The regulator also proposed harmonising capacity planning requirements across stock exchanges, clearing corporations and

depositories. The proposals are aimed at simplifying regulatory requirements, removal of redundant provisions, discontinuation of duplication, in order to promote ease of doing business and reduce the compliance burden on exchanges, SEBI said.

Under the proposed

framework, immediate corrective action would be required if actual utilisation of any IT component exceeds 75 per cent of installed capacity. Such instances would be reviewed by the Standing Committee on Technology (SCOT), while capacity augmentation would be under-

Government technology initiatives. Voice AI startup Gnani.ai was selected under the IndiaAI Mission and received Government-backed GPU compute credits worth ₹177 crore to help build sovereign AI models.

Info Edge's deeptech portfolio comprises 30 companies spanning robotics, semiconductors, biotechnology, spacetechnology, defence technology and electric mobility. Investments of ₹455 crore are currently valued at ₹559

crore, representing a 1.2-times multiple and an estimated gross IRR of about 15 per cent.

The company said it entered sectors such as robotics, healthcare, biotechnology and space technology well before they attracted mainstream investor interest, often backing startups at the intellectual property creation and research-and-development stage. Notable investments include warehouse automation company Unbox Robotics, electric aircraft startup ePlane, satellite propulsion company Manastu Space, semiconductor venture Bharat Semi and battery technology startup

Clean Electric. Two portfolio companies — ePlane and Manastu Space — recently secured funding allocations under the Indian Government's Research Development and Innovation (RDI) scheme. EPlane received ₹285 crore, the largest allocation among approved projects, while Manastu Space secured ₹115 crore, subject to matching private-sector investment.

Bikhchandani said several deeptech companies were beginning to show promise in areas including warehouse robotics, immuno-oncology, semiconductors and electric mobility, although he cautioned that deeptech businesses typically require

longer development cycles.

Consumer technology remains the largest contributor to value creation within Info Edge's startup portfolio. The company has invested ₹2,755 crore across 45 consumer technology and consumer AI startups, with the portfolio now valued at ₹37,214 crore, representing a 13.5-times return on invested capital and an estimated gross IRR of about 34 per cent. The portfolio includes listed companies Eternal, which houses Zomato and Blinkit, and PB Fintech, parent of Policybazaar, alongside investments in sectors including travel, healthcare, e-commerce, fintech, gaming and education technology.

World Bank approves \$1.5bn to support reforms

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The World Bank's Board of Executive Directors has approved \$1.5 billion in financing to support India's structural reforms aimed at boosting private sector-led job creation and accelerating economic growth.

The financing, provided under the Boosting Job Creation in the Private Sector Development Policy Financing (DPF) Operation, is expected to support reforms that can create employment opportunities for 11 million young Indians entering the workforce over the next two decades.

The programme builds on reforms undertaken in recent

years, including tax simplification, trade integration, regulatory changes, and measures to improve the business environment, the World Bank said in a statement on Monday.

The DPF supports initiatives to reduce barriers to entrepreneurship, strengthen labour market participation, particularly among women, streamline trade and investment processes, and improve access to capital for businesses, it added.

In November 2025, the Government consolidated 29 labour laws into four comprehensive Labour Codes, aimed at simplifying compliance, modernising outdated provisions, and creating a more efficient framework for busi-

nesses while protecting workers' rights.

According to Government estimates, employment in India increased from 452

million in 2017-18 to 604 million in 2023-24, adding more than 150 million jobs over six years. During the same period, the unemploy-

ment rate declined from 6 per cent to 3.2 per cent, while nearly 9 million women joined regular wage employment.

The reforms reflect India's shift towards outcome-oriented governance focused on transparency, predictability, and long-term economic resilience, it said.

The operation is aligned with the World Bank Group's Country Partnership Framework for India for FY26-31 and supports the Government's Viksit Bharat by 2047 vision by improving the environment for firms, encouraging private investment, and expanding productive employment opportunities, it said.

The programme will focus

on three key areas - improving the business-enabling environment, promoting trade and investment openness, and mobilising private capital for business expansion and job creation, it noted. "India is well paced in its reform agenda to unlock private capital and create jobs in a challenging global context," said World Bank Vice President for South Asia Johannes Zutt.

The DPF also complements recent investments by the World Bank Group's private sector arm, the International Finance Corporation (IFC), to increase credit access for MSMEs and underserved communities, including women in rural and semi-urban areas.

Silver rebounds on progress in US-Iran talks

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Silver futures rebounded by ₹5,146 to ₹2.38 lakh per kg on Monday, tracking firm global trends amid progress in US-Iran negotiations.

On the Multi Commodity Exchange (MCX), the white metal for July delivery increased by ₹5,146, or 2.21 per cent, to ₹2,38,331 per kg in a business turnover of 10,463 lots.

Similarly, the September contract also advanced by ₹5,076, or 2.13 per cent, to ₹2,43,817 per kg in 5,110 lots.

Analysts said silver prices rebounded following signs of diplomatic progress between Washington and Tehran, easing traders' concerns after weeks of heightened tensions in West Asia.

"Silver prices saw a modest recovery in the domestic markets on Monday as progress in US-Iran peace talks provided some support to the precious metals market," Gaurav Garg, Research Analyst at Lemonn Markets Desk, said.

In the international markets, Comex silver futures for July delivery rose nearly 3 per cent at \$66.71 per ounce in New York.

"Bullion prices witnessed a recovery on progress in US-Iran peace talks, however, gains remained limited as the US dollar continued to trade near a 13-month high," Kaveri

More, Commodity Analyst, Technical Research at Choice Broking, said.

Iran's Foreign Minister Seyed Abbas Araghchi described the first round of talks in Switzerland as showing "progress", even as negotiations began under the shadow of renewed warnings from US President Donald Trump.

"Oil and petrochem exports are waived, blockade lifted, some frozen assets released, and a major reconstruction & development plan launched for Iran," Araghchi said in a post on X.

Meanwhile, a joint statement from mediators said both sides had agreed to establish a "communication line" aimed at preventing incidents in the Strait of Hormuz, and to create a de-confliction arrangement involving Lebanon.

Vedanta Aluminium Metal to double production capacity

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Vedanta Aluminium Metal Ltd (VAML), which recently got listed on the BSE and NSE, on Monday said it plans to double its production capacity to 60 lakh tonnes per annum (LTPA) to meet rising demand from infra, automotive and electrification sectors.

VAML officially commenced trading as an independent listed entity on the National Stock Exchange (NSE) and Bombay Stock Exchange (BSE) from June 15, following the successful completion of Vedanta Group's demerger, which became effective on May 1.

The listing marks a major milestone in the company's evolution, creating a focused, pure-play aluminium business with enhanced strategic flexibility and stronger long-term growth visibility, the company said in a statement.

"With its vision to double the existing production

capacity to 60 lakh tonnes per annum, deep backward integration and structural cost advantages, it is set to achieve among the lowest costs of production globally while upholding the highest standards of quality, serving demand across key global markets and benefiting from long-term tailwinds in infra, automotive, electrification, aerospace and advanced manufacturing," the statement said.

The company's current production capacity is 30 LPTA.

The company is also poised to emerge as the largest aluminium producer across the US, Europe, the Middle East, Australia, and Africa.

Vedanta Aluminium operates one of the world's largest alumina refineries at Lanjigarh and one of the world's largest aluminium smelters at Jharsuguda in Odisha, and the country's iconic aluminium producer Bharat Aluminium Company Limited (BALCO) at Korba in Chhattisgarh.

Info Edge says AI, deeptech portfolio tops ₹1,800 crore in value; startup portfolio crosses ₹41k crore

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Info Edge has emerged as one of India's earliest institutional backers of artificial intelligence and deep technology startups, with investments of more than ₹1,000 crore across 54 companies since 2020 generating early gains and attracting follow-on funding from global investors.

Info Edge, one of India's most active startup investors, said its early bets on artificial intelligence and deep technology startups are beginning to pay off, as the company doubled down on its conviction that AI, deeptech and consumer technology will

drive the next wave of value creation from India.

In a letter to shareholders, founder and vice chairman Sanjeev Bikhchandani said Info Edge has invested more than ₹1,000 crore across 54 AI and deeptech startups since 2020, many of them before the global surge in investor interest in artificial intelligence.

"We began investing in AI and deeptech in 2020 - ahead of the broader market wave," Bikhchandani said, adding that the company's strategy is to "identify exceptional founders early, invest before consensus forms, and stay invested longer than most others are willing to."

The company has invested

₹614 crore across 28 AI-focused startups, a portfolio now valued at ₹1,268 crore, implying a 2.1-times multiple on invested capital and an estimated gross internal rate of return (IRR) of about 31 per cent.

The AI portfolio spans enterprise AI, consumer AI and AI infrastructure, and includes companies such as Aftershoot, Attentive AI, Gnani.ai, LumiQ, Pascal AI and Shipy. Fifteen of the 28 AI startups have raised follow-on funding from institutional investors including Insight Partners, Peak XV, SIG and Vertex.

Several portfolio companies have also secured support under flagship

PROSPECT



Rameshwar Teli, Minister for Labour Welfare, Tea Tribes, Adivasi Welfare and Transformation and Development, Government of Assam, called on Hardeep Singh Puri, Union Minister for Petroleum and Natural Gas in Duliargaj, Assam



Shaji Krishnan V, Chairman, NABARD, called upon Assam Chief Minister Dr Himanta Biswa Sarma in Delhi



Ranjeet Bhattacharya, General Secretary, Kissan Morcha, Assam Pradesh, welcoming the pilgrims of Ambabuchi Mahayog 2026 with 'Anna Sewa' in Guwahati

ALIMCO receives special mention jury award at BML Munjal Awards 2026



ALIMCO has been conferred the Special Mention Jury Award at the prestigious BML Munjal Awards 2026 for its outstanding achievements in business excellence through learning & development initiatives. The award was presented by Dr Mohan Bhagwat to Praveen Kumar, CMD, ALIMCO, at a grand ceremony held in New Delhi. This recognition reflects ALIMCO's commitment to excellence, innovation, continuous learning, and organisational development.

CBI arrests former CEOs of RCFL, RHFL in ₹7,623 crore bank fraud

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The CBI arrested former CEOs of Reliance Commercial Finance Limited (RCFL) and Reliance Home Finance Limited (RHFL) on Monday in connection with separate cases pertaining to an alleged fraud of ₹7,623 crore in multiple public sector banks, officials said.

The CBI has arrested former RCFL director and chief executive officer Devang Mody and former executive director and CEO of RHFL Ravindra Sudhakar, they said.

"In RCFL case, the accused have caused a loss of ₹4,097 crore to 13 Public Sector Banks (PSBs), whereas in RHFL, the loss amount is ₹3,526 crore to 10 PSBs," a CBI spokesperson said in a statement.

The CBI probe has shown that Mody, who was the CEO of RCFL from April 2017 to December 2018, "was a key decision-maker" responsi-



Anil Ambani

ble for managing the operations of the company, the agency said.

"He approved loans to intermediary and conduit companies despite being aware that such lending was contrary to RBI guidelines and the sanction conditions governing borrowings from Public Sector Banks," the statement said.

Sudhakar served as the ED and CEO of RHFL from

October 1, 2016, to March 31, 2022, it said.

"He was a key decision-maker responsible for managing the operations of Reliance Home Finance Limited (RHFL). He approved loans to intermediary and conduit companies despite such lending being contrary to the company's lending policies, NHB/RBI guidelines and the conditions governing borrowings from Public

Sector Banks," the statement said. The agency alleged that the accused diverted funds borrowed by RCFL and RHFL to Reliance ADA Group companies, including Reliance Capital Limited, Reliance Infrastructure Limited and Reliance Power Limited, thereby causing a combined wrongful loss of ₹7,623 crore to the lending banks and corresponding wrongful gain to themselves and related entities.

The CBI has registered seven FIRs against Reliance Communications Limited (RCom), RHFL, RCFL and Reliance Telecom Limited (RTL), based on complaints received from various PSBs and the Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC).

The agency has arrested five persons in Reliance ADA Group-related cases. It filed its first chargesheet in the RCom case on May 29 against 16 accused — the company, five senior executives of RCom and 10 bank officials.

Yoga is a scientific tool for total health, says Dr MM Joshi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Describing yoga as "a scientific tool" that helps achieve balance of bodily, mental and emotional functions, former Union Minister Dr Murli Manohar Joshi has called for embracing India's ancient wellness traditions to build healthier individuals and societies.

He was speaking at the International Day of Yoga 2026 celebrations organised by the Illness to Wellness Foundation in the national Capital.

Held on the theme "Yoga for Healthy Ageing," the event brought together distinguished delegates, diplomats, ambassadors from various countries, corporate leaders, wellness practitioners, healthcare advocates and yoga enthusiasts to celebrate yoga as a holistic approach to preventive healthcare and healthy living.

The programme focused on the growing need to shift from illness-centric health-



care towards wellness-oriented lifestyles as societies across the world grapple with rising lifestyle disorders, stress, chronic diseases and rapidly ageing populations.

"Yoga is not a religion, a political movement, or dogma. It is a way of bringing harmony within diversity. It respects all cultures, creeds and nations. Yoga is a scientific tool, pleasant and enjoyable, which can help achieve balance of bodily, mental and emotional functions. If practised conscientiously, it uplifts the mind and emotions, raises consciousness and brings us into harmony with the whole of nature," Joshi said.

Addressing the occasion, Anil Rajput, Chairperson, Advisory Council, Illness to Wellness Foundation, emphasised that healthy ageing is no longer merely a healthcare objective but a societal imperative that requires a shift towards prevention, awareness and sustainable lifestyle choices.

Adding a practical dimension to the celebration, participants took part in a power-packed yoga session on the lawns of ITC Maurya led by Dr Tanu Singh, Founder, LifeYoga, who guided attendees through a series of asanas, breathing techniques and movements designed to improve strength, flexibility, posture and overall vitality.

Air India to operate direct flights from Guwahati to Dubai, Abu Dhabi from August 4: Himanta

TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

Air India will commence direct flights from Guwahati to Dubai and Abu Dhabi from August 4, Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said on Monday.

Announcing the development in a post on X, Sarma said the new services would connect Lokpriya Gopinath Bordoloi International Airport to four countries — the UAE, Thailand, Singapore and Bhutan.

"Opening new avenues to connect Assam to the global community! Just days after EU member states lifted their travel advisory for Assam, I am happy to share that from August 4, Air India will commence direct flights from Guwahati to Dubai and Abu Dhabi," he said.

With the launch of the non-stop services, Guwahati airport will now have direct international connectivity to four countries, the Chief Minister said.

"My next goal is to commence direct services to



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

State-owned NHAI on Monday said it has directed its field offices to ask roadside amenities (WSAs) lessees to prioritise setting up vehicle repair shops and puncture repair facilities along National highways and expressways at the earliest to enhance ease of commuting.

NHAI, in a statement, said it has been observed that a larger number of vehicles and puncture repair services are required on several National Highways and expressways to enable highway users to access mechanical assistance during breakdowns and

emergencies, avoiding inconvenience, delays, and potential safety concerns.

National Highways Logistics Management Limited (NHLML) is developing a network of modern roadside amenities on a long-term lease basis under the public-private partnership (PPP) model, it added.

Under the existing lease agreements executed with concessionaires and lessees, a range of permissible facilities can be developed in addition to the mandatory amenities prescribed for each WSA.

Vehicle repair Shops and puncture repair facilities are among the approved permissible facilities under the contractual framework.



Opening new avenues to connect Assam to the global community! Just days after EU member states lifted their travel advisory for Assam, I am happy to share that from August 4, Air India will commence direct flights from Guwahati to Dubai and Abu Dhabi

— HIMANTA BISWA SARMA, CHIEF MINISTER

Vietnam, and I will keep you posted on that," Sarma added.

He said the new flights would provide a major boost to the state's efforts to position Guwahati as a key travel and transit hub for Southeast Asia.

On Saturday, Sarma had said in a Facebook Live session that European Union (EU) member states, following Australia and Japan, had revised their travel advisories and removed restrictive guidance for their citizens visiting Assam.

Double Stack Container Train services start from JNPA on Western Dedicated Freight Corridor

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a major boost to rail-led logistics, CONCOR has successfully moved Double Stack Container Trains on DFC from JNPA to CONCOR MMLP Dadri (Delhi-NCR), MMLP Khatuwas (Rajasthan), and Varnama (Gujarat), demonstrating the strength, efficiency, and readiness of this transformative service.

Now, Double Stack Container Train service is available with CONCOR from MMLP Dadri, MMLP Khatuwas, and Varnama to



JNPT directly and vice versa, along with extended connectivity from JNPT to key inland destinations such as Tughlakabad and Ludhiana

(via Khatuwas), Moradabad (via Dadri), and Indore (Tihl) (via Varnama), among several other route combinations-enabling faster evacu-

ation of import/export containers, sharply reducing cargo dwell time, improving rake turnaround, and significantly enhancing rail coefficient for a more efficient and reliable supply chain.

With minimised port detention, predictable transit, and reduced dependency on road transport, this marks a decisive shift in cargo movement dynamics. Now it is the time to beat port congestion with CONCOR.

More than a milestone-it is the future of India's freight movement.

ICAI celebrates International Day of Yoga worldwide

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Institute of Chartered Accountants of India (ICAI) celebrated the spirit of wellness on the 12th International Day of Yoga 2026 through yoga sessions organised across the country, witnessing enthusiastic and overwhelming participation across its 5 regional councils, 186 branches and overseas chapters.

Aligning with this year's inspiring global theme, "Yoga for Healthy Ageing," ICAI's celebrations echoed the vision of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, highlighting India's holistic framework for longevity, mental agility and lifelong well-being. The IDY 2026 celebrations, pan-India, were organised under the aegis of the Beneficiary Schemes Directorate and the Public Relations Committee of ICAI. As a premier professional



body, ICAI recognises that sustainable economic and professional success is built upon a foundation of physical and mental wellness. This year's theme underscores a critical global shift: treating health not merely as the absence of disease but as a proactive journey toward longevity.

On this occasion, CA Prasanna Kumar D, President, ICAI, along with the Members of the Central Council and the Northern India Regional Council, and CA (Dr) Jai Kumar Batra,

Secretary, ICAI, participated in the yoga session, setting a powerful example of leadership through wellness. The event witnessed enthusiastic participation from ICAI members and employees, reflecting their commitment to holistic well-being and a healthy lifestyle.

Encouraging the CA fraternity to integrate the practice into their demanding daily routines, CA Prasanna Kumar D, President, ICAI, stated, "Yoga is India's timeless gift to humanity, offering a perfect blueprint for a bal-

anced life. For chartered accountants, whose responsibilities demand utmost intellectual sharpness and emotional strength, Yoga bridges the critical gap between professional career and a healthy life. By embedding yoga into our daily lives, we embrace a holistic vision for longevity."

Simultaneously, in Mumbai, the Yoga Day celebrations were graced by Piyush Goyal, Union Minister of Commerce & Industry, along with central & regional council members. Echoing the sentiments at the Mumbai Yoga Day celebrations, Piyush Goyal said, "As our Hon'ble Prime Minister has emphasised, development and heritage must go hand in hand. The vision of a Viksit Bharat can be realised only when we remain deeply rooted in our culture, heritage and values, while carrying them forward with pride for future generations.

DAILY SUDOKU

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★☆☆☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction-no maths involved.

SOLUTION (22.6.26)

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
TUESDAY | JUNE 23, 2026

ACROSS

3 Time will certainly not stand still! (5)
8 Apply for the job of president? (5)
10 To rob thus shows no humanity! (5)
11 The "beat" of a giant heart! (3)
12 Bad ignition (5)
13 Familiar form of grub chewed by diners without much noise? (7)
15 In Germany we get faultless service (5)
18 Wherein the chemists could have a little party (3)
19 Possibly sent half a mile to rest in comfort (6)
21 Went back to bed (7)
22 Honest people? (4)
23 Small quantity of margarine returned

DOWN

1 Use a knife on some stuff in a cup (3,2)
2 Felt things tailored to make a singlet! (7)
4 They can be put on in the manner of a sari (4)
5 Exulted when, given credit, one was in debt (6)
6 The flat stones shone weirdly! (5)
7 Way to make love by the book (5)
9 Bit of a stare from Jack (3)
12 Rarebit cooked up for the referee (7)
14 One must do so or die in the attempt! (3)
16 Rant or rave about the weather (5)
17 Once more, a manuscript takes plenty of paper (5)
19 Closest to seeming unusually earnest

ACROSS

1. Bottle
2. Youngest
3. Jars
4. Deb-ar
5. Tripod
6. Awning
7. Mates
8. Rose
9. D-eer-ay

DOWN

1. B-utter
2. Trip-le (jump)
3. Eyed
4. Snowman
5. Deb-t
6. S-trap-s
7. Miss
8. Co-y
9. N-ay
10. N-ay
11. Never
12. Jetty
13. Old-EN

19.Des
20. Coe
21. Garland
22. Tab
23. J-Emi-ma
24. A-lasi-s
25.Skewer
26. Duncie
27. Balls
28. Tex
29. Far-in

BRIEFLY

Iran plays 10-man Belgium to 0-0 draw at World Cup



Alireza Beiranvand made seven saves while Iran and Belgium played to a 0-0 draw at the World Cup on Sunday, with Team Melli unable to break through after the Red Devils went down to 10 men in the second half.

Belgium defender Nathan Ngoy received a straight red card in the 66th minute when he miskicked a ball backward and then fouled Mehdi Taremi to prevent the Iran star from getting a clean breakaway scoring chance.

Iran couldn't capitalise, and Belgium actually generated better scoring chances down the stretch – but both teams left with their second straight draw in group play. Neither team will feel good about the result at SoFi Stadium.

During a tumultuous World Cup trip affected by travel restrictions and visa denials from the US, Iran will regret missing a golden opportunity to beat a European powerhouse sitting 10th in FIFA's world rankings while playing before a loud, supportive crowd. Iran returned to the Los Angeles area for its second straight match in front of a crowd packed with fans from the diaspora both supporting Team Melli and decrying Iranian government with boos of anthem and hundreds of Lion and Sun flags displayed.

(AP)

It was a good goal: Surman on World Cup goal vs Egypt



New Zealand defender Finn Surman made a surprise appearance on the score sheet, burying the opening goal in his team's 3-1 World Cup loss to Egypt on Sunday night.

The loss puts New Zealand at the bottom of the group with just one point, but the team can still advance to the knockout round. If the Kiwis pull off an upset victory over Belgium in Vancouver on Friday while Egypt defeats Iran in Seattle, they can move on with an improbable second-place finish.

New Zealand carried much of the momentum through the first half against Egypt thanks to Surman's goal. On a 15th-minute corner kick from fellow defender Tim Payne, Surman tracked the ball and knocked in a header from just outside the 6-yard box.

"It was a pretty big jump," Surman said. "I definitely felt that it was a good goal, so I'm pretty happy about that."

The Kiwis held that 1-0 lead into halftime, but a second-half flurry of Egyptian goals took New Zealand from potentially leading the group to sitting in last.

(AP)

World Cup: Cape Verde gets 1st goal of tournament, holds Uruguay to draw

ALANIS THAMES
■ Miami Gardens (Florida)

Cape Verde's magical start to its first World Cup isn't over. It might just be getting started.

The tiny island nation that stunned tournament favourite Spain last week did it again against Uruguay – a two-time World Cup champion – on Sunday, coming from behind for a 2-2 draw.

Kevin Pina scored on a free kick for Cape Verde's first-ever goal in the World Cup, and Helio Varela scored the equaliser for what has become one of the most surprising teams of the expanded 48-team



Iran's challenges at FIFA World Cup swirl outside 0-0 draw with Belgium

AMY TAXIN ■ Inglewood (California)

Iran took another step toward advancing in the World Cup on Sunday, but once again the off-the-field play dominated the conversation. At the match's conclusion, at least one attendee wearing a pre-revolutionary flag shirt was detained for trying to run onto the pitch.

And afterward, though demonstrations were quieter than Monday's, an Associated Press reporter observed a fan who got into a scuffle with protesters being loaded into an ambulance.

But before the match had even kicked off, US Homeland Security Markwayne Mullin said Sunday that the Iranians had "tried to get somebody in yesterday" who had direct ties to Iran's Revolutionary Guard. In a state-



ment, the soccer federation vociferously pushed back.

"The claim that an official representative of the Iranian Football Federation attempted to board a flight to enter the United States yesterday and was prevented from doing so is an outright and undeniable lie," the statement said.

Mullin told Fox News that most teams travel with around 120 people, but the US had accepted 53 in Iran's case.

He said the rest of the people Iran had tried to secure visas for had "direct ties to the IRGC and aren't their normal travelling group."

(AP)

Thiaw mum on changes ahead of clash against Norway

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ East Rutherford

With Senegal in a difficult spot in World Cup group play, coach Pape Thiaw is not revealing how many changes he might make for his team's game against Norway on Monday night.

"Am I going to shake things up a bit? Well, you'll find this out," Thiaw said through an interpreter at a news conference Sunday.

Senegal hung in tough against France for the first half of its opener before losing 3-1. Edouard Mendy allowed three goals on eight shots in that game, which included Kylian Mbappe scoring from long range moments after Senegal finally got on the board in stoppage time.

Reserve goalkeeper Mory Diaw accompanied Thiaw to the news conference, but denied his appearance may indicate he would start in place of Mendy.

Senegal has only Iraq left to play after facing Norway in Group I, so the Lions of Teranga are treating their second game as if it is a must-win final. "We're in a very tough group; we knew this coming in," Thiaw said. "We obviously lost the first one, but there's everything left to play for. We cannot get this wrong."

Containing Erling Haaland: Whoever is in goal – and on the field – for Senegal, the biggest challenge is slowing down Erling Haaland, the high-scoring striker who had two goals in a 4-1 rout of



Iraq on Tuesday after leading Europe with 16 in qualifying.

"Yes, Haaland, but it's not Haaland alone," Diaw said through an interpreter. "Haaland by himself, he can't do anything. He needs his teammates, so it's not how do we stop Haaland. It's up to us to be prepared for the game against Norway."

Diaw was echoing Thiaw, who said his plan was to neutralize Norway as a team. Of course,

that begins with Haaland, who scored 27 goals in 35 Premier League games for Manchester City this past season and has 57 internationally.

"Haaland obviously doesn't need any introducing," Thiaw said. "We've got good defenders. We've got very high-level defenders who have played in very high-level competitions and have come across strikers of this caliber."

Thiaw says problems have been

resolved, including his contract.

After reports lingered for months that Thiaw was coaching without a contract, he said he now has one. He declined to say how long it was for, calling the details confiden-



tial and the timing less than ideal.

"It took too long," Thiaw said. "But it was not really a money issue. It was more principles and respect issue, but it's been resolved."

Thiaw also acknowledged players had some problems but said they have been worked out. Amid reports that Senegal is enduring food issues without a team chef at the World Cup, Diaw was asked what his complaints were and responded that the team handles issues internally.

"I don't think we need to come and air our dirty laundry here," Diaw said. "We've got a group of players, professional players, and we're here to represent our Senegalese country and that's what we're here to do. And we're trying to do the best that we can (Monday night). And all of the other problems or these scandals, there's nothing that's going to take away from our focus on our common objective."

Norway can advance with a win: Haaland and his teammates would move on to the round of 32 with a victory. Norway is in the World Cup for just the fourth time and first since 1998.

Salah scores and Egypt downs NZ 3-1 for first World Cup victory

ANNE M. PETERSON
■ Vancouver

Egypt's players danced on the field while their red-clad fans celebrated in the stands. The Pharaohs finally got their first World Cup win. Mohamed Salah scored the go-ahead goal and Egypt went on to defeat New Zealand 3-1 on Sunday night.

He celebrated his 68th international goal by pumping his fist before he was mobbed by his teammates in the 67th minute.

When he was subbed off in the 85th he was treated to a standing ovation by the sellout crowd at BC Place Vancouver.

When it was over, coach Hossam Hassan and an assistant grabbed an Egyptian flag and ran around the field waving it aloft. The fans cheered and sang long after the final whistle.

"I always give my best to the national team," Salah said. "Today I think is a very special day, with our first win in the World Cup."

Egypt moved to the top of the standings in Group G with the win, but was not



yet assured of a spot in the knockout round. The Pharaohs will play a deciding game against Iran on Friday in Seattle, needing at least a draw to advance.

Egypt is making its fourth World Cup appearance after missing the field in Qatar four years ago. Salah scored a pair of goals in the 2018 World Cup in Russia.

Finn Surman put New Zealand in front in the 15th minute with a flying



header off a corner kick delivered by Instagram sensation Tim Payne.

It was the third international goal for the 6-foot-3 defender who plays for the Portland Timbers in MLS.

Omar Marmoush dropped a free kick off to Salah in the 35th minute but it went just wide and bent into the side netting and Egypt went into the half down 1-0. "In between the first and the second half, we said it's a no-go, we are not going to leave this pitch unless we claim the victory for ourselves, unless we make everyone proud and happy," Hassan said.

(AP)

Uruguay struggles as Suarez watches from stands



GRACIE FISHER
■ Miami Gardens (USA)

Uruguay is off to a start many did not expect. After draws against Saudi Arabia and Cape Verde, and with a match against Spain still to come, the two-time World Cup winner is at risk of missing the knockout stage.

Among the many fans watching was someone the team looked to for goals for more than 15 years: Luis Suarez. The matches were played in Miami Stadium, near where Suarez serves as striker for Inter Miami. The 39-year-old watched from above as Uruguay struggled despite being heavily favoured.

Suarez ended his international career in 2024 as all-time leading scorer for the national team with 69 goals in 143 appearances. He was ultimately left off coach Marcelo Bielsa's squad after months of speculation. After the match, Bielsa spoke about the team's inability to capitalise on some of its advantages.

"I think that the problem or greatest issue is that we started the second half with the ball and with the victory," Bielsa said through a translator after Sunday's game. "And it was at that moment that we didn't close it. We didn't make any danger." Bielsa claimed his team "lacked a finishing touch" in Sunday night's draw. Something that Suarez once delivered in his time with Uruguay. Fans of Uruguay recognized how difficult it can be to replace a player of Suarez's caliber.

"(I have) mixed feelings to be honest," Uruguay supporter Frederico Suarez said. "He's old and now it's time for the younger players. But he's a good player, maybe the best player I've ever watched with Uruguay." In April, Luis Suarez announced he was willing to come out of retirement to play for Uruguay in World Cup. The announcement fueled speculation that Uruguay's star could make one final appearance on soccer's biggest stage.

(AP)

Yamal scores 10 minutes into his first WC start, gives Spain liftoff

JAMES ROBSON ■ Atlanta

Welcome to the World Cup, Lamine Yamal. Welcome to the World Cup, Spain.

Teenage superstar Yamal scored 10 minutes into his first start on soccer's biggest stage and Spain kickstarted its campaign with the 4-0 demolition of Saudi Arabia in Atlanta on Sunday.

The 18-year-old forward slid in at the far post to touch home a low cross for the opening goal and became the eighth-youngest scorer in World Cup history. More importantly, he settled Spanish nerves after the European champion was held to a surprise 0-0 draw by Cape Verde in its opening game.

"The first game wasn't really us, it was different, but now we've arrived and we're going for more," Yamal said.

In a tournament that has already seen Lionel Messi, Kylian



Mbappe, Erling Haaland and Harry Kane get off to flying starts, Yamal's strike saw him join the party. "I've always dreamed of being at a World Cup, and being able to score in my first match as a starter is a dream," he said. "I watched the last World Cup from

a classroom so being able to score here with my mum and my family in the stands is a dream come true."

The Barcelona winger is already considered one of the world's top players and helped Spain win the European

Championship in 2024 despite being just 16 years old when the tournament started. He is tipped to take over from Messi and Cristiano Ronaldo as the sport's biggest star but came into the World Cup with questions over his fitness after he missed the end of the season with a hamstring injury.

Yamal, who was only used as a second-half substitute against Cape Verde, was thrown in from the start against Saudi Arabia and wasted no time in making his presence felt. He had already repeatedly sliced through the Saudi defense before turning home Mikel Oyarzabal's cross.

A full house at Atlanta Stadium that was mainly filled with Spain fans erupted in celebration just at the sight of Yamal emerging for the pre-game warm up. And the cheers were even louder as he raced away to celebrate his goal, dropping to his knees, praying and kissing the turf.

(AP)

Gukesh must improve speed, technique: Sasikiran

SUMAN RAY ■ Chennai

World champion D Gukesh's penchant for creating complex positions often leaves him vulnerable to time trouble, according to Grandmaster Krishnan Sasikiran, who believes the Indian must improve his technique, speed and defensive accuracy ahead of his title defence against Uzbekistan's Javokhir Sindarov.

Gukesh is set to put his crown on the line against Sindarov, the winner of the 2026 Candidates Tournament, in the World Championship match provisionally scheduled from November 23 to December 17.

"Sometimes Gukesh takes too much risk by his unconventional play creating chaos and imbalance ... in a sense, he wants to let things go out of control, it does not matter if the position is completely in chaos," Sasikiran told PTI.

"He is a champion of that kind of a game but he often gets into time trouble. So, one thing I'd advise him to concentrate on is speeding up his calculation, he definitely needs to speed up, because you don't want to consistently find yourself in a scenario where your opponent is driving you into time trouble.

"To avoid time trouble, you have



to get your house in order. Preparation will continue right up until you enter the match. There will be a lot to memorize, that's undeniable, because some things simply cannot be played at that level without memory; memorizing things is necessary."

Gukesh has experienced a mixed run of form following his historic world title. He has struggled in classical events like the Grand Swiss, World Cup last year and the recent-

ly-concluded Norway Chess. Sasikiran, who served as a second to five-time winner Viswanathan Anand during his World Championship matches against Magnus Carlsen in 2013 and 2014, believes Gukesh must identify and exploit the pressure points in his opponent's game.

"My advice to him will be: the World Championship requires proper preparation. Cover a lot of areas and then make positions

that are a little uncomfortable for your opponent," said the Chennai-based Grandmaster.

"From what I have seen from Sindarov, all this candidate stuff, he is also making some complications, he had prepared very deeply for the Candidates tournament. I mean very high level of chess, so this world championship match is going to be very tough."

Sasikiran described Sindarov as a player who depends on

memory and speed. "Sindarov, I have seen, plays a solid set of openings and relies more on memory, specifically, speed; he plays very fast and relies more on his memory. He is having a slight bit of trouble when his opponent has a slightly better endgame," the 45-year-old Indian said.

By contrast, Sasikiran said Gukesh's technique in technical positions needed improvement.

"While Gukesh is known to let down a little bit in technical positions, technique is one area that definitely needs improvement. His technique has to be at a very high level, if he is to get an advantage from the opening, he needs to convert with very high accuracy.

"He cannot let this go... I think even in the Candidates, I saw that Gukesh missed some opportunities to convert technical positions, so that is one area he definitely has to work on," he noted.

Sasikiran, however, said Gukesh's experience of playing a world championship match could prove decisive. "But Gukesh has already been at that level, he has already played a world championship match, so match experience is in Gukesh's favour, but the challenger also carries momentum." (PTI)

Shahbaz steers Rarh Tigers to maiden Bengal T20 League title

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Kolkata

Shrachi Rarh Tigers out-classed Sobisco Smashers Malda by nine runs via DLS Method to clinch their maiden Bengal T20 League title. Skipper Shahbaz Ahmed led from the front with a brilliant unbeaten 88 off 46 balls, an innings studded with seven fours and six sixes, to guide his side to a memorable victory in a rain-interrupted match here on Sunday.

Put into bat after the match was reduced to 15 overs per side, Rarh Tigers recovered brilliantly from 10/3 to post a challenging 165/4.

Shahbaz anchored the innings with a captain's knock and was ably supported by Gaurav Singh Chauhan, who smashed 55 off 30 balls.

Chasing a revised target of 107 in 9 overs, Malda fought hard but fell short, scoring 97/5 in the allotted overs.



Abhimanyu Easwaran top-scored with a fine 38 off 22 balls. For Rarh Tigers, Sukhmeet Singh bagged two wickets, while Raju Halder and Rohit Kumar claimed one wicket each.

Three golfers of Indian origin secure top-20 finish at US Open

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Southampton

Sahith Theegala produced his best-ever finish at the US Open as three golfers of Indian origin ended inside the top-20 at Shinnecock Hills. Wyndham Clark held off a relentless final-round challenge to capture his second US Open title.

Theegala, and Akshay Bhatia had a memorable week. Theegala finished tied-11th at two-over-par after a closing 73, while Bhatia capped another impressive major performance with a final-round 70 to finish tied-17th. Aaron Rai, the reigning PGA Championship winner, shared the 11th place, rallying after a slow start to the week. This marked the first time



three players of Indian origin have finished inside the top-20 at the US Open.

At the top, Clark completed a remarkable wire-to-wire victory despite seeing his six-shot overnight lead shrink to a single stroke early in the final round.

Lakshya, Tanvi lead challenge at US Open Super 300

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Fullerton (USA)

Seasoned campaigner Lakshya Sen and rising star Tanvi Sharma will lead India's challenge at the US Open Super 300 badminton tournament beginning here on Tuesday.

India will have a sizeable presence across the singles draws, including former world championships silver-medallist Kidambi Srikanth and a seven-strong women's team.

World Number 14 and Paris Olympics semifinalist Sen has been seeded second and drawn to face Belgium's Julien Carraggi in the opening round. Placed in the opposite half of the draw is top seed and world No. 6 Chou Tien Chen of Chinese Taipei, who headlines the men's singles field.

Sen enjoys a 5-4 head-to-head record against Chou, having won their last two meetings, and could run into him if he goes all the way.



The Indian will be eager to bounce back after a disappointing first-round exit at the Indonesia Open earlier this

month. Former world championships silver-medallist Srikanth is the other seeded Indian in men's singles.

India need to improve field-goal conversion: Marijne after Nations Cup triumph

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Auckland

Indian women's hockey team chief coach Sjoerd Marijne has said his side must improve their field-goal conversion despite securing promotion back to the FIH Pro League by winning the Nations Cup. India on Sunday defeated hosts New Zealand 2-0 with goals from Navneet Kaur and Sunelita Toppo to win their second Nations Cup title and secure promotion to the Pro League.

"Of course, we are delighted to win our first tournament and final together," Marijne said after the match.



"It was crucial for us to learn how to win finals, especially after our recent heartbreak against England at the World Cup qualifier. The team improved with every match.



We relied on a very strong and well-organised defence."

"While we created enough

Serena to play singles at Wimbledon in comeback at 44

ANDREW DAMPF ■ London

It's been talked about ever since Serena Williams announced nearly three weeks ago that she was returning to professional tennis after almost four years away from the sport.

Still, seeing the single-sentence announcement from The All England Club that the 23-time Grand Slam champion will play singles at Wimbledon was stunning nonetheless. "Serena Williams (USA) receives the final ladies' singles wild card," read the key line in



Sunday's announcement, which was issued eight days before the grass-court Grand Slam begins.

At 44, Williams will actually play both singles and

doubles at Wimbledon after already accepting a wild card for the doubles competition with older sister Venus.

"This is not a drill,"

Wimbledon said on its social media accounts Sunday.

Commented the WTA Tour, "Name a more iconic return — we'll wait."

Wimbledon held open the eighth and final women's singles wild card spot until Williams made up her mind. As recently as earlier this week after losing a doubles match in Berlin, she appeared to be waffling over the decision. "Oh my gosh, there are some left!" she replied when she was told there was still a wild card spot open. (AP)

Wyndham Clark avoids record collapse and holds on to win US Open

DOUG FERGUSON ■ Southampton

Wyndham Clark couldn't remember being in a darker place. He was publicly reviled for a moment of petulance when he smashed a locker at Oakmont after missing the cut in the US Open last year. His game, his reputation, he felt it all was slipping away. Sunday at Shinnecock Hills wasn't much better. The New York crowd behind Scottie Scheffler in his bid for a career Grand Slam turned on Clark, cheering his misses and wishing for the worst.

That's what made this US Open title so much sweeter.

On the edge of the greatest collapse in US Open history, Clark held his nerve against a charge by Sam Burns and a Shinnecock Hills crowd that never gave him much love until he showed his mettle with his second US Open title in four years. "The first one was kind of just the breakthrough of knowing I can do it," Clark said after a two-putt par from 50 feet for a 3-over 73 and a one-shot victory. "And then this one was a lot of redemption. Last year was so tough, a terrible year. I left this place in shambles, and it's amazing what a year can do. I'm leaving here this Sunday as a champion, and I'm just so blessed." (AP)



India look to carry momentum against Pakistan in London leg of Pro League

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ London

A thrilling win against Olympic champions Netherlands boosting its confidence, the Indian men's hockey team would look to carry forward the momentum when it takes on arch-rivals Pakistan in the opening match of the London leg of the FIH Pro League here on Tuesday.

It will also be the first time that India and Pakistan will lock horns against each other since the Asian Champions Trophy clash in Hulunbuir, China, in 2024 which India won 2-1, thanks to captain Harmanpreet Singh's brace.

The head-to-head record between the two sides over the last 10 years is hugely in favour of



India, who remain undefeated across 17 matches, with 15 wins and two draws.

The Indians won two matches

out of four in Rotterdam. They beat hosts and world no.2 the Netherlands 3-2 on Sunday in the concluding match of the Rotterdam

leg. India's other victory (3-1) came against reigning world champions and world number 5 Germany.

In the other two matches, India lost 2-3 against the Netherlands and 1-2 against Germany, all close results.

The Dutch leg turned out to be a valuable experience for the Indians, who are using this tournament to fine tune their grey areas ahead of this year's two big ticket events — the FIH World Cup and the Asian Games, which is also an Olympic qualifier.

India are currently placed eighth in the nine-team Pro League standings, ahead of their next rival Pakistan, who are yet to log a point in the tournament.